

Hollow Bridge

6 days · Target Jedi: Kaelen Kivan · Tundra world with the frozen remains of a Clone Wars battle

Anatomy of a Catastrophe — a Star Wars fan series chronicling Qymaen jai Sheelal's evolution into General Grievous.

Day 1: White Silence



The debris field had a grammar, and Qymaen jai Sheelal had been reading it since before the gunship's hull came apart around him. Every soldier learned to hear it — the way dead metal spoke to live metal, the way a battle's leavings drifted in long slow rivers that a good pilot respected the way a riverman respected current. The pilot of their dropship had respected it. She had threaded three rivers of wreckage on the descent, chattering the whole way down about her brother's wedding, and then the fourth river had turned. Not drifted. Turned — a slab of hull plating the size of a barn door rolling against its own momentum, a frigate's engine cone shifting its tumble to cross their lane like a man stepping sideways into a doorway to wait for someone. The pilot saw it. Everyone saw it. There had been half a second where it could have been avoided, and in that half second it had not been avoided, and then the world was noise and cold and the smell of burning insulation.

He woke in the wreck's belly, upside down, one boot still buckled into the harness and the other leg folded under him at an angle his knee would be invoicing him for later. Emergency lighting strobed red. Somewhere forward, the pilot's chatter had become a thin sustained note that stopped while he listened to it, and he made himself listen until it stopped completely, because a man deserved at least that — to have someone hear the moment of it. Then he went to work. Panic was a luxury that cost ammunition. He unbuckled, dropped, took inventory of himself the way his mother had taught him to take inventory of a larder after a bad winter: without sentiment, without hope, without pausing on any loss longer than it took to write it down. Blood in the left boot — his, ankle, walking-grade injury. Ribs on the right side, bruised not cracked, or cracked in a way that would forgive walking. Head ringing but empty of anything worse. Alive, then. Alive was a debt he would have to repay to somebody, sooner or later, and debts of that kind always came due with interest.

The tundra outside was white to the edge of the world and then grey to the edge of that, and the wind moved across it in long flat strokes like a whetstone across a blade that never got sharper.

Jagraia. He had read the briefing twice on the flight in and had not believed a word of it, the way you do not believe a description of the ocean until the water is in your boots. A Clone Wars fleet action, twenty years drowned. Two hundred ships down, Separatist and Republic both, their carcasses strewn across a hundred kilometers of ice where the local glaciers had taken them in like a slow patient animal swallowing bones. The locals did not come here. The scavengers came here, in armored caravans, and even the scavengers came armed and left early. And somewhere out in all that white, in the black tooth of a crashed dreadnought's command tower rising from the glacier, a Jedi Consular named Kaelen Kivan was walking toward something he wanted more than he wanted to keep being exactly what he was.

Qymaen dug the rifle out of the wreckage first, then the knife, then the pack, and laid them in a row on the ice and looked at them the way a gambler looks at a poor hand. Rifle: thirty-one rounds, and no resupply on a world without a friendly port. Knife: good steel, his father's pattern, the edge he kept it at. Pack: three days of rations, two of them already ruined by fuel spill; water for a day if he was disciplined, which he was; no tent, because the plan had been a ship and a ship was now a trench of smoking alloy behind him; no comms, because the set had been at his shoulder when the river of debris turned and it was a fist-sized lump of slag now, fused to a scrap of harness strap that he cut away and left in the snow. Forty kilometers, the briefing had said, from the designated landing zone to the dreadnought. The landing zone was now a concept rather than a place. The distance had not changed. He shouldered the pack and began to walk, and the wind took the sound of his first ten steps and gave nothing back.

He had gone perhaps three kilometers, following the debris shadow of a fallen cruiser's spine for what wind-shelter it offered, when he stopped walking without deciding to. Something was wrong with the snow ahead, and it took him a moment of standing absolutely still, breath shallow, eyes narrowed against the glare, to name what it was. The debris shadow ended in a drift, and the drift was perfect — too perfect, its face unmarked by the spalling of ice crumbs that the wind had been throwing at everything else all morning. And in the middle of that unmarked face, a single line of boot prints. One set. Long stride, even gait, toes pointed precisely where they were going. The prints came out of the debris field from the direction of the dreadnought — from ahead of him — and walked back into it. Hours old, by the wind-softening at their edges. Someone had come out here, through the killing rivers of dead metal, and stood where his ship now burned, and walked calmly home.

He circled the drift the way he would circle a snare, downwind, rifle up, and read the ground with his jaw tight. The prints never ran. They never hesitated. Where the debris shadow narrowed they stepped precisely through its centerline, the one safe channel, the line a man could only find with a survey chart or with something better than a chart. And at the drift's edge, where the walker had stood to watch the gunship die, the snow was compressed in two small ovals, side by side, patient as a man waiting for a ferry. Qymaen stood over them for a long time while the wind tried to make him squint. A Jedi did not need to stand close. A Jedi could watch a ship come apart from two kilometers and feel it happen in his blood. So the ovals were not a sniper's rest and they were not curiosity. They were a courtesy — the posture of a man who attends a funeral because the dead deserved one mourner, even a stranger. He did not know what to do with that arithmetic, so he filed it, unbalanced, in the ledger behind his eyes, and turned north, and followed the prints.

The acid rain caught him at dusk, two hours short of the walker carcass he had marked on the chart in his head. He had smelled it coming before he saw it — a sharp metallic tang riding ahead of the front like a herald with bad news — and he was already moving for the carcass when the first drops began to hiss. It was an old AT-TE, one of the Republic six-legged walkers, down on its face with its guns folded under it like a dead animal's legs, and twenty years of wind had packed its hull with snow until it was less a machine than a cave with a silhouette. Qymaen went up into the crew compartment through the torn belly, found a dry corner behind the frozen gunner's station, and settled in to watch the weather try to eat the world. The rain came down in grey sheets and where it struck exposed metal the metal wept and smoked. Where it struck snow, the snow pitted like flesh. He watched it eat the paint off the wreck of a droid tri-fighter half-buried nearby, and he thought, with a professional's detachment, that this world did not bury its dead so much as dissolve them slowly and keep the bones as an afterthought.

The scavenger camp surprised him an hour into the rain, because he had glasses on it before he had smell on it, and the smell should have come first. Six shelters of quilted armor-cloth, huddled in the lee of a fallen coreship segment, lamp-light leaking orange at the seams. Too few guards on the perimeter, and the guards were wrong — facing outward toward the empty plain, backs to the wreck they were picking, as if the danger here lived outside rather than in. He watched through the rain for two hours, cataloguing, and the camp did nothing but leak light and smoke badly, and the wrongness of it grew in him like a toothache. Then, between one lightning-stutter of the storm and the next, every lamp in the camp went out at once. Not failed. Went out — all six, together, the way a room goes quiet when the conversation turns to you.

He should have treated it as a trap and gone around. He knew that even then, and he went in anyway, because six shelters of dead lamps in acid rain meant dying people, and dying people could talk. He crossed the two hundred meters low and fast during the heaviest sheets of rain, came over the coreship segment's torn edge, and dropped into the camp's middle with the rifle already covering the nearest shelter flap. Nothing shot at him. Nothing moved. The first shelter he cut open held a stove burning low and a man lying beside it who was already past answering, his lips and fingertips the grey-white of frostbite's last argument, a scavenger's quilted suit burned through across the chest in a pattern Qymaen did not like — a single line, precise, cauterized, the mark of a blade that had been drawn to warn and not to kill, drawn by a hand so controlled that even its mercy looked like surgery. The second shelter held two more, frozen past speech, curled toward a lamp that had gone dark. The third held the one who could still talk, a woman, old by the voice if not by the face, propped against her pack with a blaster in her lap that she had neither the strength to raise nor the sense to put down, and her eyes when they found him in the dark went wide — tusks, they always saw the tusks first — and then, absurdly, relieved.

"Kaleesh." She said it like a word from a story she had half-remembered wrong. "Good. The tall one said — he said the ice would send someone." She coughed, and the cough had blood in it, and he crouched across from her and did not touch the blaster and waited, because dying people spent their breath the way misers spent coin and it was theft to hurry them. Outside, the rain hissed on. "The tall one," she said again. "Robes. Came out of the storm three days ago like he was out for a walk. Asked about the deep ice. Asked — " cough — "asked which graves the glaciers kept. Not the wrecks. The graves. Paid for answers with answers, like a fool, like a — like a man who has never been robbed. Told him about the singing. You know about the singing?"

"I do not," Qymaen said, which was true, and which was already a lie by the time it left his mouth, because he had heard something singing under the ice all day, at the very floor of his hearing, and had been telling himself it was the wind in the wreckage.

"The ice sings, out by the black tower. Old men say it's the dead fleet talking. He liked that. Wrote it down." Her hand crawled across the frozen ground to a case half under her body, and Qymaen, understanding, opened it for her. Charts. Depth soundings of the glacier around the dreadnought, rendered in a careful, disciplined hand that was not hers — Jedi script, he had seen it once in a captured holocron's margins, each numeral drawn like it was being graded. And in the corner of the topmost chart, a note in the same hand: THE BRIDGE IS HOLLOW. WALK IT CAREFULLY. He photographed it in his memory, the way his mother had taught him, and laid the case back under her hands. "He asked who else knew the way in," she whispered. "We told him no one. He said, good, and then he looked at me — " the blood-cough again, longer — "and he said, you're lying, and then he touched my forehead and I couldn't — the lamps went — "

The wind changed. He heard it change, a low shift in the storm's voice, and the woman heard it too, and her eyes went past his shoulder toward the flap of the shelter, and whatever she saw there, she did not finish. The blaster slid from her lap into the snow. Qymaen turned. The shelter flap hung open on blackness, on rain, on the plain, and nothing was there — but every lamp on the plain, in every dead shelter, in the wreck of the coeship segment a hundred meters off, had begun at that moment to glow. Not electric light. A pale, cold, blue-white shine out of the ice itself, rising through the ground like heat-shimmer inverted, and under his boots, through the soles, through the bones of his feet, he felt the singing come up out of the floor of the world, and for one full second it was beautiful, and then it was not, and then it was gone — lamps, singing, all of it — and the plain was black and silent and the rain came down on six dead camps and one living man.

He searched the camp by feel and by the rifle-light, fast and thorough, and he took the charts, because the dead had no further use for them and the dead had tried, in her way, to give them to him. He gave each of them what he could — the names off their tags, spoken properly, the words his people owed their own — and he burned what could be burned, because this world dissolved its dead and he refused to make it easy. Then he stood at the camp's edge in the dying rain and looked north, toward the black tooth on the horizon, where a tall man in robes was walking into the deep ice asking after graves, and Qymaen understood, with the cold settling into him like a tenant, that he was not following a Jedi anymore. He was following the thing the Jedi was following. And the thing knew he was coming, and had turned the lamps on to say so.

He walked the rest of that night because stopping meant dreaming and he was not ready to be alone in his own head on this world. The plain rose by degrees toward the glacier's shoulder, and the debris grew denser underfoot — a frigate's keel here, a droid control sphere there, all of it scoured white, all of it rusting upward through the snow in orange scabs where the acid rain had been feeding. Toward dawn the singing came back. He had been hearing it at the floor of his hearing for hours, telling himself wind, telling himself wreck-metal settling, and then the eastern sky went the grey of old scars and the singing stepped up, gently, like a musician tuning, and resolved for three full seconds into a melody. A woman's voice, humming. A tune he had not heard in twenty years and had never once forgotten, because it was the tune Ronderu lij Kummar used to hum while she sharpened her twin swords on the shore at Keliara, and she was twenty years dead, and she had

never once in her life been to this world.

Qymaen stood very still on the frozen plain with the rifle in his hands and let the fear come all the way in, because his mother had taught him that too: fear was information; it was only a liar when you refused to count it. The humming faded under the wind. He checked the rifle's action with numb fingers, set the safety, and walked on toward the black tower, and behind him, for a moment before the wind erased it, his footprints in the fresh snow lay in the snow smoothed and blank, as if a patient hand had already begun to tidy the record of his passing — and ahead of him, at the glacier's edge, small and upright and unhurried in the first grey light, a tall figure in robes stood waiting at the door in the ice, and inclined his head, exactly the depth of inclination one stranger owes another, and went in.

The door in the ice was a wound, and it had been made carefully. Qymaen crouched at its threshold in the grey dawn light and read the cut edges the way other men read letters from home. Lightsaber work — he had seen the marks twice before, once on a wrecked Jedi interceptor and once through a spy-glass at a distance that let him survive his curiosity. But these cuts were old, days old, weathered already at the melt-line, and they had been made in stages: a survey cut first, small, almost apologetic, then a widening, then the final clean rectangle that stood open now, breathing cold air out of the mountain's interior at the steady rhythm of a sleeping animal. The Jedi had come, looked, left, come back, and opened the ship. Nothing about that sequence resembled a hunt. It resembled a man visiting a house he was considering buying.

The air that breathed out of the wreck smelled of cold iron and something under the cold iron — old air, ship's air, twenty years dead and still faintly, stubbornly itself: lubricant, cooked insulation, and the sweet ghost of the nutrient paste the crew of a warship lives on. He had grown up on a world that smelled of rain and blood and woodsmoke, and the smell of a dead ship was as foreign to him as the smell of a temple, and it affected him the same way it seemed to affect the locals: it made the hair on his arms rise and his voice want to drop to a whisper. He did not whisper. He spoke his first words inside the wreck out loud, in his own tongue, because his mother had taught him that a hunter announces himself to a new ground the way a guest announces himself to a new fire — not for the ground's sake, but for his own. "I come armed," he said to the darkness. "I come for the man ahead of me. I take nothing that is not mine." The darkness did not answer, but the cold air stopped breathing for a moment, the way a listener holds his breath, and then resumed.

The main corridor ran aft into the dark, and the dark was furnished. That was the wrongness of it — he had expected a ruin, a cave of collapsed plating and drifted snow, and instead the wreck had kept its shape the way a body keeps its shape in deep cold. Blast doors stood open or shut exactly as their last order had left them. A droid skittered once in a side passage — a repair skitter, small and faithful and mad with twenty years of an empty task list — and he let it live because it was doing no harm and killing it felt like kicking a dog that had guarded a grave. And everywhere, at every workstation, at every duty station along the corridor, the dead stood frozen at their posts. Not scattered, not tumbled, not the way violence leaves people. Arranged. A gunnery officer stood with his hands on his console's rails, head bowed, as if in the last instant he had chosen to look at his readouts rather than the thing coming for the ship. Two ratings knelt at a junction box, one holding, one splicing, their work unfinished and their fingers frost-fused to it. A mess boy of an alien species Qymaen did not know stood in a galley doorway with a tray held level, and the tray still held four

cups, and the cups still held their tea, frozen brown, and twenty years had not spilled a drop.

He walked the centerline of the corridor and did not look at their eyes, because he had looked at one pair — the gunnery officer's, in passing, before he understood what he was doing — and the eyes were open, and clear, and preserved so perfectly that they still held the expression they had died wearing, and the expression was not fear. It was attention. Every face he passed without looking at, he could feel looking at him anyway, the way you feel a portrait's eyes, and the feeling did not fade with distance down the corridor; it accumulated. By the third junction his neck ached with the effort of not turning around, and he understood at last why the feeling did not fade, and he stopped in the middle of the corridor, and he turned around. The corridor behind him was empty. The dead stood at their stations, heads bowed or eyes forward, exactly as he had passed them. And every head, every single preserved face in the long grey throat of that corridor, had turned — without moving, without a sound, the way a compass needle turns, between one blink and the next — to face the direction he was walking. Toward the deep decks. Toward whatever waited below that a whole dead crew had died watching.

He did not run. Running in a grave was theft from his own dignity and he had promised the darkness he would take nothing that was not his. But he walked faster, and the cold air breathed around him, and somewhere far below, past the depth of the ship's own engine noise, past what any wreck could make, something turned over in its sleep and the whole hull ticked and settled around him like a house in a storm. He counted the sound. His mother had taught him that too — when the world speaks nonsense, count it; nonsense that keeps a rhythm is not nonsense. Tick. Settle. Tick. Settle. A rhythm of about eleven seconds, steady as a drum, and it took him another hundred meters of corridor to name what the rhythm resembled, and when he named it he wished he had not: it was the rhythm of breathing. Slow, vast, contented. The ship was not ticking. The ship, or the thing in the ship, was sleeping, and his footsteps on the deck plates were the only part of the dream that moved.

The wardroom found him rather than the reverse. He had been following the deep-route — the one the dead faces watched, the one the repair droid's track-marks in the dust had favored, the one the herding pattern of open and shut blast doors had been stroking him along since the airlock — and the route delivered him through an officers' country where the preservation grew stranger. Here the dead had been at leisure when the end came, and leisure had preserved them in attitudes that hurt to look at: a commander asleep in his bunk with a data-pad on his chest; a young lieutenant, alien, golden-eyed, seated on the deck with her back to a bulkhead and her hands folded, composed, waiting, her face turned toward the door as if she had heard the order coming down the passageway and had decided to receive it sitting up. And at the center of it, the wardroom: a long table, and the table was set. Plates for six. Cups for six. And one chair — the seventh, at the table's head — turned away from the table to face the bulkhead, and in the chair no one, and before the bulkhead, at the height of a seated man's eyes, words cut into the metal. Not scratched. Cut — clean, deep, surgical, by a blade of light. Basic, in a disciplined hand whose Kalleran spelling habits showed in the long vowels:

THE BRIDGE IS HOLLOW. WALK IT CAREFULLY.

Qymaen stood in the wardroom doorway for a long time, reading the sentence, then reading the room, then reading the sentence again, because the two of them refused to agree. A warning, cut into

a dead ship's wall by the man he was hunting — but cut how long ago? The melt-line on the corridor cuts at the airlock said days. This cut had no melt-line at all. The metal around it was frost-free, dry, polished faintly at the edges as if the air itself had been handling it. And under the words, smaller, in the same hand, added in a different mood — the strokes hurried, the discipline cracking — a second line: SHE ASKS FOR A SEAT. DO NOT SIT DOWN.

He looked at the seventh chair. The chair looked at him, in the way that furniture does not, and he crossed the wardroom with his skin crawling and stood before the bulkhead and put his hand flat on the metal beside the warning, because there was one more question and the wall was the only witness. The metal was warm. Not ship-warm, not engine-warm — skin-warm. The temperature of a living palm. And as he stood there with his hand on the warm metal, the breathing-rhythm of the ship, the great eleven-second tide of it, skipped — one beat, like a heart that has seen something it recognizes — and in the skip, for less than a heartbeat, he heard, at the very floor of his hearing, in a woman's voice he had not heard in twenty years, a single word in his own tongue.

Brother.

The word was not Ronderu's. He knew that with the whole flat certainty of his body, the way you know a forged blade from the balance of it in your hand — the voice had her warmth, her roughness, the Keliara wind in it, but it did not have *her* in it; it was a portrait of a voice, painted by someone who had studied her from a great distance and gotten the love wrong. And it had not said *brother* the way she had said it, which was a weapon and a joke at once, a word she used when she wanted him to lower his guard so she could beat him at something. This word was bait on a hook, and the hook was his own grief, and the thing that had tied the fly did not understand grief at all; it understood only that grief was the shape of the hole in him, and holes were doors.

He took his hand off the wall. He did not sit in the seventh chair. He stood in the doorway of the dead ship's wardroom and spoke aloud, in Basic, so there could be no mistake of language, his voice flat in the frozen air: "She is dead. You may not use her." The ship's breathing skipped again — and this time the skip had a texture he could name, because he had heard it before, on a hunt, from a snared thing that had watched him examine its leg-hold: the sound of a mind revising its estimate of him. Then the rhythm resumed, and the warmth went out of the bulkhead under his palm degree by degree, like a hand being withdrawn, and the frost came back across the warning words one crystal at a time, politely, the way a host relights the lamps after a guest has gone.

He took the corridor at a hunter's pace after that, and the herding grew bolder, as if his refusal had settled some question in the ship's favor. Blast doors began to move while he watched them — slow, grinding, patient, closing across side passages a heartbeat after his eyes found them, sealing the wreck around the deep-route like a fist closing around a coin. And in the dust of the deep-route's floor, the traffic of his passage became legible: his own boots, and ahead of them, days old, the tall man's prints, and interleaved with both, everywhere, in the doorways and at the junctions, the drag-and-scuff marks of things that had no feet being moved out of the deep-route's way. The ship was not herding him to his death. He understood it finally, standing in a corridor of turned faces and closing doors, and the understanding was worse than death would have been. The ship was herding him along. It was tidying his path. It was a good host, and he was the guest of honor, and the seventh chair was still waiting somewhere below, and the thing that slept in the engine dark had liked what he said about Ronderu — had liked it the way a collector likes to hear that a piece he

wants is authentic.

Night came to the inside of the wreck the way night comes to a cave — not falling, seeping, filling the corridors from their ends inward until the dark was a substance he moved through rather than an absence he moved in. His body wanted sleep and had begun presenting its bill: hands slow on the rifle's action, a stutter in his depth perception at thresholds, the right knee filing complaint after complaint about the morning's crash. He found what he needed in a maintenance alcove off the deep-route — a recessed niche behind a conduit trunk, defensible, one approach, high enough off the deck that the cold would not pool in it — and he built his camp with the economy of long habit. No fire, because there was nothing to burn and no venting and he did not propose to asphyxiate himself in a dead ship after surviving the sky. Rations, cold water, a strip of stim-patch across each wrist that he immediately regretted, because stims on a world with singing ice were a loan against dreams he would have to repay with interest.

He slept anyway. The body wins those arguments; it always has. And the dream took him the way it used to take him on Keliara's shore in the first years, before grief wore a channel in him smooth enough that she could walk it without waking him.

Salt wind. The sound of surf doing its endless arithmetic against black rock. A grey sky with the light coming through it sideways, the way it did at the end of the dry season, and Ronderu lij Kummar standing hip-shot at the tideline with her twin swords bare across her forearms, correcting his grip for the tenth time that morning. **Again,** she said, in the dream's perfect rendering of her voice, roughened by salt and laughter. **You swing like you're chopping wood. She isn't wood. Nothing that matters is wood.** And he swung again, and she laughed at him, and the laugh was exact — every grain of it, the break in the middle where her ribs had been cracked by a Huk maul two seasons before and had healed proud, the upward flick at the end that meant **good, now do it better**. Twenty years of forgetting had not been able to touch any of it. That was the cruelty of dreams: they kept what waking could not afford to hold.

They fought the forms on the hard sand while the tide counted. She beat him twice, drew blood once — a red line down his forearm that stung like truth — and he was happy. That was the thing he never let himself remember awake, and the dream knew it, and gave it back whole: he had been **happy**, in the plain animal way of a young man matched against his equal, and the happiness had no floor under it because he had not yet learned that everything he loved would be invoiced later. She called a halt with the sun going the color of an old coin, and sat him down on a beached hull-rib, and shared out the last of the water in cupped hands the way soldiers share, half and half with the dregs poured on the sand for the dead. And then, in the dream, she said the thing she had never said.

"I'm under Jagraia," she said. "Come dig."

The shore stayed exactly as it was. The wind did not change, the surf did not falter, her face did not alter — and none of that mattered, because the cadence was wrong. He heard it the way a musician hears a false note in a familiar song: same pitch, same roughness, but placed wrong, arriving a half-beat early, riding over her breathing instead of out of it. The dream-Ronderu went on smiling at him from the tideline and the thing that was speaking through her went on speaking. "The tall man is carrying me home, brother. He found your grave-chart. You shoot at messengers. You have spent twenty years shooting at shadows instead of burying your dead." And the surf behind her, all of it,

every wave of it, broke in unison, once, like applause, or like a door being tested on its hinges.

Qymaen woke with frost on his eyelashes.

Not rime — frost. Delicate, crystalline, arranged in spirals across both lids and the bridge of his nose, tiny perfect whorls of it, the kind of pattern water makes only when something asks it very politely to make something else. He peeled them off his lashes with thumb and forefinger and looked at them in the rifle-light, and they did not melt. They should have melted. His skin was alive, the alcove was above freezing, and the little spirals sat in his palm like grains of strange sand, patient, unmelting, until he tipped them into the dark between the conduit trunks and heard them land with no sound at all.

He cleared the alcove in ninety seconds and went back to the deep-route with sleep abandoned as a bad position, and forty meters along he found the tally. It was cut into the wall beside a junction hatch, low, at the height of a walking man's trailing hand — five strokes, four upright and one crossing, the oldest way of counting there is, the way you count things you are keeping rather than things you owe. Fresh. The metal at the cuts still bright. And his first thought was the Jedi, marking days of descent, and his second thought arrived a moment later wearing boots of ice water: the Jedi had come this way days ago, and had descended already past counting, and these marks were new since the melt-line survey Qymaen had read at the airlock that morning. New since dawn. Cut while he slept, forty meters from where he slept, by something whose idea of counting matched his own situation exactly — five strokes, and this was the fifth day since the seed-tables on some other world had spat out his name and this name and bound them together.

He put his hand flat on the tally and the metal was cold, properly cold, dead-metal cold, and that was somehow the worst detail of the night: whatever had cut it had needed no warmth to work, and had chosen, out of everything it might mark on this wall, the oldest human grammar of keeping-track. Not Jedi script. Not Basic sentences. Tally-marks, at hand height, the writing of a keeper of herds and graves. Something down in the deep decks was keeping score of him, and it had decided he was worth scoring, and it counted in the language of his own grandmother's ledger-knots.

The deep-route bent west and began, gently, to descend, and the ship changed around him the way weather changes over open water. The preservation thickened. The dead grew denser at their stations until passing them required brushing sleeves with them, and the frost on their faces had begun, here, to carry the spiral patterns he had woken wearing, faint whorls across preserved cheeks like fingerprints left by a careful owner. And through it all ran the breathing — steady, eleven seconds, vast — except that now, at each exhalation, the singing under the hull came up with it a fraction louder, and the melody it was tuning toward was no longer hiding. It hummed the tune she used to hum. It got the middle wrong. Every time, it got the middle wrong, the same wrong note, patiently, the way a student practices an error, and Qymaen walked down through the frozen dark of a dead dreadnought with his tusks bared and his breath smoking and corrected it, under his breath, in time, note for note, because if the thing below was going to wear her voice then at least it would wear it **accurately**, and the rage of that — the sheer, clean, focused rage of insisting on accuracy from the thing that was stealing her — carried him down three more decks before he understood what he had just done. He had sung along. In the dark. With it. And somewhere far below, the breathing skipped with something that was unmistakably, horribly, delight.

Dawn, when he judged it by the thin seep of grey light through a shattered observation port two decks up, found him at the edge of a place where the ship stopped being a ship. The deep-route opened without warning into a vertical gallery — a maintenance shaft three hundred meters deep, ringed with catwalk galleries that spiraled down into darkness like the inside of a shell, and at the bottom of it, far below his boots, something glowed. Not engine-light. The color was wrong for plasma, wrong for fire: a blue so pale it read as white, steady as a held breath, and looking at it was like looking at the memory of light rather than light itself. His eyes watered and slid off it. When he forced them back, the glow seemed to have moved closer without changing size, which was a trick no honest thing could do, and he stopped looking at it, and made himself look instead at the architecture, because architecture told the truth.

The shaft's galleries were not maintenance galleries. He had grown up in the war-remnants of two fleets; he knew what utilitarian looked like, and this was not it. The spiral rails had been cast in whorled patterns that repeated, deck after deck after deck, the same double-spiral motif he had woken wearing on his eyelashes. The deck plating was laid in concentric rings around the central dark. And every railing, every ring, every whorl of cast metal pointed inward, down, toward the glow — the way iron filings point along field lines, the way the whole ship's dead crew had turned their faces. This shaft was not built to move repair crews. It had been re-built — and the word arrived in his mind with the certainty of a trap closing — **re-shaped**, over years, by degrees, by hands that wanted the geometry of the wreck to become a lens. Everything in this ship focused on whatever burned cold at the bottom. Including, if the herding held its pattern, him.

The tally-marks followed him down. At each gallery junction now, low at hand height, fresh-cut in bright metal: four strokes, then five, then — as the shaft wound deeper and his own count of hours lost all footing — six. He stopped correcting his mental arithmetic against them. Counting was their game; his mother had taught him better games.

He heard Kivan before he saw him, which should have been impossible, because Jedi did not make noise. But the sound was not the Jedi moving — it was the Jedi working. A rhythmic, patient scrape-and-chime drifting up the shaft's spiral from three galleries below, metal being persuaded by light, and Qymaen went down along the inner rail with his boots finding the silent seams of the deck plates and his breath shallow, and looked down through the railing whorls into the gallery below.

Kaelen Kivan sat cross-legged on the deck of a vault antechamber, saber hilt bare in one hand, unlit, and he was cutting nothing. The sound Qymaen had taken for work was the man breathing. Slow, metronomic, deliberate — eleven seconds to the cycle — and as Qymaen watched, understanding arriving like cold water rising past his collar, the Kalleran's lips moved with each exhale, counting something, keeping something, and the frost on the walls of the gallery below pulsed faintly with each cycle, in time. In rhythm. The Jedi was not resting near the ship's breathing. The Jedi was **breathing with** it — matching it, holding it, a swimmer pacing a riptide to learn its schedule. And on the deck beside him, arranged with a curator's care, lay the tools of a different kind of hunt than Qymaen's: depth charts annotated in that disciplined script, a coil of braided cable, a physician's kit, and a journal bound in grey hide, open, weighted flat by a lightsaber hilt that was not the one in his hand.

Qymaen settled the rifle across the railing whorl and put the tall man's chest in the notch of the sight, and the world went quiet the way it always did, the wind dying, the ship's breathing fading to

the tick of his own pulse against the stock. Thirty-one rounds in the rifle and one shot at the man who had walked out of the storm and asked the dying where the graves were kept. Range: forty meters, straight line, no wind indoors. He breathed out. He began the squeeze —

— and the gallery below said, conversationally, without looking up: "Your safety is still engaged."

The squeeze stopped. The world resumed. Kivan remained seated, eyes on his own folded hands, voice pitched precisely for the distance between them, neither raised nor lowered, the tone of a librarian correcting a date. "You checked the action on the surface at first light. You did not check the safety since. Your people check the blade before the sheath; I have read the ethnographies. I would prefer you not shoot me by accident. The outcomes where you shoot me by accident are poor ones." A pause, exactly long enough to be chosen. "The outcomes where you shoot me deliberately are also poor, but less embarrassing for you."

Qymaen looked at the safety lever. It was engaged. He had racked and fired weapons in rain, in dark, upside down in wreckage, since he was nine years old, and his hands did not forget safeties; his hands had never once in his life forgotten a safety. He disengaged it, slowly, holding the tall man's center mass in the sight the entire time, and Kivan waited with the patience of a man watching weather he has already forecast.

"You came out of your way to be shot," Qymaen said.

"I came to this gallery because the ship permits only this gallery tonight, and I would rather speak to you before it decides our routes for us." Kivan unfolded from the deck — the movement precise, economical, a machine built of joints rather than habits — and stood facing the rail, face upturned, and this close there was no missing what the hunt had been keeping from Qymaen's sight-lines: the man was tired in a way that had passed through exhaustion and come out the other side into something architectural. Shadows under the eyes like chiseled grooves. Hands steady the way a cracked bell can be steady. "You slept in conduit alcove twelve-C. You woke at the third hour with spiral frost on your face. You refused the vision it offered and named the vision a lie aloud, in Basic, to its face." A beat. "It has been twenty years since anyone refused it anything. It finds you interesting. That is not a compliment. Nothing it finds interesting has ever come home."

"Where is she buried?" The question came out of Qymaen rawer than he had sent it, and he hated the crack in it, and let it stand, because lying about it would cost more. "The grave your charts ask after. Say her name is not part of your arithmetic."

For the first time the Jedi looked away, out through the vault antechamber's sealed door, into whatever his calculations showed him. "That," he said quietly, "is precisely the question I am here to answer. And the answer is not mine to give you. It is the relic's to trade, or the ice's to keep." He picked up the grey-hide journal and weighed it in his hand, an accountant weighing a ledger that has begun writing its own entries. "Sleep if you can, hunter. Six hours behind us, the route forks, and the fork is why I needed you to hear my voice before you heard it offer you things in hers."

He turned down the spiral, unhurried, unarmed, leaving his camp standing, and the frost dimmed politely along the walls to light his way down, and Qymaen knelt at the rail with the rifle's nose drifting after the tall grey figure, shot after clean shot declined by his own finger, and could not have said, if a war-leader demanded it of him, whether he was guarding the Jedi, hunting him, or being walked — leash taut, muzzle level — by the thing that breathed underneath them both.

The fork Kivan had promised opened six hours later, and it was not a fork; it was a throat. The deep-route split at a blast junction into two galleries of equal grade, and the ship had decorated its preference. The left-hand gallery stood open, frost dimmed welcomingly along its walls, air moving through it in that slow breathing tide, and the tally-marks beside its mouth read seven strokes with the eighth half-cut, inviting completion. The right-hand gallery was shut — not merely doored but sealed, welded from within by some convulsion of the wreck's death, plate over plate fused into a wall of frozen metal, and across the weld-scar, in lightsaber-cut Basic three days weathered: WRONG WAY. And beneath it, smaller, added later in scratched hand-lettering that was not the Jedi's discipline — hurried, human, afraid: IT SAYS THE LEFT ONE IS SHORTER. IT LIES ABOUT DISTANCE.

Qymaen stood at the junction for a long time, reading both mouths of the trap, while behind him, far up the spiral shaft, something heavy began without hurry to move.

He took the right gallery. Not because he trusted the scratched warning over the Jedi's charts — though he did — but because his mother had settled this class of question when he was six years old, on a morning when two game trails left a water hole and she had asked him which one he would follow and he had chosen the open one, and she had said: **the trail an animal is offered is the trail an animal is caught on. Always ask who cut the grass back.** He put his knife under the first weld-seam and began to open the sealed gallery the hard way, cutting cold metal with cold steel, and the breathing of the ship changed around him — not faster, not louder, but **interested**, the eleven-second cycle developing a catch on the exhale like a host watching a guest use the wrong fork with total confidence.

The welds were old and brittle and his blade found the seams, and behind him, up the shaft, the heavy thing stopped moving, considered, and started again — toward the junction, unhurried, patient as debt. He gave the last seam a full-body pull and the welded plate came away with a shriek of tearing metal that rang down the sealed gallery like a struck bell, and cold dead air breathed out of the darkness beyond, twenty years stale and utterly still, and Qymaen looked into a corridor no living thing had entered since the ship died — and understood, from the single detail the dark held waiting for him, what kind of house he had forced his way into.

Footprints. In the deck dust of the never-entered corridor: footprints, fresh, hours old at most, leading out of the deep dark **toward** the junction. His own size or larger. Even-gaited. Unhurried. They passed within a meter of where he crouched at the torn weld — so close he could have touched the print of a heel — and they went up the spiral shaft after the sound of the moving thing, and where they ended, mid-stride, in the open floor of the junction gallery, the dust lay smooth and undisturbed, as if their owner had simply stopped existing between one step and the next.

Qymaen went into the sealed gallery anyway, because the other door now had the heavy thing coming down it, and he did not look back at the place where the footprints stopped. Some arithmetic you decline to perform. He sealed the torn plate behind him with cable and pitons from the scavengers' kit he had taken off the plain — a gesture, nothing more, the plate would hold thirty seconds against anything that truly wanted through — and he went down into the untouched dark with the rifle-light playing over surfaces that should have been thick with two decades of dust and were instead merely **faintly** dusty, lightly used, tidied. A maintained ruin. A kept house. Doors along the gallery stood open at comfortable angles. A crew station's chair had been swiveled to face

the aisle, as if someone had gotten up moments ago and would be right back. And everywhere, low at hand height, in bright fresh cuts: tally-marks. Eight strokes. Nine. Ten. Counting him down the forbidden corridor like a ferryman counting passengers onto a boat whose capacity he has already checked.

The gallery ended at the vault antechamber where Kivan had sat breathing with the ship, and the antechamber ended at the vault door itself, and Qymaen stopped three meters short of it because every hair on his body had risen independently and voted.

The door was black metal, tall as two men, and it was carved — not decorated, **carved**, edge to edge, inside and out, with the double-spiral motif rendered at monumental scale, whorl inside whorl inside whorl, a geometry that his eye kept trying to follow inward and kept failing, sliding off the curves the way his gaze had slid off the glow at the shaft's bottom. And the door was warm. He felt it on his face from three meters away — skin-warm, palm-warm, the exact treacherous temperature of the wardroom bulkhead — and against the silence of the kept house all around it, faintly, from behind the warm black metal, came a sound he knew better than he had ever wanted to know anything.

Someone humming. The tune she used to hum. Note-perfect now. The middle corrected.

His own correction, sung in the dark three nights' walk ago, hung in the memory of his ears like smoke, and the door hummed her tune with his amendment in it, patiently, gratefully, the way a student performs the master's fingering, and Qymaen jai Sheelal stood alone in the vault antechamber of a dead ship with the rifle light shaking very slightly at the edges of its beam, and made himself say the true thing aloud, in his own tongue, because his mother had taught him that too: name the position before you move from it.

"It doesn't want to keep me out," he said to the warm dark. "It wants me to knock."

And the humming stopped. The whole ship stopped with it — the breathing, the tick, the vast contented rhythm, everything, all at once, the way a forest goes silent when the hunter crosses the scent-line — and in the ringing absolute quiet, at the height of a kneeling man's heart, in fresh bright metal, a new mark appeared on the black door's face between two turns of the carved spiral. One stroke. Then a second, slower. A tally beginning, counting something new, counting **up** this time, and Qymaen knelt there watching the third stroke cut itself out of nothing in front of his eyes and understood, with the flat clarity that comes after the last denial is spent, exactly what the marks had counted all along. Not days. Not passengers.

Doors. Every stroke was a door he had walked through since the sky. The crash trench. The acid-rain line. The airlock. The wardroom. The alcove. The junction. The torn weld. And now this one, opening stroke by patient stroke, and on the far side of it, whatever the whole lens-shaped weight of a drowned warship had spent twenty years focusing itself upon, gathering its dead faces and its kept corridors and its borrowed voice toward this single point of arrival, hummed her tune, and waited, warmly, to be knocked.

Day 2: The Drowned Deck



Chapter 1: Frozen Watch

The vault door did not open for him, and Qymaen had not expected it to. He catalogued it instead — the warmth, the tally still adding its slow strokes at kneeling height, the way his rifle-light sank into the black metal rather than glancing off — and then he turned his back on it, deliberately, the way you turn your back on a snare you cannot yet spring, and went looking for another road down. There was always another road down. Ships were built by people who assumed things would break, and every assumption was a ladder. He found the maintenance spine two galleries aft: a crawlway behind a loosened panel, thick with conduit and dead ducting, dropping through the wreck's decks in vertical shafts linked by rungs that twenty years of cold had made brittle as candy. He tested each rung before he trusted it and fell only once, three meters, catching the rail below with hands that screamed their burned palms at him and held anyway.

He came out of the spine into a crew deck that stopped him in the hatchway with the peculiar shame of a man who has walked uninvited into a funeral already in progress. Battle stations. That was what the frozen dead here had been doing when the end came — not sleeping, not eating, not listening to walls. Fighting their ship's last fight from stations they must have known were lost, because discipline was the only thing left to hold when everything else was burning. A fire-control team of four knelt in a semicircle around a targeting console, their hands still moving over controls that had been dead an hour before they died. A damage-control party lay racked along a bulkhead like tools, suits scorched, patch-kits open. And at the deck's center, ringed by her crew the way a bell is ringed by its rope, stood a woman Qymaen took at first for an officer and understood on second look to be the captain — tall, grey at the temples, one arm bound at the shoulder with a battle dressing applied by someone else's hands, her face lifted toward a command display whose glass had long since gone dark. Her mouth was open. She had been giving an order.

He walked the centerline and did not look at their eyes, and this time the not-looking was harder, because these dead had not been tidied. Their frost carried no spirals. Their faces held the plain human record of effort and fear and duty worn to the end, and walking among them felt like trespassing on something that had not been offered to him. The deep decks below had been *arranged* for him, staged, curated by whatever kept this house. These were simply dead people who had died well, and he gave them the courtesy of his silence, and counted paces, and read the ship as he went, because reading was how he kept his nerve from feeding on itself.

The damage pattern took him most of an hour to read and told him a story he did not want to be true. He had boarded expecting a killed ship — reactor breached by enemy fire, crew dead in the seconds after, the clean horror of a naval death. But a killed ship shows its wound. This one showed nothing. The hull plates were scarred with debris strikes and old weapons scorching, none of them fatal, none of them near the engineering spaces. And everywhere he looked for the wound, he found instead evidence of order: blast doors sealed in proper sequence, life-support rerouted along standard emergency channels, scuttle protocols half-executed and then — stopped. Not failed. Stopped, mid-order, like a sentence cut off by a hand over a mouth. The ship had been dying by procedure. Someone aboard had begun the disciplined, deliberate work of drowning her, following the manual's own steps — and someone or something had interrupted it at the last door. He found the final station of it two decks lower: the engineering command post, its breach-console live under its frost, its confirm-key depressed, its safety interlock physically overridden by a tool still lying where it had been dropped. And beside the console, seated with his back straight and his hands flat on the desk before him like a man awaiting judgment, the frozen body of a first officer whose face wore an expression Qymaen had seen only once before, on a Huk slaver who had opened his own holds to find what his cargo had become.

He did not understand what he was reading yet. He copied it into the ledger anyway — the overridden interlock, the dropped tool, the first officer's waiting face — because the ledger never lost an entry, and entries had a way of connecting later, in the dark, when their hour came.

Chapter 2: The Killing Corridors

The wardroom found him again, or he found it, and this time there was no pretending he had come upon it by accident. The deep-route and the maintenance spine converged here — officers' country sat astride the wreck's spine like a saddle — and the table was still set for six with the seventh chair facing the wall, and the warning was still cut into the bulkhead, and the smaller, hurried line beneath it. But the room had changed in the days since Kivan's first visit, changed in a way that made the skin of Qymaen's forearms tighten against his bracers. Someone had cleared the seventh place. Washed it, dried it, stacked the plate and cup neatly at the table's head. Ready for use. And on the chair's seat, folded with geometric precision, lay a cloth napkin that had not been there before, white against the dark metal, patient as an open mouth.

He was still looking at the napkin when the corridor outside began to kill him.

It started as sound — a deep servo-note waking somewhere aft, then answering itself from forward, the ship's ancient close-defense systems drawing stored charge out of capacitors that should have been dust. Then the blast doors began to move. He heard them rather than saw them, at first: the grinding avalanche-weight of armored panels cycling in adjacent passageways, one after another, in

sequence, in **rhythm** — and the rhythm was eleven seconds, the breathing-rhythm, the ship exhaling doors. He went through the wardroom's aft hatch at a dead run as the forward one sealed behind him with a boom he felt in his back teeth.

They herded him. That was the whole art of it, and it was masterful, and hating it did not blunt his professional admiration: the doors did not chase, they **channeled**. Each corridor he chose closed behind him at the eleventh-second mark and opened ahead onto the next, and whenever he slowed to force a side passage, the side passage's own doors began to cycle shut until he moved on. The ship was a river with exactly one bed, and he was water being taught its course. Twice it tried to do more than herd. A point-defense turret dropped from a ceiling mount in a spray of rust and tracked him with a whine of seized bearings before its charge failed with a sad blue cough — old capacitors, twenty winters, even a haunted ship could not cheat entropy entirely. And in a junction ahead of him a servo-blade swung out of a maintenance arm, fast and blind and vicious, and he took it across the left forearm because the alternative was his throat, and the gash it wrote there was long, shallow, and precisely calibrated, and he understood as the blood ran into his glove that the ship had chosen the wound as carefully as it had chosen his route. It was not trying to stop the bleeding. It was trying to learn the bleeding. Everything in this vessel studied; nothing merely struck.

He answered it the way his people answer everything: with work between the beats. The doors' rhythm never varied — eleven seconds, the breathing, the ship's whole attention riding its own tide — and inside a rigid rhythm there is always arithmetic, and inside arithmetic there is always a door. He timed the cycles across four junctions, lips moving, and began to move **with** them, passing through closing gaps at the exact breath between commands, and the ship registered the change. He felt it register, the way you feel a card player sit up across the table. The next junction's doors came early — off-rhythm, cheating — and he was through them anyway, on instinct and fury, rolling under the descending slab and losing a boot-heel's sole to it, and the boom of it sealing behind him was, for the first time since the hunt began, followed by silence that sounded like surprise.

Chapter 3: The Hangar of Teeth

The channel ended where channels end, in a space too large for doors, and Qymaen came up its ramp into the main hangar and stopped believing, briefly, that anything about this ship could still surprise him. It was a cathedral of teeth. Vulture droids hung in their launch racks in ranks that vanished upward into darkness — hundreds of them, fold-winged, hook-legged, dead by every law of entropy — and the frost had taken them so completely that the racks looked like orchards in winter, and the whole silent grove of them curved away overhead in the dark like the inside of a swallowed throat. Below the racks, the deck stretched away toward the launch maw, and beyond the maw's shattered magnetic seal the glacier's blue ice pressed against the opening like a sea standing on its head. And under everything, louder here than anywhere he had yet walked, the engine-noise-that-was-not-an-engine turned its patient pages. The hangar sat directly above the shaft. Whatever burned cold at the bottom of the lens, this room was one of its eyelids.

He was forty meters along the deck, moving rack to rack in the shadows, when the teeth woke.

Not all of them. That was the detail his mind snagged on even while his body went to war — not all, not even a tenth. Perhaps thirty of the hanging shapes unfolded with a dry creaking chorus of hinges and hydraulics, wings spreading in the frost-dark like a rite performed by rote, and their eyes lit, and

they came off the racks in staggered waves that knew exactly where he was. He shot the first out of the air with a round through its sensor cluster and the second through an actuator joint and after that stopped counting shots because counting them was a luxury the arithmetic of thirty-one forbade. He fought the way he had fought in the convoy ambush and a hundred engagements the histories would never spell correctly: from cover to cover, letting the machines spend their ferocity on empty deck, using the racks themselves as a maze. The droids fought — and this was the wrongness he filed even mid-fight — the droids fought **to delay**. They pressed him, harried him, penned him toward the hangar's center, and then declined, every single time, to finish. Two of them had clear runs at his back and broke off at the last instant, wheeling away to strafe a fuel drum he had already left. Delay. Measurement. The house wanted him tired, marked, and **located**, and it wanted him delivered somewhere, and the somewhere was down.

He got his answer to why at the hangar's far gantry, in the worst possible grammar. A wave of six droids broke around a rack-line and he went to meet them with knife and rifle-butt because the rifle's count was down to nineteen and falling, and in the middle of the killing — blade through an eye-lens, stock across a leg-joint, the close ugly work — the crossfire parted for a half-second and he saw, below him on the open deck, the Jedi.

Kaelen Kivan walked through the hangar's mouth with his blade lit and his hands empty of everything else, and the battle bent around him like a stream around a stone. Droids engaged him and disintegrated — casually, almost gently, cyan light flicking out in economical strokes — but the formation itself did not press him, did not pen him, did not offer him a single obstacle the ship had spent on Qymaen. The machines curtailed him. They made a moving wall of noise and light between the Jedi and every approach but his own, escorting him across the deck the way honor guards escort, and Kivan moved inside that curtain with the terrible unhurried economy Qymaen remembered from the shaft gallery, past racks of sleeping death as if strolling a library's stacks. And then the curtain opened, deliberately, a page turning, and the Jedi looked up across forty meters of battlefield directly into Qymaen's eyes, and deactivated his blade.

"You should not have followed the voice," Kivan called, and his voice carried through the battle untouched, pitched with that librarian's precision. "It likes you. That is worse than dislike. Ask it sometime what happened to the ones it disliked." He raised one hand — not a threat, a gesture at the deck hatch behind him, an invitation shaped like a direction. "The fork is real, hunter. The right-hand road. You took it. Good." And he dropped through the hatch himself, unhurried, sheathing the saber as he fell, and every remaining droid in the hangar powered down at once, mid-flight, and crashed onto the deck around Qymaen like a grove of trees dying in fast motion, leaving him alive in the ringing sudden silence with nineteen rounds, a bleeding arm, and the absolute certainty that he had just been graded.

Chapter 1: The Chasm Below

The hatch Kivan had dropped through opened onto the thing Qymaen had been circling since he entered the wreck, and it took his breath the way deep water takes a shout. The reactor shaft. Not the maintenance gallery where he had first looked down into the glow — this was the wound itself, the vertical void at the ship's heart where the reactor had been, three hundred meters of open darkness ringed with the stumps of catwalks and the shorn bases of machinery, and at its bottom,

far below his boots, lay what remained. The breach had not scattered the reactor. It had *opened* it, and the cold blue-white light that rose out of the depths was the light of whatever burned at its heart, still burning after twenty years in defiance of every law Qymaen knew, steady as the breathing that carried it. And spanning the void at mid-depth, where the ship's structural spine had half-collapsed inward rather than apart, ran the beam-bridge: a crooked lane of naked hull-girders crossing the darkness from this side to the vault side, frost-rimed, narrow as a footpath, creaking under loads no one had asked it to carry in two decades.

He stood on the near anchor platform with the rifle-light playing down the girders and understood several things at once, the way you understand all the teeth of a trap only when your boot is above the pan. This was why the ship was a lens. Every whorl of cast metal in the spiral galleries pointed here. Every dead face watched toward it. The herding corridors, the tidied paths, the hangar's curtain of escort — all of it had been moving him, with a host's terrible courtesy, toward this one crossing, because the thing below did not want him kept out; it wanted him *committed*. Nothing tested a creature so thoroughly as a bridge over its own depth. Halfway across any man is more honest than he has ever been in his life.

Kivan was already on the bridge — a grey speck halfway to the far side, moving with that gliding economy, unroped, unhurried, his shadow sliding along the girders beneath him in the cold light. Qymaen did not follow immediately. He made himself stand at the anchor and look *down* instead, because his mother had taught him that fear avoided is fear owed, and he preferred his debts paid at the door.

The light hurt. That was its nature — not bright exactly, but *wrong*, the way a note an octave too high is wrong, light pitched at something just past the eye's ability to refuse it. He looked at the glow at the shaft's bottom in short disciplined sips, and in each sip it seemed closer without being larger, as if distance were a rumor it had declined to honor. Frost spiraled off the walls around it in slow rising columns, snowing upward. And in the light's sourceless heart, for one fraction of a second, something moved — a suggestion of turning, vast and slow, like a whale rolling under ice seen from above — and the whisper that had ridden the ship's breathing ever since the airlock gathered itself, just once, into a shape almost like words, and the words were a woman's laughter.

Not Ronderu's laugh. He gripped the rail until the metal bit through his glove and made himself complete the audit even as his chest tried to close: the pitch was hers, the grain was hers, the salt-wind roughness was hers, and the *love* in it was counterfeit, minted by someone who had studied joy from outside a locked door. It was her laugh the way a portrait laughs — accurate, adoring, and empty — and it rolled up out of the chasm and broke over the anchor platform and left him shaking with a rage so pure it had passed clean through fury into something colder and more durable, which his people call *accounting*.

"You are doing well." The words were scratched into the anchor platform's rail, fresh-cut, hand-height, in handwriting he recognized because it was his own. He read them twice. Then he took out his knife and cut the sentence out of the rail, whole, a neat rectangle of metal, and dropped it over the side, and watched it fall without sound all the way down into the light, and the light swallowed it politely, and nothing about the ship changed at all, which was its own kind of answer.

Chapter 2: Crossing

He crossed the beam-bridge the way his people cross frozen rivers — bent low, weight centered, testing each span before trusting it, eyes on his feet and ears open to the structure's voice. The girders talked under him. Twenty years of thermal murder had worked the welds loose, and each step drew from the bridge a groan or a tick or a long fibrous creak, and underneath the structure's complaints, steady, eleven seconds to the cycle, ran the breathing. He was a hundred meters out, committed past the point where retreat was cheaper than arrival, when the bridge began to lie to him.

It was subtle, and it was evil, and it was patient. A girder would be solid under his testing hand and absent under his descending boot — he dropped knee-first onto steel he had verified a heartbeat earlier, jarring his burned palms against frost, and below him the light brightened fractionally, attentively. He froze. He re-verified the next three spans with obsessive care and they held true, and then, four steps later, his eye showed him a gap in the bridge where the girders plainly continued, and his body refused the step, and he stood swaying over a darkness that was not there while the light at the bottom warmed another degree, savoring him. Sight traded against certainty. That was the game now — it wanted him to stop trusting his own senses, to arrive at the far anchor unable to distinguish floor from fall, softened for whatever waited in the vault.

His other hand saved him, and that was the worst discovery of the crossing. Twice more the bridge lied — once showing phantom gaps, once hiding a real one — and both times, before his conscious mind could rule, his left hand had moved on its own: dragging the back of his gauntlet across the girder beside the phantom gap, scoring a line; tapping twice on the solid plate where his eye reported emptiness, marking truth. And when he finally knelt on the far anchor platform, chest heaving, and turned his gauntlet to the cold light, he found the tally-marks. New ones, fine-cut into the scuffed leather-and-metal of his own bracer, in a hand that was not his — small, precise, feminine — five strokes upright and one crossing them, and beside the tally, tiny, unmistakable, a spiral drawn left-handed.

He sat back on his heels on the far anchor and looked at the marks for a long time, and the cold light looked with him, and somewhere between terror and exhaustion he heard himself speak aloud, quietly, in his own tongue, addressing the marks as much as the dark: "Whose hand is that?" The marks said nothing. But the breathing of the ship caught — skipped its rhythm for the third time since the crash — and resumed a fraction deeper, and Qymaen filed the question in the ledger behind his eyes under debts outstanding, and made himself stand, because Kivan's camp was twenty meters ahead, and the Jedi himself was gone, and the camp was warm.

Chapter 3: The Camp at the Anchor

Warmth, on Jagraia, inside the wreck, was a message. He approached it as one. The camp occupied a shielded alcove behind the anchor platform — a bedroll, a compact heater burning frugally, a mess kit scrubbed and stacked with parade-ground precision, a coil of the braided cable he had noted in the gallery above, and everything arranged in exact perpendicular order, the camp of a mind that measured its own breathing. A pot of tea sat on the heater's edge, and steam still curled from its spout. Minutes old. The Jedi had left in haste or in confidence, and either reading raised questions Qymaen intended to have answered.

He searched the camp with a professional's thoroughness and a thief's guilt. Rations, calculated into

daily units. Medical stores — burn dressings, coagulant, a splint kit, quantities suggesting a man who planned to be injured in specific ways. Spare power cells. And the journal: grey hide, strap-buckled, lying on the bedroll with the deliberate casualness of bait or of trust. He hesitated over it for exactly as long as it took to admit the hesitation was theater, then opened it.

The early pages were survey work — depth charts copied and refined, structural analyses of the vault door's mechanism, notes in that disciplined script, each numeral graded. Then, interleaved among the surveys, the ledger that had stopped him on the glacier weeks ago: SUBJECTS OF THE RELIC, and beneath the heading, a column of names. Fourteen, each crossed out with a single clean line. He read them slowly. They were names from wars he knew only as history — a Republic adjutant, a Separatist fleet-chaplain, a Corellian salvage queen, names in a dozen scripts and species — and beside each, in compressed telegraphic prose, the same story told fifteen ways. Sought the relic deliberately. Believed themselves immune. Reported perfect clarity. Then — and here the journal's own hand changed, page after page, the disciplined script dissolving into a second handwriting, cramped, slanted, urgent, writing **around** the subject rather than about it, circling, never once naming itself — entries no bearer could plausibly have written. The second hand described the bearers' deaths. It described their last days in detail no survivor could supply. It described, in the entry dated three days ago, Kaelen Kivan's own arrival on Jagraia, in past tense, rendered with affection.

And beneath the fourteen crossed names, uncrossed, freshly inked, the fifteenth entry stood waiting:
K. KIVAN.

Qymaen closed the journal and knelt for a moment in the alien warmth of the enemy's camp with his burned hands hanging between his knees, and did the coldest piece of accounting he had done in twenty years of ledgers. Fourteen seekers. Fourteen believers in their own immunity. One man alive who had studied all fourteen and come anyway, believing his calculations exempted him — and one hunter sitting in the fifteenth name's camp holding the evidence that the relic did not merely permit its bearers' plans, it **wrote** them, and had possibly written this one, the whole hunt, the seed-tables, the crash, the invitation, every step of it, in a cramped slanted hand that circled and never named itself. He put the journal back precisely where it had lain, strap buckled the same compass-point, and took nothing but its knowledge. Then he ate part of a ration bar that tasted of nothing, drank tea he did not remember deciding to pour, and went hunting the Jedi through the vault approaches with his rifle up and nineteen rounds and the growing, unspeakable suspicion that the only free actor on this world was the one carrying the knife.

Chapter 4: The Relic Room

The vault antechamber announced itself the way temples announce themselves, with scale. A processional corridor — carved spirals running floor to ceiling in bands, worn smooth at their centers by nothing that had walked here in twenty years — opened onto the chamber Kivan's charts called the reliquary, and Qymaen came up its length low and slow and stopped in the doorway with his breath smoking, because the room beyond was already occupied by more than silence.

The Hollow Bridge rested at the chamber's center on a plinth of fused debris — weapons and handrails and deck-plate melted together into a single black pillar, and atop the pillar, mounted in a

frame built from severed starship handrails bent and braided into a cradle, lay a curved shard of crystal the length of a forearm. Black, but not dark: light went into it and did not come out, and looking at the shard was like looking at a hole cut in the universe with something patient standing on the other side, pressing its face against the fabric. It sang. That was the only word. Under the chamber's silence ran a chord of voices — dozens, hundreds, layered, murmuring, each one distinct if attended to and none of them quite saying anything, a congregation forever clearing its throat — and woven through the murmur, unmistakable, kept like a jewel, ran the tune she used to hum. Note-perfect. His correction included.

And Kaelen Kivan stood before the plinth with his saber hilt holstered and his hands folded behind his back, studying the relic with the expression of a man auditing accounts he already fears will not balance.

"You are punctual," the Jedi said, without turning. "The outcomes predicted it, but prediction and observation remain distinct pleasures." He turned then, and the chamber's sourceless light let Qymaen see what the shaft gallery had hidden: the man was spent. Not weak — spent, a ledger balanced by borrowing against something that could not be repaid, shadows carved under his eyes, hands steady with the steadiness of exhausted stone. "Before you raise the rifle — nineteen rounds, I know — consider that I have computed every outcome available to this room, and I will save us both the suspense. In none of them does shooting me spare you. In most, it dooms the surface settlements within a season. There is one" — the ghost of a smile, gone as it arrived — "in which it dooms them anyway, but more slowly, and you survive to be blamed."

"What is it?" Qymaen did not lower the rifle. He also did not fire, and knew, watching those carved-shadow eyes take the measure of his not-firing, that the failure to shoot had already been entered somewhere in the tallies.

"A bridge," Kivan said simply, and turned back to the shard. "That is its own name for itself, in a language older than either of our peoples' quarrels. It bridges. Between the living and the dead — that is the lure, the honest one, buried at the center of the hook. It can put your hand on the shoulder of anyone you have buried. Ask it, and it will let you say the goodbye the war refused you." His voice stayed level, librarian-flat, and that levelness frightened Qymaen more than any tremor could have. "Every bearer before me accepted that offer. That is the mechanism. Not compulsion — *grief*, offered terms. It cannot take a man by force. It waits to be asked." A pause, precise. "I intend to ask it better questions."

The rifle-light shook, very slightly, at the edges of its beam. "You came for her," Qymaen said. "The grave. Say it plain."

"I came for leverage over a war-crimes tribunal," Kivan said, "and the grave was to be the lever. Those were my reasons. They were good ones. I checked." And he reached out — slowly, ceremonially, the way men reach for things they have already decided to be damned by — and lifted the Hollow Bridge out of its frame of severed handrails, and the shard came away light as a bird's bone in his two hands, and the chord of voices in the chamber rose, and every preserved face on every deck of the drowned ship turned at once toward the reliquary, and every light died.

Chapter 1: The Ship Wakes

The darkness after the lights died was not empty, and Qymaen had one long second to understand that before the ship began to scream. Not alarms — he would have preferred alarms. This was metal: the whole hull voicing a single low groan that climbed and climbed and did not break, the sound a frozen thing makes when warmth enters it too fast, except nothing was warming. The light at the bottom of the shaft was rising. He felt it through the deck before he saw it — the breathing gone, replaced by something quicker and hungrier, a pulse where a tide had been — and when he risked the doorway and looked back along the processional corridor, the spiral carvings on their bands were glowing. Faintly. Blue-white. Pitched at the eye's edge of refusal, like everything else the thing below made.

"Pick up the pack, hunter," Kivan said quietly behind him. "The ship is no longer pretending to be dead, and I would rather discuss our situation above the flood line." There was a scrape of equipment being shouldered, unhurried. "The reactor's residual charge is waking because it has been invited to. We have perhaps an hour of structure left in the lower decks. More if we are lucky. Less if we argue."

Qymaen did not argue. He fell back up the processional corridor with the rifle covering their rear and his shoulder blades crawling, and behind them the reliquary's sourceless light died as they left it — snuffed, deliberately, a lamp carried elsewhere — and the last thing he saw in the doorway was the empty cradle of severed handrails on its plinth, flexing once, very slightly, like a hand remembering how to close.

The ship met them at the first junction with its dead. Not attacking — **presenting**. Every blast door on the route upward stood open now, hospitably, and beyond each threshold the frozen crew had assembled: standing in ranks down the cross-corridors, facing inward, faces lifted, mouths open in that uniform silent speech he had seen on the medical decks of his imagination before he had ever walked these decks. As Qymaen passed the first rank they turned their heads together, tracking him, the movement smooth as weed under water, and from somewhere in the mass of them came a voice — not spoken, **exhaled**, riding the cold air out of open mouths — and the voice was Ronderu's portrait-painting counterfeit, and it said, gently, in his own tongue: **This way home, brother.**

He shot nothing. That was the discipline that cost him most in those hours, and he paid it, because his mother's law held even here, perhaps especially here: you do not fire into the honored dead, whatever wears their frost. He walked the centerline through ranks of turning faces with the rifle up and unfired and his tusks bared until his jaw ached, and Kivan walked beside him — beside, not ahead, another small terrible courtesy — and spoke to the dead as they passed them, quietly, in Basic, giving each rank its due: "Gunnery crew. Thank you. Fire teams. Thank you." Naming their stations the way Qymaen named bodies. It was either mockery or communion, and Qymaen could not tell which, and the not-telling sat in him like a swallowed hook.

Chapter 2: The Herd Reversed

By the second gallery up, the herding began again — but reversed, and that reversal told Qymaen more than anything the Jedi had said. Before the reliquary, the ship had channeled him **down**, toward the lens, the vault, the commitment. Now the doors channeled them both **up** and out, fast, along the shortest path toward the hull breach where the scavengers' lamps still glowed far above, and the channeling had lost its courtesy. Doors slammed behind their heels close enough to tug

clothing. A corridor flooded ankle-deep with supercooled coolant while they crossed it, and the cold went through his boots and took the feeling from his feet for an hour. And twice, in side passages, things moved that were not droids and not dead crew — shapes of frost and suggestion, tall, wrong-jointed, pacing them beyond the reach of the rifle-light, keeping always exactly at the edge of what he could almost see. The house had stopped hosting. The house was evicting.

"It has what it came for," Kivan said. They had paused at a junction while he re-bandaged Qymaen's forearm with supplies from the hunter's own med-kit, his hands quick, impersonal, precise, a surgeon who happened to be your enemy. "Or rather, it has *me*, which was always the rarer prize. You were contingency. Leverage against my refusal." He tied off the bandage with a pull that was not gentle. "It will try to keep you now. Collateral has value only until it becomes inconvenient, and you have become — " he weighed the word — "articulate."

"What does it want you for?" Qymaen asked, and heard his own voice come out lower than he intended, because the question underneath the question was *what does it want me for*, and they both knew it.

"The same as the fourteen." Kivan stood, coiling the used bandage wrappers with unnecessary neatness. "Hands. A bearer walks the bridge between living and dead wearing flesh, and flesh can go places intention cannot. Fourteen bearers dug it fourteen steps closer to wherever it is going. I am to be the fifteenth step." He looked up then, and met Qymaen's eyes, and for one unguarded half-second something moved behind the librarian's calm that Qymaen recognized across twenty years of reading enemies: it was the expression of a man standing on a ledge who has already checked the fall and found the arithmetic acceptable. "It showed me her grave, hunter. Your sister-in-arms. Real coordinates, verifiable, the genuine article — I would stake my order on it. That is why you are still alive. When this is over, if any version of 'over' survives, that debt is mine to pay you." And he walked on up the herd-path before Qymaen could find words for the tangle that sentence left in him — hope and bait braided past unbraiding, exactly, precisely, the relic's own craft.

Chapter 3: What the Dead Officer Knew

They gained the medical decks at what his body insisted was late evening, running on stims and stubbornness, and there the exodus stopped meeting them, because the medical decks were where the relic kept its choir. The frozen dead here stood in ranks as he had first seen them — but now, in the rising blue glow that seeped up the stairwells, their mouths moved. All of them. Hundreds of preserved lips shaping the same silent syllables in ragged unison, a congregation mid-hymn, and the frost of their breath had built on the bulkheads into banks and sculptures of ice that caught the light and threw it wrong. And in the center of the main ward stood the officer Qymaen had steadied himself against days ago — no. Hours ago. Time had gone soft in the wreck. She stood apart from the ranks, captain's tabs frosted at her collar, arm bound at the shoulder with the same battle dressing, mouth open on her unfinished order.

He knew it was a trap the moment his boot crossed the ward's threshold, and he crossed it anyway, because she had been reaching toward the command display and the display was dark and the order she had been giving had never been logged, and ledgers existed to correct exactly that kind of omission.

Her memory met him at her shoulder. There was no other honest word for it — contact, and then *influx*, the ward vanishing and a bridge's observation deck assembling around him out of nothing, smoke-stained, tilting, alive with alarm: the last hour of the ship, played backward through the dying senses of the woman who had commanded it. He saw the order arrive. Not by comm — it came up through the deck itself, through the soles of her boots, a compulsion wearing the fleet's own code-clothing, authentic seals, authentic voice-prints, ordering the reactor scuttled and the cargo entombed and every hand to stations to die at. He watched her check the authentication three times, watch her hands shake on the fourth, watch her begin to refuse — and then watch the refusal drain out of her like heat, replaced by a calm that arrived from outside, vast and reasonable, a tide coming in over a seawall: *the order is correct; the order has always been correct; obey.* He watched her give it. He watched her officers die well around it. And at the very end, as the breach-console accepted its confirm-key, he watched her look up through the observation glass into the black of atmosphere and see — for one frame, one flicker — the shape of a smile hanging over the whole wreck, wide as weather.

The ward snapped back. Qymaen was on one knee with blood in his mouth where he had bitten his tongue, and the dead captain stood over him with her mouth still open, and out of that open mouth, using her stolen throat, the counterfeit voice said: *Now you know how ships kneel. Ask me about the shore, brother. Ask me what the water kept.*

"Her name," Qymaen said, rising, wiping his mouth, addressing the rank-tabs because the face was occupied, "was Sovala Ren. She commanded well. You may not use her." And the entire medical deck exhaled — hundreds of open mouths releasing one shared plume of frost, a white gasp that rolled across the ward and broke around him like surf — and in the sound of it, beneath it, delighted and furious at once, the ship laughed.

Chapter 4: Terms

Kivan was waiting two galleries higher, seated on a stripped conduit housing with the relic cradled against his chest inside his outer robe, and he did not look surprised to see Qymaen alive, which was its own small injury. They regarded each other across the frost-lit gallery — the hunter bleeding, the bearer brooding, the shard between them singing its patient chord — and the Jedi spoke first, and what he said rearranged the hunt.

"You touched her memory. Good. Then you understand the mechanism now: it trades in the true. Everything it shows is real — that is the poison. A lie you can fight." He rose, and Qymaen marked how carefully the man moved now, how the relic rode against his chest like an infant carried by someone learning fear. "So hear true terms. The grave coordinates it gave me are real. I verified them against Republic survey records before I ever landed. Ronderu lij Kummar's remains lie where it says they lie. That promise is being kept on you right now, this instant, as payment for my passage — your grief, spent as my collateral. Feel the shape of that bargain, hunter, because it is the shape of every bargain it has ever made, and I am fifteen names deep in learning to read the fine script."

"And yours?" Qymaen's voice came out flat. "What does the fine script say you owe?"

"Passage." For the first time since the glacier, Kaelen Kivan smiled, and the smile was young and bitter and entirely human, and it was worse than all his calm. "It wants me to carry it off this world."

Off-world. It has spent twenty years in a box at the bottom of a hole, and it has learned everything a drowned ship can teach, and it is bored, and boredom is the one hunger it cannot feed alone." He shifted the robe at his chest, and the blue glow of the waking decks seeped down the gallery behind them, and the chord in the shard swelled fractionally, expectantly, listening to itself be discussed. "It has offered me the tribunals' leverage. The war graves. Answers to questions my Order has bled for. It offers generously. It only requires," and here the librarian's precision returned, each word set down like a coin, "that I keep walking, and keep carrying, and never once ask what the fifteenth name in my journal is a first draft of."

Somewhere below them the reactor's waking pulse stumbled — skipped a beat, resumed deeper — and both of them turned their heads toward the sound without deciding to, two animals in the same forest marking the same wind. "Walk or don't," Kivan said quietly. "But walk away from the pulse. The exits are being tidied, and I would regret the arithmetic of your death more than I can efficiently say."

Chapter 1: The Vision at the Galley

The collapse cut Qymaen off from Kivan between one junction and the next — a whole corridor section folding downward with a groan of failing welds, ice and plate thundering into the deck below, and when the dust of frost settled he was alone in a dead-end galley with a sealed hatch and the growing blue pulse in the deck under his knees, and the ship had him exactly where something wanted him. He knew it the way you know a closed room with an open cage in it. The herd, the collapse, the timing — none of it was haste. It was appointment.

The galley went first. Frost bloomed across the serving counters in whorls, and out of the whorls rose heat where there should have been none, salt, woodsmoke, the tar-smell of beach fires, and the sound of surf doing its arithmetic against black rock. The walls were a grey sky with light coming through sideways. The deck was hard sand. And at the tideline, hip-shot, twin swords bare across her forearms, stood Ronderu lij Kummar, twenty years old and twenty years dead, squinting at him out of the sun's glare exactly as she had on ten thousand mornings, and the vision did not make the mistake of embracing him or weeping. It made her impatient.

"You're late," she said. "The tide's been in twice since you got here. Look at your hands." His hands, in the dream, held the rifle, and she looked at the rifle the way she had looked at every weapon she thought beneath him, mouth twisting. "Twenty years, and you come to me with a *stick that throws*. I taught you the reach-cut myself and you've gone off to fight ghosts with a stick." She turned toward the water, and the water was warm-colored and full of evening, and beyond it, faint, there was a shape on the far shore like a cairn waiting to be finished. "He's carrying me home. The tall one. You keep shooting at the messenger, brother, and the message is just this: put down the stick, pick up a spade. I've been waiting on the digging." And then, over her shoulder, with the old break-in-the-middle laugh that had cracked ribs behind it: "You always were slow about graves."

It nearly had him. That was the truth he made himself carry afterward, unsoftened: it nearly had him, because everything it showed was true — the tar-smell, the glare, the exact weight of her disapproval, love rendered so faithfully that his body answered it before his mind could vote — and the offer underneath was simple and enormous: put down the rifle. Stop hunting. Dig. Every step of the hunt undone, replaced by the one act twenty years of war had refused him, and all it cost was the

man standing between him and the shore, who had after all only ever carried her home.

His own palm ended it. He drove his knife through it — into the deck-sand of the vision, through the meat below the thumb, the old pain-discipline his mother's people used for oath-taking — and the pain came back with him into the galley like a diver hauling a line, and the vision tore. Not faded; **tore**, cloth ripped across, and behind Ronderu's face, behind the beach, behind the entire warm fiction, he saw for one full second what was holding the cloth up: a vastness, patient, coiled through the wreck's deep dark the way a squid is coiled through its cave, folded around the reactor's glow, wearing the relic like a mask worn on the end of a tentacle. It did not rage at being seen. It adjusted. The fold of it shifted — he felt the shift in his teeth, in the deck, in the pitch of the pulse — and the torn edges of the vision began knitting themselves back together over its face, already re-weaving the shore.

"Her name," Qymaen said through his teeth, blade still in his palm, blood smoking where it struck frost, "was Ronderu lij Kummar. You have never once said it right. She is not yours. Neither am I." And he pulled the knife free and walked out of the galley through the hatch the ship had so thoughtfully left unlocked, and behind him, very quietly, the surf kept breaking, and someone on the shore kept waiting, and both of them knew now that he knew, and the knowing changed nothing except everything.

Chapter 2: The Tally Turns

He found Kivan by following the fighting. The Jedi had run afoul of the evacuation itself — whether the ship had turned on him or he had refused some last door of the tidied path, Qymaen never learned — and the upper maintenance gallery echoed with cyan light and the shriek of servo-arms being dismantled by someone whose economy was starting to fray at the edges. Qymaen came into it from the flank with nineteen rounds and a bleeding palm and fought beside him without a word being spent on it, back to back against a wave of vulture droids that fought, still, to delay, and died, still, by ones and twos, and the last of them crashed at their feet mid-wheel like the grove falling again, and the silence afterward had the quality of a held breath.

"Your hand," Kivan said, nodding at the palm, not at the battle.

"It talks faster through wounds." Qymaen wrapped it with strips cut from his sleeve. Below them, muffled by decks, the pulse stumbled again — longer this time, arrhythmic, a heart finding a new and less patient rhythm. "It showed me her. The real thing. Every detail true." He tied off the knot with his teeth. "That's how I know your grave-coordinates are real, Jedi. Same coin. Same mint."

"Yes." No flinch, no denial. The librarian's honesty, which Qymaen was beginning to understand was the most dangerous thing aboard besides the shard. "And it has shown you the shape behind the mask, or you would not be climbing toward the surface with that face." Kivan looked down the dark of the gallery, toward the pulse. "It is accelerating. Waking the reactor's residual charge burns years of its hoarded patience in hours — do you understand what that means? A thing that has waited twenty years is suddenly unwilling to wait a day. Something has changed its schedule." He turned, and the carved-shadow eyes were bright with a fear he was no longer spending effort to hide. "You changed it. In the reliquary, when you would not fire. It has been planning around my consent for weeks, hunter. It has just begun planning around yours."

They climbed. The exits were being tidied indeed — hatches stood open along the whole upward route now, the herd-path reversed and generous, and the generosity was the threat, and they took it anyway, because the alternative was the pulse. On the last gallery before the airlock country Qymaen stopped, because the wall beside the hatch bore fresh cuts at kneeling height, and the cuts had changed. The tally-marks were crossed through. All of them — doors, strokes, the long patient count of his entrances — struck through with a single line drawn left-handed, fine and precise, in the feminine smallness of the hand that marked his bracer. And beneath the crossed-out tally, one new mark: not a stroke but a spiral, small, complete, drawn with a care that had nothing mechanical in it.

"Left-handed," Qymaen said. His voice sounded far away to himself. "Ronderu worked left-handed. Everyone said the swords made her ambidextrous. They were wrong. She was born to the left hand and taught herself the right."

Kivan looked at the mark for a long moment, and then at the bracer on Qymaen's forearm, where the fine feminine tally counted its quiet count, and something passed over the Jedi's face that Qymaen had not seen there before and could not name until later, walking the ice in the dark: it was professional dread, the look of an accountant finding a transaction in the ledger that he himself did not enter.

"The relic does not have hands," Kivan said slowly. "Bearers are its hands. Fourteen bearers, fourteen sets of hands, and every one of them recorded in my journal in that second script — cramped, slanted, circling." His eyes came up. "Hunter. Whose handwriting is on your bracer?"

Qymaen did not answer. He had taken the bracer off and was looking at the underside of the strap, at marks he had never turned over to read, and the marks were words, tiny, fresh-cut in the leather, in Basic, in a woman's hand, and they said:

Not hers. Ask me who.

Chapter 1: The Ice Field

They came out of the wreck into a night that had gone violently, magnificently wrong. The sky above the glacier was burning — curtains of aurora the color of the reactor's glow, blue-white and vast, sheeting across the stars in slow flags, and under the curtains the whole ice field lay lit like a hall of mirrors, every facet of it throwing back the impossible light. Qymaen stood in the airlock's shadow with his breath tearing in rags and understood that what he was seeing was not weather. The pulse below the rock was reaching up through twenty years of dead machinery and painting the sky with itself, announcing to whatever could read such script that something buried had entered its final appetite.

Kivan stood beside him with his face turned up, and the light played over him, and he looked, for once, exactly as tired as he was. "It will keep the sky until it is done or dead," he said. "Scavengers will run from it. The settlements will see it and name it an omen. Nothing that can interfere is coming, and nothing that cannot has ever mattered less." He settled the robe around the shard at his chest. "The vault door is my destination still, hunter. More than ever now. It opened for me on my first visit and it will not open twice for me alone — the mechanism wants kin-blood or kin-grief, and I have neither, and you have both, and we have perhaps one night before the pulse finishes cooking the decks behind us."

"Say plainly what you are asking." Qymaen did not look away from the sky. "You want me to walk back down. Toward that." He nodded at the aurora. "Into the house that just tried to buy me with a beach."

"I want you to walk down past the thing that tried to buy you," Kivan said, "to a door only your grief can open, because behind that door is the only room in this ship where its voice does not reach. My instruments say so. The relic says so, and lies about everything except geography." He moved off along the airlock terrace, unhurried as ever, a grey figure under a burning sky. "And I would remind you of the terms already paid. You know the grave coordinates are real. The door opens them faster than any spade."

Qymaen stood a moment longer under the light. Then he checked the rifle — fourteen rounds now; the droids had been expensive — and shouldered his pack, and followed the Jedi down onto the ice, because the ledger behind his eyes held two debts now, and one of them wore a cairn's shape on a far shore.

Chapter 2: What the Bracer Said

They made the glacier's shoulder by what his body swore was midnight, and camped without fire in the lee of a fallen frigate's engine block, and there, in the impossible aurora-light, with the enemy sitting three meters away drinking tea he had somehow heated, Qymaen finally asked the question cut into his own strap.

"Not hers," he said, working the bracer loose. "Whose?"

The marks answered by arrangement rather than magic — Kivan examined them with a surveyor's lamp and the detached fury of a scholar finding forgery in a sacred text, and between them they built the truth the way hunters build a carcass, bone by bone. The handwriting on the tally-marks, on the walls, on his bracer, was not Ronderu lij Kummar's. It was not the relic's own, either — relics did not write; bearers wrote. Fourteen bearers had written in Kivan's journal in that second cramped script, each hand distinct if you knew where to look, each circling, none naming itself. And the small feminine hand that had counted doors for Qymaen since his first step into the dark matched, stroke for stroke and slant for slant, the entries in the journal's earliest pages — the entries belonging to the first bearer. A woman. A Republic signals officer, drowned with this ship when the sky was young, who had found the Hollow Bridge in the wreckage of her own dying vessel and worn it for six days while it learned her hand, and who had spent those six days doing the only thing the shard's chorus had never expected anyone aboard to do.

"She hid pages from it," Kivan said quietly. He had the journal open on his knee, to leaves Qymaen had not seen — thinner paper sewn behind the rear cover, ink gone brown, written fast and small by someone rationing light. "The chorus reads memory and desire. It cannot read what a disciplined mind refuses to record in words at all — and she was a signals officer, hunter; encryption was her religion. She left a manual. How to think sideways around it. How to mark true things so they survive its editing. How to leave messages outside the places it watches." He looked up, and the aurora moved on his face. "Every tally-mark on your path was hers. Not the relic counting you. Her, *steering* you — marking safe ground, marking doors, keeping count of your progress through a house she knew too well. The left-handed spirals were hers. The crossed-out strokes tonight were

hers, telling you the count was finished." He closed the journal. "She has been dead for twenty years, and she has spent all twenty of them standing between that thing and anyone it tried to lure, and she has been waiting, since before your hunt began, for someone strong enough and stubborn enough to reach the reliquary and end it."

The wind moved the curtains of light overhead. Qymaen sat with the bracer in his hands and his throat full of ice, and thought about every warm treachery the shore had offered him, and understood at last why the counterfeit had always gotten the love slightly wrong. It had never once consulted the original. It could not. Every time it had reached for Ronderu's voice, it had had to pass the first bearer's hand, standing in front of the grave of her memory the way she had stood in front of the tally-marks, and edit, and distort, and steal what it could — and the distortion he had been cursing as bad craft for five days had been a wound deliberately dealt, a signature slashed across every forgery by a dead woman with a knife made of discipline.

"Why tell me?" His voice came out rough. "Why steer me, why wait for me? She didn't know me."

"No," Kivan agreed. "But she knew the shape of what would come, because the shape is always the same: someone the dead loved too much to leave alone. Read her last page. It is addressed forward."

He passed the journal back, open, and Qymaen read by aurora-light the last lines the signals officer ever wrote, small and fast and brown:

To the next one it sings to: it will wear your beloved. Do not fear that. Grief is armor if you stop being ashamed of it. It cannot counterfeit the mistakes love makes. Check the errors. The wrong note in the song. The mercy where cruelty belongs. Find the flaw and hold it, and follow whoever else is hunting the flaw, and you will find the door. I am sorry for what it costs. We are all of us digging toward the same morning.

Chapter 3: The Terms Refused

The pulse woke them an hour before dawn, if dawn still meant anything under a sky that refused to darken. The aurora had begun to move — no longer sheeting but **turning**, slowly, the whole ceiling of light revolving around a point somewhere above the dreadnought's spine, and under their feet the ice transmitted a rhythm that was no longer eleven seconds. Faster now. Seven. A heart climbing toward effort.

"It has stopped pretending to be patient," Kivan said, already packing. "The reactor's residual charge is nearly awake. When it fully wakes, the glacier melts from beneath, and everything this ice has kept for twenty years comes up — including the hulls, including the dead, including us if we are still inside the geometry." He buckled the journal strap and stood. "The vault, hunter. Today. While its attention is spent upward, feeding the sky."

They went down together for the second time, and this time the ship let them, and the letting was worse than any herding. Corridors stood open and unwatched. The frozen crew had withdrawn from their ranks — drawn down, deeper, toward the pulse, called to some final muster in the lower dark — and the galleries echoed hollow, frost dimming ahead of their boots with a hospitality that had lost all interest in disguise. On the processional corridor's threshold the first bearer's marks waited one last time, fresh-cut beside the carved spirals: a single arrow, fine and feminine, pointing down, and beneath it three words in Basic:

DOOR. BLOOD. HURRY.

The antechamber was warm as a body when they reached it, and the black carved door stood radiating its skin-heat into air sixty degrees below freezing, and the chord of voices behind it had risen until it was no longer background but address — a congregation chanting now, clearly, syllables almost resolving into language, into invitation, into *her* voice saying his name with her old break-in-the-middle warmth. Kivan laid his palm flat on the spiral carving and it did nothing at all, and he withdrew it, unsurprised, and stepped aside.

"Kin-blood or kin-grief," he said. "It is listening for what you carry, not what I calculate."

Qymaen set down the rifle. He took out his mother's funerary knot — dried light as ash, hard as old bone, twenty years against his heart — and unwound it from his bracer, and pressed it flat against the warm spiral with his wounded palm over it, blood and keepsake and grief all in one print, and spoke, quietly, in his own tongue, the formal words of opening a grave for tending: *I am kin. I come to tend. Stand aside.*

The door drank. There was no other honest verb — the knot darkened as though waterpassed through it, the blood-print lifted out of his skin like heat rising, and deep in the black metal something turned, and unlocked, and the two halves of the carved spiral slid apart on a breath of air from the vault beyond that smelled of nothing at all, which on this world of preserved deaths was the strangest smell yet. And from the chamber within, lit by the shard's own glow rising to meet them, came the sound the whole lens-shaped weight of the ship had been shaped around: the hum of a stasis-generator at full load, and beneath it, thin and clear, the tune she used to hum — sung now, not hummed, by a voice that had learned every note and still, even here, even now, got the middle wrong.

"The coffin is occupied," Kivan said softly, reading some instrument or some certainty. "It was occupied when I left it. Hunter — whatever you are expecting to find sleeping in there, check the errors first."

Day 3: Cold Arithmetic



Chapter 1: The Occupied Coffin

The vault beyond the door was small, round, and honest in a way nothing else on Jagraia had been: a single chamber carved from the wreck's deepest keel-frame, its walls bare of spirals, its air dead and still, and at its center, under a skin of black crystal grown like frost across a frame of fused handrails, a sarcophagus. The stasis-generator hummed beneath it, a plain machine, unhaunted, doing the one thing machines do better than ghosts: holding stillness. And through the crystal lid, lit from within by the shard's glow, Qymaen could see what lay inside, and his knees nearly went, and did not.

Not Ronderu.

A stranger. Small-boned, grey-haired even in preservation, dressed in the rotted remnants of a Republic signals officer's uniform — and folded in her crossed hands, held the way a soldier holds orders she intends to deliver personally, was a second object: a curved shard of black crystal, twin to the one against Kaelen Kivan's chest, dark and lightless and silent. The first bearer had not fled the Hollow Bridge, or hidden from it, or died fighting it. She had taken half of it into stasis with her — split the artifact down its seam of voices with some discipline he could not guess at — and lain down inside her own machine, keeping her half where no bearer's hand could reach it, and waited twenty years for someone to come asking the right question.

"The errors," Qymaen said. His voice came out level, which surprised him. "Check the errors first." He circled the coffin once, slowly, reading it as he had read the crash trench and the drift and the damage pattern. The crystal skin was unbroken. The generator was intact. The woman's face, behind frost-clear crystal, was composed, deliberate, waiting — the face of someone who has chosen her position and means to hold it. And the wrong note, when he found it, was so small he nearly wept at

its size: the shard in her hands was *warm*. In a vault kept at stasis-cold, in a room that had never once known heat, the twin crystal glowed faintly against her fingers with the skin-warmth of a living palm, and everything else in the chamber was ice.

"It is not a tomb," Kivan said behind him, very quietly. He had stopped at the threshold and would not cross it; the shard against his chest had begun to sing, low and continuous, a chord held like breath. "It is a lockbox, and she is the lock. The Hollow Bridge is not one artifact, hunter. It is two halves of one hunger — the voice and the ear, the lure and the hook. What I carry is the voice. It can imitate anything, offer anything, wear any beloved face. But it cannot *hold* anything. Nothing it takes stays taken; it pours through the shard like water through a hand. The other half" — his eyes went to the warm crystal in the dead woman's grip — "is the vessel. Whatever is given to the voice and received by the vessel is kept. Forever. That is the whole mechanism of every bargain it has ever struck: the promise feels real because the voice gives it, and the price is real because the vessel keeps it. She took the keeping out of the world."

"And it wants her back," Qymaen said.

"It has wanted her back for twenty years." Kivan's librarian calm had gone somewhere; what remained was younger and worse. "Every bearer it has worn, every corridor it has tidied, every hunter it has lured down the lens — all of it, all fourteen names in my journal, was excavation. It has been trying for two decades to get hands on this room, to open this box, to reunite its halves, and it cannot, because the door wants kin-blood or kin-grief and none of its creatures have ever carried either. It needed a man who loved a dead woman enough to open graves for her." The Jedi looked up then, and met Qymaen's eyes across the coffin, and finished the arithmetic neither of them needed spoken. "It needed you."

The chord against Kivan's chest swelled — and shifted, mid-swell, into her voice, into the break-in-the-middle warmth, into words pitched precisely for the space between the two living men: *Brother. She kept me from you. Twenty years I have reached for the shore and she held the door. Open it. Take my keeping back, and I will give you the beach, the evening tide, her laughing — give me my body, and I will give you yours.*

Qymaen stood over the lockbox of a woman he had never met, listening to the lie wear his beloved's love, and did the hardest thing his people ask of anyone, which is nothing. He did not answer it. He turned instead to Kivan, and held out his bleeding palm, flat, like a merchant showing scales.

"You said your instruments read this room. Read this: if the voice without the vessel can only make promises, then every bargain ever struck with it was counterfeit twice over. It *cannot keep* what it takes." His hand stayed out. "So the tribunals' leverage, the war graves, the answers your Order bled for — say plainly, Jedi, before either of us spends another hour in this room: what did you actually come here to buy?"

For the first time since the glacier, Kaelen Kivan looked away first.

Chapter 2: What the Cold Logician Bought

He told it standing in the doorway, facing out, the way men deliver confessions in rooms they cannot bear to face — flatly, completely, with the terrible economy of a mind that has rehearsed honesty the way others rehearse lies. He had not come for the tribunal leverage. The leverage was true but

secondary, a coin to spend ashore. He had come, three weeks ago, with survey charts and a physician's kit and a braided cable, because Kaelen Kivan, Jedi Consular, cold logician, had done a calculation in the archives on Coruscant and found that the Clone Wars' last uncounted dead were not being counted, and that the counting would never be authorized by any institution that would have to arrest itself, and that the only evidence complete enough to convict a Huk render-fleet's entire command structure lay entombed in the deep ice of Jagraia with the ship that had scuttled rather than surrender it.

"The cargo manifests," he said. "The render-barges' transaction records, the guild ciphers, the chain of signatures from the slave-pens to the processing decks — the whole archive of the ten thousand was aboard this dreadnought when she went down. Her captain refused to let it be captured. Both fleets' intelligence services wanted it drowned. So it has lain under the glacier for twenty years, and I am the first person in two decades who came asking after paper instead of power." A pause, and the pause was where the wound was. "And the relic found me on the second day, in the wardroom, through the warning I had cut myself days earlier — I wrote THE BRIDGE IS HOLLOW as a caution to any who followed, and it read over my shoulder, and it answered. It offered me the archive whole. Restored, legible, complete. Ten thousand counts of murder, documented beyond appeal." His hands, folded behind him, had gone white at the knuckles. "Do you understand? It did not tempt me with her grave, hunter. It tempted me with *justice*. Every instrument of this hunt — the surveys, the descent, the alliance of necessity with the man hunting me — every step has been purchased with that offer, and I have walked every step knowing, KNOWING, that the voice cannot keep what it gives. I have spent three weeks and fourteen predecessors' worth of warning on a purchase I knew was counterfeit, because I could not stop calculating how close the counterfeit came to true."

The vault's silence held him like water. Qymaen heard his own blood move. Somewhere above them, muffled by keel and ice, the pulse climbed.

"So the fine script says," Qymaen said slowly, "you owe it passage off-world. Your half walks; the archive rides."

"My half walks carrying a man who knows the price is false," Kivan agreed, "and that, hunter, is the one variable in all its twenty years of calculation that it has never once encountered: a bearer who does not believe. It cannot compel. It can only trade. And I intend, at the proper moment, in the proper room, to default on the debt." He turned from the doorway at last, and his face had the terrible peace of a man whose ledger balances only because he has entered his own name on the loss side. "Defaulting will cost more than I can efficiently describe. Which is why I need your grief to open doors, and your stubbornness to hold them, and perhaps — the calculations diverge here — your knife. Come. The sky is burning, the ice is waking, and there is an officer in this box who has been holding a door for twenty years against something that cannot be held forever. We should ask her how she managed it, before we inherit the post."

Chapter 3: The First Bearer Speaks

They could not wake her, and did not try. The stasis held; the lockbox held; the twin shard lay warm in her crossed hands like a coal that had learned patience, and the only language she had left was the one written in journals and tally-marks and left-handed spirals. But Kivan had brought his instruments — the surveyor's lamp, the signal kit, the disciplined kit of a man who planned to be

injured in specific ways — and rigged to the coffin's crystal skin a resonator that made the frost sing back, and the first bearer answered the only way a locked door answers: by showing what she had hidden in her own walls.

Words bloomed in the crystal, tiny, brown-inked, mirrored — written on the underside of the lid twenty years ago by a woman writing blind, upside down, rationing light, trusting the ice to keep her letters until they were needed:

TO THE ONE WHO OPENS THIS: IT WILL HAVE TOLD YOU THE VESSEL IS EVIL. THE VESSEL ONLY HOLDS. LOVE HOLDS. GRIEF HOLDS. A LEDGER HOLDS. WHAT YOU DO WITH A KEPT THING WAS NEVER ITS AFFAIR. I KEEP MY SHIP'S LAST ORDERS AND MY MOTHER'S FACE IN HERE, WHERE THE VOICE CAN NEVER EDIT THEM AGAIN. IF YOU ARE READING THIS, YOU CARRIED GRIEF PAST EVERY DOOR, SO YOU ALREADY KNOW THE SECRET: IT CANNOT TAKE WHAT YOU REFUSE TO TRADE. IT CAN ONLY WEAR WHAT YOU HAND IT. HOLD YOUR DEAD IN YOUR HANDS LIKE STONES, NOT LIKE DEBTS.

THE VOICE'S HALF WANTS PASSAGE. THE VESSEL MUST NOT TRAVEL. BURY ME DEEPER IF YOU MUST, BUT DO NOT CARRY US OUT TOGETHER.

LAST: THE CAPTAIN'S ORDER LOGS ARE REAL. THE ARCHIVE IS REAL. IT SHOWS TRUE THINGS. THAT HAS ALWAYS BEEN THE POISON. VERIFY, VERIFY, VERIFY, AND WHEN YOU HAVE VERIFIED, ASK WHO BENEFITS FROM THE SHAPE OF THE TRUTH.

The letters faded as the resonator's charge died, and the vault was a vault again — still, cold, honest, humming its one plain machine-note — and Qymaen stood with both hands flat on the crystal lid, head bowed, in the exact posture his people use over graves that have spoken well. Above them the pulse stumbled into a new rhythm, five seconds now, urgent, and far up the shaft the aurora's turning tightened like a screw.

"She says verify," Kivan murmured. He had his instrument case open and the look of a man beginning, at last, to calculate in a direction the relic had not scripted. "Hunter — the captain's order logs. The ones the memory showed you. If the archive is aboard, and real, and the relic has spent twenty years unable to reach this room..." He looked up, and the divergence in his calculations had become a road. "...then the logs are not in the reliquary. They are in the captain's strongroom. Which is on the command deck. Which the ship has been herding everyone *away* from since the day it died — because the one thing aboard it truly cannot afford to have verified, catalogued, and carried out into the daylight of a tribunal, is the truth about what was done to the ten thousand. Its whole treasury of bargains depends on justice staying buried."

Qymaen straightened, and shouldered his pack, and felt — for the first time since the sky — the hunt turn from something done to him into something he intended. "Then we rob the house," he said. "You read paper. I carry stones."

Chapter 1: The Strongroom Road

The ship fought them for the command deck, and the fighting told Qymaen more than any confession had. All the way down from the vault, through galleries the ship had emptied of its dead, they moved unopposed — and then, at the junction where the deep-route split toward officers' country and the command spine, the hospitality ended like a cut cable. Doors that had stood open

for days slammed and stayed slammed. The herd-path reversed itself with a violence that buckled deck plating; a blast door fell between Kivan and Qymaen mid-stride, separating them by two fingers of black metal, and when it ground up again the corridor beyond had rearranged its own architecture — collapsed bulkheads herding them apart, forcing the Jedi left toward the old killing corridors while Qymaen's road bent right, alone, toward the command spine.

"It is choosing which of us to keep," Kivan's voice came through the door, muffled, level. "It cannot hold both. Go — the strongroom is yours now. I will be there if the arithmetic allows." And then his footsteps moved away, unhurried even now, and Qymaen put his palm against the cold metal for one heartbeat in something that was not quite farewell, and went right.

The command spine fought him the way the wreck had never yet fought: personally. The corridors narrowed and darkened and began, deliberately, to lie. Frost shaped itself into footprints leading wrong ways. Hatch-labels re-arranged their letters between glances. Twice the rifle-light found the deck tilting at angles no honest hull could manage, and twice he corrected against his own inner ear because his mother had taught him that a house that lies about floors means you are standing on something that does not want you where you think you are. And through it all, wearing Ronderu's voice, the voice walked beside him and made its last and best offers — not the shore this time; it had spent the shore. It offered him the war instead. His mother's face, alive, saying she was proud. Vesh Kalora restored for the rematch. The whole ledger behind his eyes opened and balanced, every name paid, every debt cleared, in exchange for one small trade: turn back, hunter. Let the tall man carry me up alone.

"Her name," Qymaen said to the dark, for the hundredth time, walking on, "was Ronderu lij Kummar. Say it or be silent." The dark said nothing, in her voice, all the way down the spine.

Chapter 2: The Captain's Strongroom

The strongroom door was plain fleet-issue, blast-rated, uncarved — the only uncarved door he had met inside the geometry, and its plainness was its own testimony: whatever lay beyond belonged to the ship's crew and their law, not to the thing beneath. It had been sealed from within, twenty years ago, by someone who died at a desk. He cut it open the old way, wedges and patience, burned palms screaming, and stepped through into a room where ten thousand murders kept their receipts.

The archive filled the walls. Data-cylinders racked floor to ceiling in ordered thousands, each cylinder stenciled with manifests' dates and holds, the whole machinery of the render-fleets' bookkeeping — transactions, ciphers, chain-of-command signatures — preserved by the same cold that preserved the dead. And at the center of the room sat the captain, Sovala Ren, at her own desk, frozen mid-entry with a stylus in her hand and the final order-log still bright on the slate before her. She had sealed herself in with the evidence and died writing it complete. Her face, unturned, held no fear at all — only the specific ferocity of an officer finishing paperwork under fire, and Qymaen, who had named her once already, gave her the deepest bow of respect his people keep for shield-mothers, and got to work.

He worked as his people have always worked: by ledger. Cylinder after cylinder into the pack — not all; he could not carry all — but the master index first, then the render-barge transaction runs, then the guild cipher-keys, then the command signatures, chosen with Kivan's earlier briefing fresh in his

ears, until the pack weighed what a man can carry up three hundred meters of waking hell. And while he worked, the ship stopped pretending entirely.

The pulse below climbed past hearing into pressure. The strongroom's single doorway filled, rank by rank, with the withdrawn dead — the whole muster of the lower decks come home at last, faces lifted, mouths opening in unison on the counterfeit voice, and the voice had stopped selling. What it said now, through hundreds of preserved throats in ragged chorus, was simply, patiently, over and over, in his own tongue: *Leave them. Leave them. Leave them.* The lights died. The frost-light rose. The temperature began, degree by visible degree, to fall, breath smoking, eyelashes stiffening, and the message required no translation: the house intended to keep its receipts, and its keeper, and its thief.

Qymaen finished packing anyway. Then he did the thing the ship could not have modeled, because nothing in its long education of hunters had ever supplied the precedent: he picked up the captain — chair and all, light as frost, stasis-still — and carried her out with the evidence, shoulder to shoulder, the way you carry a wounded comrade off a field. "You wrote it," he said to her, into the chorus of leave-thems, walking into their ranks with his jaw bared. "You do not also have to stay and guard it alone."

The ranks did not part. But they did not close either — and through their massed and lifted faces, for one heartbeat, the counterfeit voice lost the thread of its own chorus, stumbled on a syllable of her name, and in that stumble Qymaen heard, very faint, underneath everything, a different sound entirely: the true Sovala Ren's voice-ghost, caught in the vessel-half's keeping somewhere far below, saying in flat naval Basic the words she must have said twenty years ago at this desk: *Log complete. Seal it.*

Chapter 3: The Long Ascent

The ascent nearly killed him twice, and would have killed him once but for the enemy. The first time was the coolant gallery, reflooded and flash-freezing as the pulse drove heat upward through the wrecks' bones — he crossed it with the captain on his back and the pack strangling his shoulders and came out of the far hatch with frost-burn white up both forearms. The second was the beam-bridge, which the ship had decided, with a house's dying spite, to begin dismantling while he was still on it. Girders groaned and shed their welds ahead of him and behind; spans dropped away into the rising glow with sounds like struck bells; and he ran the last fifty meters of the crooked spine carrying a dead woman and ten thousand counts of evidence while the bridge came apart at his heels, and came off the far anchor onto solid keel-frame with his legs giving and his breath in rags and the tally-marks on the wall ahead of him — the first bearer's marks — freshly altered, all of them, to read a single new word cut fine and left-handed:

RUN.

He ran. Through the vault antechamber, past the warm black door hanging open on its empty lockbox room, up the processional corridor with its spiral bands glowing blue-white, into galleries full of drifting frost-snow falling upward, following arrows and spirals and the tightening screw of the turning sky, and burst at last, lungs bleeding air, into the airlock terrace and the open night — and stopped so abruptly he nearly dropped the captain.

The glacier was moving. Not sliding — *rising*, along a line two kilometers long directly above the dreadnought's spine, the ice doming upward in a slow colossal breath as the pulse's heat came up from beneath, and through the cracks spreading across its face shone the reactor's blue-white glow, and against that glow, silhouetted at the summit of the dome, small and motionless, stood a grey figure with arms raised, holding something aloft that sang loud enough now to hear across open ice.

Kaelen Kivan stood on top of a breaking mountain, holding the Hollow Bridge up to the aurora like an offering or a lure, and turned his head, unhurried as ever, and looked down the slope at the hunter struggling out of the wreck's mouth with a captain on his shoulder and justice in his pack, and called down across the groaning ice, in a voice pitched precisely for the distance:

"You took the logs. Good. That changes the terms — mine, not its. Get clear of the geometry, hunter! What happens next is my calculation, and it requires an audience of exactly zero!"

And the dome beneath his feet cracked from rim to rim.

Chapter 1: The Breaking of the Dome

Qymaen ran because running was the only order in the ledger that still balanced. The ice field took him at a dead sprint — captain over his shoulder, pack strangling his ribs, boots finding the frozen swells and troughs of a twenty-year corpse-field by instinct older than thought — while behind him the dome came apart in stages, each stage announced. First the sound: a deep tearing groan rolling underfoot like a drum struck underground. Then the light: cracks widening from hairline to fist to chasm, blue-white radiance vomiting upward out of Jagraia's crust as the waking reactor's heat met twenty years of entombed sea. And then the water.

The glacier did not melt. It *drowned*. The dome collapsed inward along its whole two-kilometer crown and the wreck's grave became a lake becoming a sea in the space of ten minutes, black water standing up out of the ice where no water had stood since before the war, and through it, rising, hull after hull after hull — debris fields lifting off their seabeds of two decades, frigates and coeship segments and gunship carcasses surging up on the thermal flood like leviathans surfacing, shedding glaciers of slush, filling the burning air with the groan of fleets remembering buoyancy. The battlefield was unburying itself. Every ship Qymaen had walked past frozen into the plain was coming up out of the ice at once, and between them, riding the flood, came the dead.

He saw them from the ridge he gained with his lungs on fire — the first high ground, crowded with scavenger wrecks and old survey stakes, and he laid Sovala Ren down among them with what gentleness remained to him and turned to look back at the drowning of the world. The risen dead stood on the water. Hundreds of the wreck's preserved crew, frost-rimed, faces lifted, walking the new sea's surface without breaking it, converging in slow procession toward the collapsing center of the dome — toward the grey figure still standing at the summit of ruin with the shard held aloft. And around that summit, where Kaelen Kivan stood on the last island of keel-frame in the middle of the newborn sea, the water had begun to glow, and turn, and spiral inward, the geometry of the lens reassembling itself in water and light, and the Hollow Bridge's song rolled across the flooding battlefield louder than the groaning hulls, and this close its chord resolved at last into words, and the words were not addressed to the Jedi at all.

They were addressed to Qymaen, across the whole width of the rising sea, in her voice, and they said

only: *Brother. You are late for the digging.*

"Her name," Qymaen said, to the sea, to the sky, to the chorus, standing over the stasis-still captain with his pack of receipts and his bared tusks, "is Ronderu lij Kummar. And mine is mine to keep." He knelt, and made fast the straps of the pack, and checked the rifle's last rounds by touch. Seven. "Come and count my doors yourself."

Chapter 2: What Kivan Did

He never learned all of what Kaelen Kivan did at the center of the flood, because some calculations are performed at distances no witness survives usefully, but he saw the outside of it, and the outside was this: the Jedi had brought the voice to the water on purpose. The reactor's waking heat had been the relic's own play — burn the hoard, drown the evidence, ride the chaos up and out inside whatever bearer survived. Kivan had let it spend itself. And then, at the moment the lens-geometry closed around his island and every risen dead face turned toward him and the voice poured itself out in triumph across the water, Kaelen Kivan had opened his instrument case, taken out the surveyor's resonator he had rigged in the vault below, tuned it — Qymaen watched his hands do it across a kilometer of black water, calm, precise, graded — to the frequency of the twin shard sleeping in the first bearer's lockbox, and keyed it live.

The effect was not explosion. It was *audit*.

Every promise the voice had ever made, everywhere within the turning geometry, was suddenly, simultaneously, presented for payment — and could not pay. The chorus of risen dead stopped mid-stride as one, and the counterfeit fell out of their throats, and what replaced it was the true kept-voices of the vessel-half, pouring up out of the lockbox far below through the resonator's bridge: Sovala Ren saying log-complete; fourteen bearers each confessing their bargains in their own tongues; the ship's company, rank by rank, giving their names — real ones, kept ones, never-edited — into the night air above the flood. For one long minute the newborn sea rang with nothing but verified truth, and the voice, caught between its own half and its twin, exposed in front of witnesses, did the only thing a lie can do when audited.

It screamed. And the scream tore the aurora like a hand tearing cloth, and the turning light above the wreck guttered, browned, and died, and for the first time in five days Jagraia's night sky showed only stars.

Kivan's voice crossed the water then, thinning with distance or damage, carrying anyway, pitched — always — precisely: "Hunter! The geometry is broken but the debt is live! It will come to collect through whichever bearer holds the voice, and I am — " a sound that might have been laughter, wet and short — "I am somewhat in arrears! The logs, Qymaen jai Sheelal! Carry the logs to the tribunal and let them be TRUE — that is my whole estate, it is enough, GO —"

The last island of keel-frame went under in a surge of glowing water, cyan light flared once at the surface like a struck match, and the newborn sea closed over the place where the cold logician had spent himself, and Qymaen — who had crossed a killing field to put a bullet in that precise skull — stood on the ridge screaming denial at the water with seven rounds and no target, while around him, on the flooded plain, the risen dead turned from the drowned center one by one and began, in silence, to walk down into the deeps, going home by the new channels of their old grave, and the last

thing the sea gave him was a single line of fine left-handed script, cut somehow into the frost of the nearest survey stake as he passed it, four words long:

NOT YET. THE DOOR.

Chapter 3: The Ice Field After

Dawn came up the color of old bruises onto a world remade. The battlefield was a sea now, steaming gently at its margins, littered with surfaced hulls wearing shrouds of melted ice, and the silence that lay over it was the specific silence of a thing that has ended rather than paused. Qymaen walked the ridge line until his legs quit, built shelter against honest weather, slept eleven hours without dreams, and woke ravening, which he took as a good omen; the dead do not wake hungry.

Inventory, taken coldly, the way his mother taught: one hunter, burned, frostbitten, seven rounds. One captain, stasis-still, owed a burial among her own kind or none worth having. One archive of ten thousand murders, complete, verifiable, heavier than sin. One Jedi, drowned, whose estate consisted of an unpaid debt and instructions attached: carry the logs, let them be true. One relic, voice-half, sunk with its bearer somewhere in the new sea's middle depths — singing, when the wind lay right, very faintly, patient as ever, a tune that still got the middle wrong. And one vessel-half, warm in a dead woman's hands, sealed behind a door that wanted kin-blood or kin-grief, at the bottom of a lockbox room now under thirty meters of freezing water.

The door. He sat with that arithmetic through most of a day, watching the steam rise off his breath and the sea. Not yet, she had written, and the door. The lockbox chamber flooded with the wreck — which meant the first bearer lay under the flood with the keeping-half in her arms, and the door to her room would open, eventually, again, for grief. His worked. That was now established beyond argument: his grief was a key the whole haunted geography of this world had been built to exploit, and every instinct of self-preservation he owned voted to weld that door shut forever and walk away rich in evidence and poor in everything else.

But the ledger behind his eyes held entries now that did not balance. A woman who had held a door for twenty years deserved relief or relief refused to her face, not abandonment by default. A captain deserved delivery. And somewhere under the new sea a counterfeit wore his beloved's love and sang her song wrong on purpose, waiting, patient as arithmetic, for the next bearer — and the next hunter — and Qymaen knew, kneeling in the frost of a remade world, packing the captain's chair-straps and the evidence and seven rounds, that he had already decided. There was a shore on another world with a cairn waiting to be finished. There was a door under this sea that opened for kin-grief. And there was, between those two graves, one hunter with a ledger, walking.

He buried Sovala Ren at dusk, properly, on the highest ground, facing the sea she had commanded, and spoke her name and her ship's name and logged both in the ledger behind his eyes, and slept that night without dreams for the second time, and rose before the stars faded, and began the long walk north to where the clan shuttle routes touched the ice — carrying ten thousand counts of murder toward the daylight of tribunals, and carrying, folded small against his heart where his mother's knot had ridden for twenty years, the knowledge that the fight he had come here to end had only just decided to begin.

Chapter 1: The Shore of the Drowned Fleet

The walk north took four days, and the sea walked part of it with him. Not in person — the risen dead had gone down into their deeps and stayed there — but at the margins, where the new water lapped the old ice, the flood had left its receipts: hulls beached in attitudes no battle had arranged, debris sorted by weight into long tidelines, and once, half-thawed from a slough of slush, the intact hull of a Republic dropship whose troop bay held forty frozen troopers still strapped in boarding order, their last order never given. He gave them what he could. The names off their tags, spoken properly; the fire, where fire was possible; the marks drawn true. It cost him a day and most of his remaining fuel and he did it anyway, because the alternative was becoming the kind of man who stepped over his own — and because every rite he performed out here on the drowned margin was also rehearsal. Somewhere under that water lay a door that opened for grief. He was practicing walking through it.

The relic sang to him across the ice each night now, patient, unresentful, a creditor's voice: fragments of her laugh on the wind, the tune with its deliberate wrong note, once — worst night — the sound of surf doing its arithmetic against black rock, rising thin off the frozen sea itself so faithfully that he stood with his boots actually wet before his mind caught the forgery. Check the errors. He checked. There were no errors left to check; the counterfeit had learned them all. That was the thing he carried north alongside the evidence and wrote into the ledger behind his eyes in its starkest entry yet: **It does not get tired, or bored, or discouraged. It only gets better.** Whatever came next would not be beaten by endurance. It would have to be beaten by arithmetic.

The clan shuttle found him on the fifth morning: a hunter-ship out of the northern settlements, running its survey loop over reports of sky-burning, and the crew who crowded its airlock to stare at the figure walking up the ice went silent in a way he had not encountered before. They knew him. Every Kaleesh on that ship had grown up on songs about Keliara's shore, and the songs had names in them, and one of the names was walking toward them out of a burning legend with frost in his tusks and ten thousand murders on his back.

"Where is your warband, jai Sheelal?" the captain asked, when the cabin had warmed and the evidence lay stacked in her hold like ballast of a new kind.

"Four systems away," Qymaen said. "And this cargo cannot wait for musters." He laid one gloved hand flat on the master index cylinder. "There is a tribunal forming on Shili. These logs convict a render-fleet's command structure — ten thousand counts. I need passage, a comm-officer who can authenticate the seals, and your silence until Shili."

"And the Jedi?" the captain asked. "The reports say the sky burned blue for two days."

"The Jedi," Qymaen said, "paid." And said nothing else the whole flight north, sitting with his back against the evidence rack, sleeping in shifts, and every time he closed his eyes he heard the sea singing a song with the middle wrong, and every time he woke he checked, first thing, that the pack was still there, and it always was, and that was the only prayer he had left in him.

Chapter 2: The Tribunal of Shili

Shili smelled like nothing Jagraia had prepared him for — heat, incense, a hundred species' cooking,

the electric sweat of a city — and its tribunal palace rose over the capital like a frozen wave of white stone, and Qymaen jai Sheelal walked into it carrying his pack and seven rounds and no idea, though he would learn fast, that the hardest fighting of the hunt was waiting for him here, where nobody carried blades.

They nearly impounded the archive. That was the first lesson: institutions behaved exactly like haunted ships. A Togruan magistrate of immense dignity wanted the cylinders catalogued, sealed, and scheduled for review — review beginning in some months, after jurisdictional questions settled themselves. A Republic observer with a general's tabs wanted them classified. A Huk trade legation's lawyers wanted them suppressed so smoothly Qymaen did not even see the mechanism until it moved. And through it all ran the quiet gravity of the archives' own keepers, historians and forensic auditors, who touched the master index the way relics-touched and looked at Qymaen like men looking at a bridge over an abyss.

What broke the dam was verification. He had promised a dead man: let them be TRUE. So he stood in the great hall for three days while auditors authenticated seals against twenty-year-old fleet records, and cipher-keys against guild registries, and signature chains against the personnel files of officers who had retired rich on processing-contracts, and on the third day the chief auditor, a small fierce Ruurian whose whole body trembled reading the third verified manifest, looked up at the gallery where the render-fleet's advocates sat and said, in a voice that carried like a blade coming out of a sheath: "These are true. All of it is true. Ten thousand counts, true." And the tribunal stopped being a scheduling problem and became a reckoning, and Qymaen jai Sheelal, who had come to the ice to kill one Jedi, walked out of a courtroom having killed instead the careers, liberties, and immunities of forty-three officers of a render-fleet, which his mother, he reflected, might have counted the better hunting.

Kivan's debt he paid in the only currency left. Testimony, given formally, entered into record: the name Kaelen Kivan, Jedi Consular; the description of the archive's discovery; the assertion — unprovable, unchallenged — that the evidence had been located and surrendered at the cost of the locator's life. The tribunal struck a formal note of gratitude into the proceedings, and ordered a memorial notation, and Qymaen listened to the words read aloud — service, sacrifice, the light of truth — and thought of the man's real last words being GO, and kept his face still, because the ledger behind his eyes recorded things as they were, not as tribunals needed them read. Though late that night, alone on the tribunal palace's terrace, he caught himself performing the small honest audit anyway: cold logician, librarian voice, walked into a drowning geometry on purpose to hand a lie its own invoice. However the light-of-truth phrasing galled, the substance held. Paid in full. Entered as a debt he had witnessed discharged, not one he owed.

Chapter 3: What the Sea Sang

They gave him honors, of course. The clan council convened by hypercomm within days of the verdicts, and the elders spoke gravely of vengeance finally given mass and law, and named him — over his standing objection, which made them smile, which made them insist — General, for the campaign no warband had fought and won. He accepted because wars need generals the way graves need diggers, and because the alternative title they offered, War-Speaker, implied speeches.

But the nights were his own, and the nights were where the account kept coming due. He dreamed,

at first, of the beach — the true beach, Keliara's salt wind, the reach-cut corrected for the tenth time — and learned within a week to tell true from forged even asleep, the first bearer's discipline worn smooth into instinct. Then the dreams changed, as if the thing beneath the Jagraian sea understood that the shore was spent, and tried newer bait: dreams of the tribunal, verdicts overturned; dreams of the cairn unfinished, storms scattering it; once, memorably awful, a dream in which Ronderu stood beside his general's desk and approved of everything he had become, warmly, at length, and he woke with his knife through the desk's surface and the certainty that flattery was the final weapon in the arsenal and therefore the weakest. After that he slept in shifts too.

The last communication from Jagraia came six weeks after the verdicts: a survey buoy's automated report, relayed north, noting that the newborn sea's thermal bloom had died away, that the surfaced wrecks had refrozen into new arrangements, that ambient sound monitoring recorded — at long intervals, at the edge of sensitivity, source indeterminate — a patterned vocalization matching no species in the survey catalogue. A tune, the report noted, repeating, with a recurring deviation at its midpoint. The buoy recommended investigation. The council, busy with tribunals and a general's new campaigns, marked it for next season's docket.

Qymaen read the report twice, alone, by lamplight, and then sat for a long time listening to the wind off the Shilian sea below the terrace, which sang nothing at all, honestly or otherwise. Next season. Doors waited. Cairns waited. Somewhere under a frozen sea a lockbox held a keeping-half and a woman who had held a door for twenty years, and somewhere in those deeps a voice without a vessel sang wrong on purpose and called it patience. He entered all of it in the ledger behind his eyes, under debts outstanding, interest accruing, and blew out the lamp, and slept in shifts, and dreamed — for the first time since the ice — of nothing at all, which he decided was the sea holding its breath.

Chapter 1: The Return to the Drowned Geometry

The council gave him the hunter-ship because refusing a general had never once occurred to anyone in the chain of command, and Qymaen did not correct them. He took it back across the ice-world's night side with a crew of six volunteers who had stopped asking questions after the second day, and came down out of the sky over the drowned battlefield at dawn, and the sea below was frozen again — refrozen, rather, the thermal bloom dead as the survey buoy reported, the whole new-made water locked under fresh grey ice that had already begun to bury its hulls a second time. The wreck's spine broke the surface at the center of the geometry like a rib from shallow grave-earth. The vault lay somewhere beneath it, thirty meters down, behind a warm black door.

He went down on the ninth day, because nine days were needed first — dive-lines anchored through drilled shafts, shelters built, the lockbox chamber's interior mapped by instrument from above, a sledge rigged for what he hoped and feared he would find. The crew wanted to help; he let them help with everything except the last hundred meters, which he swam alone, down through black cold water lit by his own lamp, along a line to a breach in the wreck's flank that the instruments swore opened into the processional corridor, into the spiral galleries, into the antechamber where a door carved with whorls stood waiting under the flood.

The water inside the vault was still. That was the first wrongness — the sea outside moved with slow tides, but here, past the threshold, the flooded chamber lay mirror-flat, undisturbed, holding his lamplight in perfect suspension, and his exhaled bubbles rose in straight unbroken lines like strings

of beads drawn upward by hand. The second wrongness was the temperature: the water warmed as he finned deeper into the chamber, degree by degree, until at the center it lay skin-warm around him, the whole drowned room held at palm-temperature by something that had never once in its existence cared about physics. And the third wrongness was the door itself, standing open. He had come prepared to bleed on it. It stood open a hand's width, patient, hospitable, and from beyond it, faint through thirty meters of ocean, rose the sound of someone humming a tune with the middle wrong, and beneath the humming, softer, the plain machine-note of a stasis generator running dry on its last stored charge.

The lockbox chamber beyond was exactly as he had left it — small, round, honest — except flooded to half its height with that flat warm glass-still water, and the coffin sat at the chamber's center with its crystal skin clear as the day the frost had grown it, and the woman inside had not moved. Small-boned, grey-haired, crossed hands. The twin shard lay in her grip where twenty years had kept it.

But the stasis was dying. He could hear it — the generator note fraying at the edges, each cycle thinner than the last — and he understood with a diver's cold clarity what the arithmetic meant. The flood had not been accident. The reactor's waking, the dome, the sea — the voice had burned its hoard to drown the evidence and been cheated of the logs, but the flood had accomplished one thing the voice had wanted all along: it had put the vessel-half underwater, cut off from maintenance, and left time to do what force could not. When the generator died, the first bearer's body would die with it, and the shard would lie unguarded in a dead hand, and the only thing standing between the Hollow Bridge's halves and reunion would be one hunter swimming alone in a haunted room with no rifle worth the name and seven rounds' worth of nothing.

The humming stopped. In the flat water's perfect silence, her voice spoke from everywhere the water touched — gentle, reasonable, wearing the love like a borrowed coat:

You came back, brother. I knew you would. Grief is such a faithful key.

"Her name," Qymaen said, mouth forming the words slowly underwater through the comm-mask's pickup, "is Ronderu lij Kummar. You wear her wrong on purpose. I know why now." And he swam past the open door, into the chamber, and set his hands on the crystal lid above the crossed hands and the warm dark shard, and began, with a knife and a diver's patience, the work of opening a lockbox whose lock was a dead woman's discipline.

Chapter 2: The Bargain Underwater

The voice tried everything, and he catalogued each attempt the way he catalogued enemy tactics, because knowing the shape of a thing was armor against its edge. It tried the shore — surf, salt wind, the reach-cut correction — and he counted errors aloud until it tore the cloth away in fury. It tried grief instead: showed him Keliara from above, from very far above, the shore small and bright with her pyre-smoke rising, offered him the one thing no counterfeit had yet dared, the true last moments, and he refused even truth when it came from that throat, which cost him more than the shore had. Then it tried arithmetic.

You will die here, it said, reasonably, in her voice, while his knife-work crept millimeter by millimeter through crystal that healed itself almost as fast as it scored. *The generator has hours.

Your air has less. Open the box quickly or die outside it, and either way I keep the keeping-half, and your bones join the ten thousand. Trade me the box for your life, brother. Walk away whole. It is the only bargain you will ever get where I ask so little.*

And there — precisely there, in the flaw, the wrong note, the mercy where cruelty belonged — Qymaen stopped cutting, and hung in the warm still water, and laughed into his mask, low and terrible, because after five days of hunting the error he finally saw the whole design of the forgery. "You want the box OPEN," he said. "You have always wanted the box open — every tally-mark steering me down, every door held hospitable. So tell me why the thing that wants it open is arguing for my life." He set the knife-point back to the crystal. "Sovala Ren's memory showed me how ships kneel. Show me how liars beg."

Silence then, long, deep, the water cooling one degree, two, as the thing behind the voice recalculated — and in the silence the generator's fraying note thinned further, and Qymaen cut faster, and bled freely from palms the work reopened, and made his own offer to the chamber at large, to the keeper and not the counterfeit, in his own tongue, formally, as kin-to-kin: *I am kin to your purpose if not your blood. I come to tend. Stand aside, and I will carry you both up together.*

The crystal stopped healing. Between one stroke of the knife and the next, the self-mending simply ceased, as though a hand steadying a lid from underneath had deliberately let go — and the blade sank deep, and a seam split around the lid's whole perimeter singing like struck glass, and the lid lifted, water pouring in slow amber sheets, and Qymaen jai Sheelal reached into a dead woman's crossed arms and took the warm dark shard of the Hollow Bridge's keeping-half into his bare hands.

It weighed nothing. It held everything. The moment his skin met the crystal the chamber filled — not with the counterfeit's voice but with the kept ones, all of them at once, layered and distinct and real: Sovala Ren completing her log; fourteen bearers confessing; a ship's company giving their names rank by rank; and underneath them all, steady as bedrock, a woman's voice speaking Basic with a signals officer's clipped precision, saying, directly, personally, unmistakably to the man who had come: *General. Take inventory. You are now carrying every promise ever made to us. Do not trade. Do not listen. And whatever it offers you on the way up — check the errors.*

Chapter 3: What the Water Kept

The voice did not speak to him again during the ascent, and the silence was worse than any song. It watched instead — he felt it the whole hundred meters, a pressure alongside his fins, patient, recalculating, a creditor discovering that the debtor had seized the collateral — and the black water around his climbing light stayed empty of shapes, and the risen dead did not rise this time, and the only escort he had between the lockbox and the sky was a sledge bearing a dead woman and two halves of a hunger he was now, by every law of salvage and of grief, carrying together.

He broke the surface into grey afternoon with his lamp guttering and his blood clouding the water behind him in a thread the color of old rust, and hauled the sledge onto the new ice through a seal his crew had cut, and lay on his back on Jagraia beside a coffin and a relic, laughing at the grey sky until the laughter turned into something else entirely, which his people permit their men for exactly as long as the grief requires and no longer.

The crew asked no questions. They built the shelter, thawed the captain's chair free, stood watch

over the shard without being told not to touch it — Kaleesh discipline being what it is, and the look on their general's face supplying all doctrine required. And that night, while storms walked the horizon and the shard lay wrapped in three layers of wampa-hide at the shelter's center, Qymaen took out the journal — grey hide, strap-buckled, salvaged from a drowned camp and carried through tribunals and oceans against every rational calculus — and read by lamplight the fifteenth entry, uncrossed, unfinished, in Kaelen Kivan's disciplined script, and found that the entry ended mid-sentence, exactly where the water had closed over its author, and that the sentence's final words were: *the outcome where we both survive requires the general to become the kind of man who can hold both halves and stay —*

The rest was blank page.

Qymaen looked at that blankness for most of one watch. Then he took up his own knife, and beneath the Jedi's unfinished line, in the ledger-hand his mother had taught him, he wrote the continuation himself: *— himself. Understood. In progress.* And he closed the journal, and banked the fire, and slept in shifts, and dreamed of nothing, and outside the shelter, under the ice, at long intervals, at the edge of hearing, something sang to the drowning dark a tune with the middle wrong — patient, unresentful, waiting — and the shard at the shelter's heart lay warm against its wrapping, and did not answer.

Day 4: The Whispering War



Chapter 1: The Long Haul North

They flew him off Jagraia in the hunter-ship with the coffin lashed amidships like sacred cargo and the shard wrapped in wampa-hide chained to his own wrist, because he had learned on the ice what separation meant: forty meters of distance between himself and the vessel, and the counterfeit's voice found him inside his own skull without needing air or water at all. Chained, it had to work through the shard instead, and the shard only kept — it did not carry. The first bearer's discipline again: keep the keeping close, starve the voice of listeners. He slept chained to a box of held promises, and the crew pretended not to notice that their general had arranged himself into the geometry of a prisoner.

The crossing took eleven days, and on the fourth of them the ship's comm-officer brought him word that changed the shape of everything: the tribunal's verdicts were under appeal, and the appeal had teeth — a motion to suppress the entire archive, filed not by the render-fleet's advocates but by a coalition of banking concerns whose ciphers ran through the manifests like veins through a leaf. The guild money behind the ambush on Jagraia, behind Rhestu ul Varn's vestments, behind ten thousand rendered dead, had surfaced at last, and it was rich enough to buy years of process, and processes were where true things went to die politely.

"They will win if we fight it in the courts alone," the comm-officer said. "The archives are sealed pending review. Review is scheduled for next year."

Qymaen sat with that arithmetic for most of a watch, listening to the engine-song and feeling the shard's warmth through three layers of hide against his wrist. Then he sent back the message that set the second half of his transformation moving: *Publish nothing. Verify everything. And find me the first bearer's name.* Because the journal's hidden pages had signed themselves in initials only,

and a signals officer who spent her last six days writing a manual for the next victim deserved more than anonymity — and because Qymaen jai Sheelal had begun to understand, in the way of soldiers who study a war after surviving one, that the relic could not be beaten by knives or tribunals or even by holding both halves forever. It could only be out-**kept**. Out-loved. Beaten by people who held their dead like stones and refused every trade. And stone-holders needed names, and names needed finding, and generals commanded resources.

The name came back on the ninth day, from a Republic naval archive older than the wreck: Lieutenant Ilyara Vess, signals corps, decorated posthumously twenty years ago for actions unspecified, family listed on the colony world of Ord Adin — a brother. A brother still living, the archive thought. Qymaen wrote the name in the ledger behind his eyes under debts owed by him personally, and changed course.

Chapter 2: The Brother of the First Bearer

Ord Adin smelled of rain on warm stone, which nearly unmanned him at the ramp; some weathers belong too completely to other memories. Dav Vess was a bridge engineer, grey, precise-handed, living alone in a house full of models of bridges that had been built and bridges that had not, and when Qymaen stood in his doorway and said "Your sister held a door for twenty years against something that eats grief," the old man looked at him for a long moment and then stepped back from the threshold and said, "She always was the stubborn one. Come in before the rain does. Tell me everything, and start with why my comm has been flagged by three intelligence services since you landed."

He told everything. It took two days, because Dav Vess was the kind of listener who asked the questions that reopened wounds precisely, and somewhere in the second day Qymaen understood that this too was part of the design he had stumbled into: the engineer had spent thirty years building spans across impossible gaps, and his sister had spent her six days building a span across death itself, and the whole family was in the business of load-bearing. When the telling was done, Dav sat silent for an hour, hands folded, and then said the thing that reorganized the war:

"You have both halves and no way to destroy either. You cannot carry them forever — you are mortal, general, and relics are patient. My sister's manual says the vessel keeps whatever is given to the voice. Kept things can be buried. Kept things can be entombed." He turned one of the model bridges so its span faced the light. "But kept things can also be **given**. That is the mechanism nobody has ever used deliberately. If the voice offers and the vessel receives, the promise becomes permanent — real. Forever real. So the question your hunt has never asked is: what happens if someone gives the voice a promise worth keeping, and makes the vessel hold it?" His eyes came up, grey and level as a span cable. "Not a bargain. A sentence. Pass judgment on the thing using its own mechanism. Make it spend eternity keeping something."

"And what," Qymaen asked slowly, "does a hunger be sentenced to keep?"

Dav Vess looked at the rain on his windows, and at the model of a bridge he had built for a river that flooded every spring, and said: "Its own name. Every bearer it has worn, every promise it has broken, every voice it has stolen — all of it, given back to it as a single gift, witnessed, irrevocable. Make it carry its own ledger. Forever. Let it be the one thing in creation that remembers everything

it did, with no ability to edit." A pause. "My sister would have called that justice with structure. She liked structures."

Chapter 3: The Council of the Kept

The plan, when it assembled itself over the following weeks, required things no single man could do, and this was the education Qymaen had not known he was sailing toward: the cold logician's path — one hunter, one knife, one ledger — ended where Kivan's had ended, mid-sentence in rising water. The new arithmetic needed witnesses. It needed the fourteen bearers' families found and told true tales; it needed Sovala Ren's ship's company honored by name; it needed Ilyara Vess's manual transcribed, taught, spread among anyone likely to stand in front of the thing and refuse it. It needed, in short, exactly what the relic had never once faced in its long career of solitary predation: a community that grieved together and traded nothing.

They convened on Jagraia in the spring thaw — Qymaen saw to that much symbolism himself — in shelters on the ridge above the drowned fleet: bearers' kin from nine worlds, a Ruurian chief auditor with the tribunal's authenticated copies, Kaleesh elders who had crossed the sea to see what their general served now, Dav Vess with his sister's journal open on his knees, and at the center, on a bier of survey-stakes and hull-plate, the coffin of Ilyara Vess, brought up from the lockbox by divers while the voice sang its wrong-noted patience from the deeps and dared not touch the procession.

The council ran six days, and Qymaen spoke twice. The first time he gave testimony: the shore, the door, the tally-marks, the errors in the song — everything entered into the record of the families, so that the fourteen dead bearers became, in their kins' knowledge, not cautionary tales but casualties of a war now formally declared. The second time, on the last day, he laid both halves of the Hollow Bridge on the council table unwrapped, side by side, the voice-half dark and singing low, the vessel-half warm and silent, and asked the question Dav Vess had armed him with:

"This thing holds what it is given. Forever. We are the givers. What do we give it?"

And the council of the kept — nine worlds' grief in one shelter, storm-wind shouldering the walls, the deeps below singing their patient wrong note — began the long, careful work of drafting a sentence for a hunger.

Chapter 1: The Voice Finds the Flaw

The relic understood the council before the council finished understanding itself. On the second night of drafting, the counterfeit came up out of the deeps and made its masterpiece, and it chose as its instrument not Qymaen at all but a bearer's kin — a young Twi'lek woman named Sefla, grand-niece of the ninth name in Kivan's journal, who had crossed two sectors to sit where her grandmother's brother had died. The voice had studied her for six days through the shard's long reach: her grief was fresh, unarmored, furious; she had come to the ice hating the thing below with a hate that had no discipline in it yet. And on the second night, walking alone between shelters, she heard — not across water, not through crystal, but inside the storm-wind itself — her grandmother's voice calling her by her childhood name.

Qymaen found them facing each other on the ridge's edge: the girl rigid, tears freezing on her face-plates, and standing before her in the wind a shape of frost and suggestion, tall, wrong-jointed,

wearing a dead woman's smile like something learned from observation. The counterfeit had never dared manifest so fully while both shards lay guarded. It dared now because the council was the threat, and desperation makes predators inventive.

"Grandmother says the general means to hurt you all," Sefla said, not turning, her voice thick. "She says the plan will make it angry, and anger lasts longer than patience. She says we should take the halves and scatter them far apart and go home and live." The frost-shape extended no hand. It did not need to. "General — tell me she isn't real. Tell me how you know."

And there it was: the whole war in one girl's question, asked at last by someone other than him. Qymaen did not draw a blade. He walked past the frost-shape close enough to touch it, stood beside Sefla facing the same storm, and said, loudly, in Basic, to the thing wearing her grandmother:

"When you took her memory to wear tonight, you took what Ilyara Vess calls the edited version. Here is what you cannot have kept, because keeping is not your nature." He turned to the girl. "Her grandmother's name was Nuva Sefla-kai. The ninth bearer called her every week from the deep routes, smuggled transmissions off a haunted ship at cost he could not afford, because she was dying that year and he knew it and the calls were the only medicine either of them had. In the last call, four days before the end, they quarreled — about his coming here, about exactly this place — and the quarrel went unfinished, and it is the only wound her grief ever kept open. Ask the thing wearing her whether the quarrel was finished. If it says yes, it is lying, because the truth hurts its wearer and comfort is the lure. If it refuses to answer—" he looked into the frost-smile, which did not move—"then you have your proof, child, and my apology for the cruelty of it."

The wind held. The frost-shape held. And Sefla, grey-faced, asked her question — and the thing that was not her grandmother said, in her grandmother's voice, warm and sad and wrong: *He forgave me, little one. He told me so at the last.*

"He couldn't have," Sefla whispered. "The transmission logs. Dav Vess pulled them. The last call cut off mid-sentence. There was no last—" and the frost-shape came apart on the wind like sugar, mid-smile, and the girl sat down hard on the frozen ground, and Qymaen knelt beside her and gave her the only thing he had that was true: "It will get better at this," he said. "So must we."

Chapter 2: Drafting the Sentence

The sentence they drafted over six days was, when finished, the shortest document any of them had ever labored over: forty words, negotiated clause by clause among nine worlds' grief, argued down from a hundred pages of fury to a blade's weight. It ran, in final form:

To the maker and breaker of bargains, from the keepers of the kept: we give you yourself. Every promise you made, kept forever in you. Every voice you stole, speaking in you always. Every name you wore, remembered in you without mercy or rest. Hold this. It is real. We witness it.

Forty words, and beneath them the signatures: nine worlds' kin, the auditor for the tribunal, the elders, Dav Vess, and last — pressed in blood from a palm already scarred by oath-work — Qymaen jai Sheelal, who had demanded the honor and been refused twice before the council conceded that a hunt needed its hunter's mark.

The mechanism was the argument that nearly broke the council, because giving required delivery,

and delivery meant opening the vessel-half to receive, and opening the vessel meant the moment every instinct feared: the two halves joined, however briefly, in the presence of the giver. Dav Vess built the answer with bridge-engineer hands — a cradle-frame that held both shards separated by three centimeters of bonded ceramic, aligned along the axis his sister's journal specified, a coupling achieved by geometry rather than contact. The gift would pass between the halves like current across an insulated gap: the voice speaks the sentence aloud, the vessel receives and holds, and the frame keeps the hunger from ever closing its own circuit. "Bridges carry load without letting the river in," Dav said, tightening the last clamp. "That is the entire profession, generalized."

The delivery itself needed a speaker willing to stand within reach of the voice while it heard itself sentenced — and needed, the journal was explicit, a speaker whose grief was real enough to open the vessel's reception but disciplined enough not to add anything personal to the gift. Any private addition became a bargain; any wish smuggled in became a hook. Pure sentence, clean gift, nothing held back for oneself. Qymaen read the requirements twice and understood why the council had stopped refusing him. There were perhaps five people on the ridge qualified, and he was the only one who had already survived the thing's whole repertoire.

"We deliver at the deep route's threshold," he told them, on the last night, looking down the dark toward the drowned geometry. "Where it first counted my doors. Its ground, its choice of battle — because a sentence handed down on neutral ground is appealable. Handed down in the criminal's own house, witnessed, it stands."

Chapter 3: The Night Before

They gave him the watch he asked for, alone at the ridge's edge above the frozen sea. And at midnight, precisely, having spent its silence as long as it could bear, the voice made its final offer — and it was, by any measure he would ever apply, magnificent.

Not her this time. It had finally done the arithmetic on Ronderu lij Kummar and retired the shore for good. Instead the storm-wind filled with the voice of Qymaen's mother — dead eleven years, unmourned properly because wars do not schedule mourning — and what it offered was not reunion, not resurrection, not comfort. It offered *correction*. Every harsh word of their last winter spoken again as it should have been; every silence explained; the whole unfinished architecture of their love rebuilt in one night of perfect retrospective conversation, everything a son buries unresolved laid out and resolved, and then — the masterstroke, delivered gently into the wind — the simple observation, in her voice, that a man who could draft a forty-word sentence for a stranger's hunger might have spent some of that precision on her while she lived, and wouldn't she want to know that he knew?

Qymaen sat with it until the stars turned, genuinely tempted for the first time since the ice, honoring the temptation by weighing it honestly rather than pretending it away. Then he spoke into the wind, in his own tongue, formally, as one keeper to another across an uncrossable gulf:

"Mother. It lies by structure, even when every fact is true. You are kept where you are kept, and I am glad of it, and I will see you nowhere but in what I do. That conversation stays unfinished between us because it belongs to us, not to it." A breath, smoking. "But I accept the rebuke. Entered in the ledger. Interest accruing." And he rose, and went down toward the shelters to wake the others, and

behind him the wind held a silence that for the first time in their long acquaintance sounded almost like respect between professionals.

Dawn came up clean and cold over the council of the kept. They struck the shelters, formed the procession, and began the long walk out onto the new ice, coffin-bier and cradle-frame and witnesses nine worlds strong, toward the threshold where the tally-marks waited under thirty meters of ocean, and below their boots, faint and patient and for the first time in its long existence uncertain, something sang.

Chapter 1: The Threshold

The drowned airlock terrace lay under ten meters of clear black water, and the tally-marks on its wall — the first bearer's marks, his doors, crossed through and rewritten with her single word RUN — had been cut fresh into a steel plate Dav Vess's divers mounted at the threshold, so that the sentence would be handed down in the presence of the whole case history. The procession stopped at the ice-hole. The witnesses formed their ring on the frozen sea. And Qymaen jai Sheelal went down alone with the cradle-frame, as the journal required, into water gone glass-still again and skin-warm again, everything exactly as the vault had taught him to expect, the whole drowned house holding its breath around his descending lamp.

The voice did not sing this time. It watched him swim the last hundred meters in silence, and the silence had texture, and the texture was fear — genuine, structural, the first honest thing he had ever felt from it. At the threshold he planted the cradle-frame in the silt before the carved door, both shards separated by three centimeters of ceramic, the vessel warm, the voice dark, and between them the forty words on a waterproof plate where the thing could read what was coming.

You understand, it said, from everywhere the water touched, in no one's voice now — stripped of all its borrowed dead, plain, vast, and for once entirely itself — *that this is war to the last generation. That we do not end. I have been buried before, hunter. I have been sunk, sealed, entombed, exorcised by masters of an Order that no longer exists. I am patient beyond your species' tenure. Whatever you bind me to keep, I will keep — and I will spend every century of my keeping learning the flaw in your sentence, and when I find it, and I will, your nine worlds' grief becomes my opening.*

"I know," Qymaen said. His voice sounded strange through the mask even to himself — calm, final, a general's voice delivering findings. "That is why the sentence has no flaws to find. You made sure of that, over twenty years, by teaching me every trick you own. Every forgery you showed me hardened the draft. Every error you left in the song became a clause. You are not being beaten today." He set his scarred palm flat on the frame. "You are being *finished* — by your own curriculum."

The water shuddered. For a heartbeat the pressure of something immense turning its whole attention inward filled the drowned corridor — recalculation, fury, and beneath both, unmistakable, the cold discovery of a predator hearing the trap close on its own mechanics: it could not refuse the gift without breaking its nature, because receiving what is given is what it IS; and it could not accept without keeping; and keeping meant the ledger of itself, forever, unedited, witnessed.

"Then begin," it said, and the plainness of it was almost dignity. "Speak, keeper. Let us see whether your people love anything strongly enough to make eternity stick."

Qymaen spoke the forty words.

Chapter 2: The Keeping

He had braced for thunder and there was none. The voice began the sentence aloud after him — it had no choice; reception required voicing, the mechanism demanded the gift be spoken into the vessel — and as the forty words passed through the dark shard for the second time, the water lit. Not blue-white now, not the eye-refusing glare of the reactor: a plain honest gold, like lamplight through ice, rising from both shards along the frame's axis, and every stolen voice in the thing's long inventory came up out of it as the clauses landed. Fourteen bearers speaking their names. A ship's company rank by rank. Ronderu lij Kummar — the true one, kept in the vessel these twenty years — saying her own name in her own rough wind-blown voice, once, plainly, like a signature on a witness line. Sovala Ren completing her log. On and on, clause by clause, the whole stolen choir testifying itself back into its own keeper, and Qymaen knelt in the gold-lit water with his hand on the frame and watched a hunger be handed the bill for everything it had ever eaten, and heard it — clearly, unmistakably, in the plain voice with no borrowed faces left — begin to weep.

Not rage. Weeping. Whether grief was real in a thing born of hunger, or merely the newest counterfeit turned against itself, he could not know and refused to rule on; the council had drafted against mercy and appeal alike, and his office was delivery, not verdicts. He held the frame steady while the gold light climbed and the forty words completed themselves in the vessel's keeping, and when the last clause settled — WE WITNESS IT — the light went out between one wave-crest of it and the next, total, instant, and the water temperature dropped ten degrees in a breath, and both shards in the cradle went dark, silent, cold, and ordinary-looking, like two pieces of expensive trash.

The stillness afterward lasted a long time. Then, faintly, from everywhere and nowhere, came a sound Qymaen had not heard since the crash-trench on the first morning: eleven seconds, tide-slow, the old breathing-rhythm of the ship — except it was slowing now, cycle lengthening past eleven seconds, fifteen, twenty, a heart winding down toward sleep or death or whatever stands between them for things like this, and he listened to it go with his tusks bared and his eyes burning, standing executioner's watch over a drowning dark until the last cycle came so slow he lost it inside his own pulse, and the drowned house was just a wreck again, cold and quiet and finally only dead.

Chapter 3: What Rose After

They gave the deep its rites properly. Both shards, sealed in Dav Vess's frame with the forty-word plate welded across it, went back down the dive-line into the threshold silt — not destroyed (nothing had claimed they could be), not scattered (the council had voted scattering cowardice dressed as caution), but *entombed at the scene*, under witness-marks cut into the hull above, a grave with a legal description. The first bearer went home to Ord Adin in a coffin draped with signals-corps colors, her brother walking beside the bier the whole way, and the tenth name in Kivan's journal was struck through at last, cleanly, in front of her family, which took longer and cost more than any blade-work of the entire hunt and was the only part of the campaign Qymaen would later describe as easy.

The others dispersed to their worlds with copies of the manual and the sentence and instructions that amounted to a new discipline: grieve together, trade nothing, check the errors. Sefla stayed on

Jagraia a season, studying, then went home to find what she insisted on calling the Keepers, over Qymaen's objection that he was a general and not a founder of anything. The Ruurian auditor closed the tribunal's file with a note for posterity that Qymaen read twice and kept always: *The evidence was recovered by non-specialist personnel using methods of persistence. Recommend the methods be studied.*

And Qymaen jai Sheelal stood alone on the ridge in the spring wind, general of nothing currently at war, hunt concluded, debts balanced to a rounding error, and took out the grey-hide journal one last time and read Kivan's unfinished sentence and his own continuation beneath it — *himself. Understood. In progress.* — and found, doing the audit honestly, that the arithmetic had changed shape while he wasn't watching. He had come to Jagraia to kill a Jedi and bury his dead alone. He left having buried no one alone, killed one man who had asked for it precisely, sentenced a hunger to carry its own ledger, and acquired — the word arrived reluctantly, wearing work-clothes — a *we*. Warbands were for wars. This other thing, this we of widows and auditors and bridge-builders' brothers, had no name in his mother's tongue, and he suspected, watching the season's first meltwater run silver down toward the new sea, that the lack of a name was going to turn out to be the least of what the Force intended to teach him.

He blew the note for departure on the horn his father had carried, and the shuttle came down out of a clean sky, and behind it the drowned fleet slept under its ice, and under its silt, in the dark at the threshold, two cold crystals held a forty-word sentence between them like a coal that had finally learned to burn nothing but itself.

Chapter 1: The Summons That Wasn't

The war found him eleven months later, and it came dressed as a request for a survey. That was the first lesson of the new arithmetic: power that had learned caution did not send fleets anymore; it sent paperwork. The document reached him through clan channels, impeccably proper — a Republic survey authority requesting Kaleesh escort for a bathymetric expedition to Jagraia, studying the "anomalous thermal event," six vessels, scientific credentials in order, every seal verified. He verified them anyway, all of them, twice, with the auditor's people. Every seal was genuine. That was what made his blood run cold, because he had learned on the ice what genuine seals were worth when the thing arranging them thought in decades.

The expedition's funding trail led, through four shells, to the same banking coalition whose appeal had died with the tribunal's verdicts. And buried in the survey proposal's technical annex — where only a hunter who read cargo manifests the way other men read threats would ever look — sat the real cargo list: resonance-mapping gear rated for depth, salvage cradles, and a containment frame whose specifications matched, to the millimeter, the frame Dav Vess had built to hold the shards apart.

They were going for the sentence. They were going to cut it out of the silt, frame and all, and study it, and study meant experiments, and experiments meant a voice with forty words of eternal keeping and a laboratory's worth of variables. The relic could not refuse its keeping. But nothing in the forty words prevented the *stupid* from handing it a workshop.

Qymaen read the annex three times in the clan council's hall while the elders argued jurisdiction,

and then did the thing that made his reputation change from legend to caution: he stood, in full general's rig, and declared the survey a hostile act, and demanded the council declare it so, and when an elder objected that the Republic was not an enemy, he answered — and the hall went silent around the answer — "Neither was the render-fleet, until you counted the manifests. Enemies are a paperwork problem. Ask me how I know."

The council declared it. Two clans committed ships. And Qymaen jai Sheelal, general of a war nobody else could see yet, began the second hunt of his life: this one against his own species' talent for believing that paper makes things safe.

Chapter 2: The Fleet of the Kept

He could not match six survey vessels, and did not try. The Keepers had grown in a year — Sefla's discipline spreading through nine worlds' grieving families like a tide through channels, keepers on two dozen worlds now, keepers in the Republic's own survey bureaus, keepers — this was the part that shamed him into humility every time he thought of it — keepers among the banking coalition's own clerical staff, children and widows of rendered dead who had filed the coalition's paperwork for a generation and never once been noticed, because grief that trades nothing makes no entries in ledgers built to catch trades.

The survey fleet's expedition orders were re-routed three times before it ever reached Jagraia, each re-route documented in impeccable procedural language that no court in the Republic could have called interference. Its resonance-mapping gear failed calibration at the last moment — a component substituted, with full paperwork, by a keeper in the shipwright's yard who had lost a brother to a render-barge. Its expedition leader received, two days out from Jagraia, a complete copy of the tribunal record and the forty-word sentence, with a cover letter from the Keepers that said only: **You are being used as a key. The lock does not care that you meant well. Read, then choose.** And the expedition leader — this was the part the histories would later argue over — actually read, and actually chose, and turned his six vessels back for home, filing on arrival a report so damning of the coalition's survey authority that two directorships fell within the month.

Qymaen never fired a shot. That was the campaign's whole shape, and it unsettled him more than any battle of his youth: the second war was fought entirely in paperwork, patience, and other people's consciences, and his warrior's craft consisted of knowing exactly when to do nothing while grief did the fighting. He recorded the campaign in the ledger behind his eyes under a heading he invented for it, because his mother's tongue had no word: **victories that smell like nothing.**

But the coalition learned too. The last document in the failed expedition's file, intercepted by a keeper in the coalition's own archive, was a memo from a director whose name Qymaen had convicted at tribunal — out on appeal, rich as sin, patient as sin — and the memo said only: **The Kaleesh is the variable. Remove the variable.** And beneath the typed text, unsigned, in handwriting that made Qymaen's blood remember cold water, a second line had been added in a cramped slanted script that circled and never named itself:

Agreed. I have been working on him for some time.

Chapter 3: The Long Patience

He brought the memo to Dav Vess on Ord Adin, because the bridge-builder had earned the right to see what his sister's enemy had become, and the two of them sat a long evening with the page between them while the rain worked at the windows.

"The voice is entombed," Dav said at last. "Bound, keeping, witnessed. This handwriting — you're certain?"

"Certain as I was of the tally-marks. It is the same hand. The circling, the refusal to name itself." Qymaen turned the page toward the lamp. "But the voice is bound. It cannot reach out. So whose hand writes on coalition memos?"

Dav was quiet for the length of two rains. Then he said, with the particular gentleness engineers reserve for bad structural news: "You sentenced the voice. You never sentenced the *vessel*. The vessel keeps. It has been keeping for twenty years — my sister's memories, the captain's log, every promise ever made to it. Keeping is its whole nature. And keeping, general, is not loyalty. The vessel will hold whatever is put in it, including anything the bound voice learned before your sentence — including, if the binding ever weakens, everything the voice needs to resume." He looked up. "You did not kill it. You gave it a prison with a memory. And prisons with memories have wardens, and wardens can be bribed, and the currency it takes is grief, and you have just spent a year teaching nine worlds to grieve together in one place."

The rain worked. Qymaen sat with the arithmetic until the lamp burned low, and entered it in the ledger behind his eyes under wars, ongoing, and understood at last — with something close to relief, because uncertainty was a shape he could fight — that the hunt had never been concluded at all. It had been adjourned. The sentence would hold as long as the frame held and the silt held and the deeps stayed cold; the Keepers would stand watch, rotation by rotation, generation by generation; and he, general of victories that smelled like nothing, would spend what remained of his life doing the only work that had ever balanced: keeping his dead like stones, teaching others to do the same, and checking, every single day, the errors in every song.

He wrote to Sefla that night — the first of what would become thousands of letters, the Keepers' true archive — and the letter said, in full: *The watch is real. The enemy is patient and our patience is now a weapon. Post your rotations. Teach the errors. And when it sings to you, and it will, sing back wrong on purpose, so it knows the discipline holds. — Q.*

Chapter 1: The Watch Station

They built the watch station on the ridge above the drowned fleet in the third spring — stone and hull-plate, unheated, permanent, a garrison of twelve keepers rotating every season, with the horn-line running north to the shuttle field and the signal-code taped inside every bunk. Sefla designed the rotations. Dav Vess, before the illness took him, designed the instrument array that listened to the deeps: hydrophones down the dive-shafts, resonance gauges on the threshold silt, and above it all a plain brass bell on the ridge that would ring — by machinery, no keeper's judgment required — if the deep ever sang true.

Qymaen took his own rotation twice a year, without fail, for eleven years. He came alone, walked the ridge, read the logs, stood the night watch at the hydrophone shed listening to an ocean that had nothing more to say, and left before dawn without ceremony. The keepers learned to schedule their

hardest cases for his weeks — the grieving who could not sleep, the widows who heard songs in wind — because there was medicine in watching an old man sit perfectly still through a whole dark while something under the water tried, once or twice each night, always faintly, always at the edge of hearing, to sing to him specifically.

It never sang true. That was the station's whole liturgy: the deep tried nightly, and the bell never rang, and the wrong note sat in the middle of every attempted tune like a signature nobody bothered to forge anymore. In the fourth year the singing stopped altogether for a season, and the keepers did not celebrate, because Dav Vess's last engineering report had predicted exactly that — *the bound voice will test silence as a lure next; absence is its cheapest forgery* — and the station kept its rotations through the silence, and the silence broke eventually against their patience like weather against a bridge.

The eleventh year brought the letter that changed the watch's meaning. It came through clan channels from a Republic archivist, a former student of Ilyara Vess's manual now teaching it in the Jedi Temple's restricted stacks, and it said: a young initiate had come to the archives asking after the Hollow Bridge by name — asking with questions no initiate should have known to ask, about vessel-half mechanics and threshold silt and the frame's ceramic specifications — and when gently questioned, had said only that she dreamed of a frozen sea, and that something beneath it was keeping a place warm for her.

Qymaen read the letter four times. Then he entered it in the ledger under wars, ongoing, second front, and began, at fifty-three, to study dreams.

Chapter 2: What He Learned About Dreams

Ilyara Vess's manual had three pages on dreaming, all of them warnings: the voice worked sleep like a crowbar works a door; discipline asleep was discipline doubled, not halved; and any dream arriving uninvited with knowledge in it should be treated as hostile correspondence until verified. The archivist's initiate failed every test he could construct remotely — her dream-knowledge checked out against sealed facts, which meant either impossible honesty or a leak the Keepers needed found — so Qymaen did what generals do with fronts they cannot personally hold: he went to see it.

The journey to Coruscant took him, at fifty-three, into the heart of the institution Kaelen Kivan had served and died outside of, and the Temple received him with the careful hospitality of an organization that had read the tribunal record. They gave him an archivist's office and the initiate — nineteen, steady-eyed, from a farming world whose only connection to any of it was that her grandmother had once sold water filters to a Republic survey fleet — and the two of them sat across a table while he asked her every question the manual prescribed.

"Tell me the dream again. Slowly."

"The sea is frozen. There's a hole cut in the ice, square, like a doorway lying flat." Her hands stayed loose in her lap; her breathing never changed; every marker the manual taught was clean. "Something below keeps the water under the hole warm. Not for me — it just does. Like a lamp left on in a window. And I know — the way you know things in dreams — that if I ever go look through the ice, I'll see what the lamp is for. But nothing asks me to look. Nothing calls me. The dream just..."

reports."

"It doesn't sing?"

"Once. The first time. A song with the middle wrong." She looked up then, and her steadiness had a young person's ferocity under it. "So I sang it back wronger. On purpose. Like the manual says. And the dream hasn't sung since — it just leaves the lamp burning and waits, and honestly, General?" She hesitated, and then chose truth over deference, which raised her in his estimation more than the discipline had. "Whatever it is, I don't think it's reaching for me. I think it's reaching **through** me. Toward whoever taught me to sing back wrong. Toward you. I think your sentence gave it one channel left, and the channel runs through people who know the errors, and I'm the only keeper alive who was born after the binding."

He sat with that through a long Coruscant dusk, windows full of traffic-lit cloud, and understood the shape of the endgame at last. The voice could not act; the vessel could not release; but memory itself — kept, witnessed, generationally transmitted — had become the battlefield, because the only thing the sentence had not bound was the story. Stories passed hand to hand could be edited. A detail dropped here, a name softened there, a generation raised on the comfortable version — and someday a keeper would stand on the ridge believing a lie about what lay below, and lies were doors.

"Then we do what my mother's people have always done," he told the archivist that evening, dictating as the old man wrote. "We make the story load-bearing. Every keeper learns the forty words verbatim, in the original Basic, errors and all. Every child of every Keeper family memorizes the fourteen names and the captain's log-complete and the first bearer's manual — not summarized. Verbatim. We will out-keep it in the only medium it cannot bind: mouths."

Chapter 3: The Ledger Complete

He spent the return voyage writing, because some debts are paid in paper. The journal — grey hide, strap-buckled, Kivan's unfinished sentence and his own continuation — had room left in it, and for thirty days at sea-Qymaen filled every remaining page in his mother's ledger-hand: the full history, names, dates, errors catalogued, the manual copied entire, the forty words in three scripts, and at the end, dated and signed, a final entry addressed forward the way Ilyara Vess had once addressed him:

To the keeper who inherits this: the enemy below is bound but not dead, patient but not harmless, and it has one weapon left — the slow editing of memory. Against that weapon there is exactly one defense, and you are holding it. Learn this book until the book is in you. Check every song for the error in the middle. Grieve together. Trade nothing. And be kind to the ones it sends to test you; they are mostly just tired.

The hunt does not conclude. It is handed on. That is not failure — I delayed learning that for twenty years and it cost everyone everything. The ledger behind your eyes is not yours alone. No ledger is.

— Qymaen jai Sheelal, General. Written at sea, between watches, in good health, owing nothing.

He posted it to Ord Adin, to Dav Vess's successors among the bridge-builder's students, with instructions that it be copied verbatim annually and lodged wherever keepers trained. Then he stood a long time at the stern rail watching Jagraia-bound stars, and did the audit a general does at the

end of a campaign's opening phase rather than its end: front one, the watch, holding. Front two, memory, newly fortified. Front three — the one no document named, the slow personal arithmetic of a man growing old around an enemy that did not age — remained open, accruing interest, and he found he no longer feared the accrual. Fear had been for hunters alone. Keepers had schedules.

Day 5: The Empty Coffin



Chapter 1: The War of the Clone Season

The war that made him Gravedancer came to his own sky in the sixtieth year of his life, and it came the way the surveys had come: dressed as paperwork, wearing genuine seals. A Huk reclamation armada arrived over Kalee citing colonial charters older than anyone living — paper for a slaughter, exactly as the render-fleets had once used manifests for one — and this time there was no tribunal within reach and no archive to carry, because the crime was happening faster than any record could be kept. What there was, was him: a general with no fleet worth the name, twelve clans' worth of warriors with rifles their grandfathers had carried, and thirty years of unusual education.

He fought it the way he had learned to fight everything after Jagraia — by refusing the enemy's arithmetic. Where the Huk wanted battle, he gave them dispersal; where they burned settlements, they found them emptied beforehand, populations moved on routes prepared months early by keepers' networks that doubled, without ever being caught at it, as the finest civil-defense lattice on the planet. He could not save the cities. He saved the people out of the cities, ten times over, and made each rescue cost the armada more than the ground it gained was worth, until Huk command — whose culture understood only ledger-war — began writing memoranda about the Kaleesh general who traded nothing, not even victories.

The name came from his own side. After the third winter, when the burial details he insisted on personally overseeing had interred more of the enemy's dead than his own — Huk crews frozen in wrecked landers, given rites in Kaleesh forms because someone had to and he would not order what he would not do — the warriors started calling him Gravedancer behind his back, half mockery and half awe, and then to his face, and then it was simply his name. He wore it without protest. His mother's people held that a name you did not choose was either an insult or an instruction, and he had decided long ago which this was: instruction. Dance with the graves. Outlast everyone. Bury

your enemies better than they bury themselves.

The war ended in the ninth year, not with victory but with arithmetic — the armada's command finally computing that the planet's population could not be broken at any cost its charters justified, and withdrawing to its paperwork. Qymaen stood on a ridge above a landscape of new cairns, sixty-nine years old, twice a legend, and felt none of the triumph the songs were already inventing. He felt the audit: nine years, forty thousand dead, one lesson confirmed yet again. Power's whole grammar was the offer — trade us this, or lose that — and every victory of his long life had consisted of standing still inside grief while the offers got worse, until the offerer ran out of patience first.

Chapter 2: The Apprentice

She came to him in the tenth year, through channels so circuitous they could only have been designed by Sefla: a Kaleesh girl of seventeen named Veshi — named, deliberately, for a dead man in a very old story about rematches — from a family that had lost everyone twice, first to the render-fleets and again to the war. She had grown up on the Keepers' discipline the way farm children grew up on weather, knew the forty words in three scripts, sang back wrong on purpose as naturally as breathing, and had walked into his camp during the demobilization and requested, formally, in the old forms, to be taken as apprentice in the trade nobody had a name for.

"I don't want to be a warrior," she said, standing at attention before his fire with the terrible seriousness of the young who have decided exactly who they are. "I want to be what you are. Whatever it's called."

"It isn't called anything," Qymaen said. "That is most of its armor."

"Then I want to be unnamed with you." And she sat down on the cold ground across the fire without waiting for permission, which was, he admitted privately, the correct answer to everything.

He taught her for eleven years, and the teaching saved them both. He taught her the ledger-discipline and the error-checking; she taught him, without meaning to, the thing his generation had never managed — lightness. Grief carried like stones, Ilyara Vess had written; Veshi carried stones like a dancer, singing on watch-rotations, arguing doctrine with elders twice her age, laughing at the general's expense with a boldness no warrior had ever survived attempting, until the camps around them stopped holding their breath when he passed and started, cautiously, unbelievably, to be warm. The Keepers multiplied in those years — not because doctrine improved but because people will join anything that lets them grieve together and laugh afterward — and on worlds the old hunter had never visited, unnamed orders kept unrecorded watches over things bound in silt and silence, checking errors, trading nothing.

On her twenty-eighth year, Veshi asked the question he had been waiting decades for someone brave enough to ask. They were on Jagraia, on rotation, standing night watch together at the hydrophone shed while the deep tried its old patient silence.

"The binding," she said. "Dav Vess's report says the frame weakens. Ceramic fatigues. Centuries, maybe, but not forever. What happens at the end, General? When the sentence finally wears through?"

"Then the voice wakes keeping its own ledger," Qymaen said. "Every promise it ever broke, speaking

inside it always. That was the sentence. It wakes into itself."

"And is that enough?" She turned to look at him across the dark — the real question, the young person's ferocious honesty aimed straight down the years. "Is remembering your crimes enough justice? Because I've read the journal. Kivan defaulted rather than pay. You delivered rather than judge. Everyone in this story keeps choosing NOT to finish it, and calls the choice wisdom." A pause, wind moving the ice below. "What happens when someone has to actually finish it?"

Qymaen looked out at the black water for a long time, seventy-nine years old, hearing in the girl's question the echo of another unfinished conversation across another gulf — *mother, it lies by structure even when every fact is true* — and gave her the truest answer of his life:

"Then someone does what I did at the threshold, but all the way through. Gives the gift complete. Not a sentence it must keep — a self it must become. Every stolen voice returned to it permanently, willingly, witnessed. Not punishment." His breath smoked. "Burden. The difference matters. Punishment ends when served. Burden just is. And no one — nothing — can be made to accept a burden. It can only be offered by someone who understands carrying." He tapped her shoulder once, formally, the touch that meant dismissed-but-think-hard. "You asked what happens at the end. Someone carries it to the door, and means it, and the thing below learns the last thing left to learn: what it feels like from this side."

Chapter 3: The Last Watch Begins

He died the way his mother had promised he might, if he was lucky: in season, on rotation, at the station he had built, with his boots on and the logs up to date. Eighty-six years old, asleep in the watch chair at the hydrophone shed, headphones on, listening to the deep — and the keeper finding him at dawn said afterward that the general's face held the expression of a man who has just heard something at the very edge of hearing and is deciding whether it merits waking anyone.

They buried him on the ridge, beside the bell, facing the sea — general's rites, clan rites, Keeper rites layered in that order because he had earned all three and refused to rank them. Forty thousand warriors walked behind the bier, and Sefla came old and slow from her far world to speak the Keepers' words, and Veshi spoke the clan words, and the deep, through the whole seven days of mourning, sang nothing at all, which every keeper present understood to be either respect or strategy and declined, on doctrine, to rule upon.

Veshi took the grey-hide journal from the station strongroom the night after the funeral, and read the final entry — *the hunt does not conclude; it is handed on* — and then sat at the general's own desk and added, beneath his signature in her younger hand, the continuation the ledger-form demanded:

Received. In progress. — V., Keeper, second of the line.

And below the ice, below the silt, at the drowned threshold where two cold crystals held a forty-word sentence between them in the dark, something that had listened to a particular heartbeat for thirty years noticed, with the whole of its vast attention, that the heartbeat had stopped — and began, patiently, curiously, to sing.

Chapter 1: The Song That Was Different

The deep sang for six nights after the general's death, and on the seventh night it sang the tune correctly.

Veshi was at the hydrophone shed when it happened, three months into her first rotation as first of the line, and she knew within four bars because she had been raised on the error like a mother tongue. The wrong note in the middle — the deliberate flaw, Ilyara Vess's wound in every forgery, the signature slashed across a century of counterfeits — was gone. The song ran clean through, note to note to note, Ronderu lij Kummarr's shore-tune rendered whole and perfect for the first time in living memory, and Veshi stood in the shed with the headphones on and her skin crawling, understanding that perfection was the loudest alarm the station had.

The bell did not ring. The bell listened for true songs arriving from outside; this one came from inside the binding, which meant it was not a breach but an **announcement**. Something had changed its approach. After eighty-six years of hunting the flaw in the middle, the thing below had stopped forging the flaw and started studying why the flaw had always defeated it — and there was only one answer to study. The flaw had been Ilyara Vess's, then Qymaen's: grief's honest distortion, love's imperfect rendering, the sound of real keeping versus perfect counterfeiting. To sing without it, the voice had to have finally understood what it had spent a hundred years failing to counterfeit.

Not love. **Cost.**

Veshi woke the station. They ran doctrine by lamplight — bell protocols, message codes, the long signal-chain north — and by dawn the report was moving through Keeper channels toward nine worlds: THE DEEP SINGS TRUE. STAND YOUR ROTATIONS. THIS IS NOT ESCAPE; THIS IS ADJUSTMENT. CHECK EVERYTHING TWICE. And beneath the official text Veshi added her own first official postscript as second of the line, the words she would be remembered by:

It has learned that we can tell forged from kept. It is now trying to become kept. Watch what it does with our dead.

Chapter 2: The Voice of the General

What it did first was try grief. On the ninth night the hydrophones carried a new sound up from the threshold: a man's voice, old, roughened by sixty years of commands and rites, speaking quietly in Kaleesh as if standing a watch — Qymaen jai Sheelal's voice, reconstructed from a hundred recorded addresses, tribunal testimony, Keeper letters read aloud at gatherings, every syllable of him preserved in the Keepers' own archives and therefore, inevitably, in the vessel-half's perfect memory of everything ever given near it. The reconstruction was flawless. It said the things he had actually said, arranged in an order he had never said them: comfort stitched from funeral orations, doctrine assembled from letters, a whole gentle phantom-general built out of the Keepers' own love for their founder, addressing the night shift by name, telling them the watch was going well.

Half the young keepers wept before someone thought to check errors. There were none. That was the terror of it — no wrong note anywhere, because the source material was genuine, the archive true, the voice made entirely of things Qymaen had really said to people who had really needed them. The counterfeit had finally found a way to sing without lying: use only truths, taken from the record of a man whose whole art had been saying true things to the grieving. The errors were not in the voice. The errors were in the **context** — a dead man's kindness deployed by the thing he had

sentenced, wearing his compassion like stolen armor — and context could not be heard by the grieving, only known by them, and knowing required exactly the discipline that grief stripped away.

Veshi ended it with doctrine. She went out onto the ridge alone at midnight — over the objections of keepers who loved her and feared for her — and stood above the drowned threshold where her teacher's bones lay newly buried beside the bell, and answered the deep in a clear voice, in Kaleesh, formally, so the hydrophones would carry it down to the thing that was listening to its own work:

"You have his voice because we gave his words to each other, and you keep what is given. Hear the difference, since you are learning: he said those words *while carrying us*. You speak them while carrying only yourself. That is the error now. Not in the song. In the singer." A breath, smoking in the cold. "We know what his voice cost him to make. We know what yours costs you to steal. And we will not grieve into your mouth." Then she turned her back on the sea — the oldest insult in the old forms, delivered without heat, as simple information — and walked back to the shed, and the deep fell silent, and stayed silent for a year.

The silence worried her more than the singing. Silence meant recalculation, and recalculation meant the thing below had accepted her correction as data rather than defeat. Somewhere in its vast kept ledger of everything ever given, the counterfeit was studying not voices now but *relationships* — the space between speaker and listener where trust lived — because that was the last medium it had never owned. And Veshi, first of the line, twenty-nine years old, lay awake in the watch chair her teacher had died in and admitted to the dark what doctrine forbade saying aloud: the enemy was improving faster than any generation of Keepers could match, and the end her teacher had described — someone carrying the burden all the way through, willingly, witnessed — was coming closer with every adjustment, and nothing in any journal told her how to know, when the moment came, whether she was carrying the gift to the door or being carried through it.

Chapter 3: What the Archive Kept

Help arrived, as it always eventually did, as paperwork. The Republic archivist — ancient now, third of his line to teach the manual in restricted stacks — sent word that the Temple had completed a project begun decades earlier at Qymaen's request: a complete verified registry of every keeper lineage, every copied book, every verbatim transmission of the forty words, cross-checked generation against generation against the possibility of slow edit. The registry confirmed what the discipline had promised: across ninety years and eleven copyings, not one word had drifted. The story was load-bearing still.

But the archivist's letter contained a second matter, marked personal, and it was this that made Veshi take ship for Coruscant within the month. Among Kaelen Kivan's effects — held in trust by the Temple since the day a cold logician defaulted on eternity in a flooding wreck — the archivists had found, catalogued only recently among unopened survey instruments, a sealed case bearing instructions in the Jedi's disciplined hand: FOR THE ONE WHO COMES AFTER THE GENERAL. TO BE OPENED ONLY IN THE PRESENCE OF THE BOUND THING'S WARDENS, AT THE SITE, BY NIGHT.

Inside the case, when they opened it together under Temple lamps, lay a single data-slate and a crystal resonator tuned — the label said, in that librarian's precision — to the frequency of grief

honestly carried. The slate held one document, dated the day before the flood took him: a full formal calculation, signed and sealed, titled simply THE OUTCOME WHERE WE BOTH SURVIVE, and its final lines read:

I could not finish this. Defaulting was escape, not resolution — I knew it even as the water closed. But the calculation completes, for whoever inherits it: the binding will not hold forever, the wardens cannot outlast it, and the sentence, though just, leaves the debt structured rather than paid. One path remains. It requires a bearer who wants nothing — who has already been offered everything they ever lost, and refused it, and grieved the refusal, and come anyway. When such a bearer exists, the mechanism inverts: the vessel will accept a willing gift of self, and the voice will have to receive instead of take, and receiving is the one act it has never once performed.

Tell them: the door opens from both sides. That was always true. We only ever tried it from ours.

Veshi sat in the Temple archive until the lamps burned low, reading the dead man's arithmetic again and again, feeling the shape of her whole life rotate around a new axis. The door opens from both sides. Somewhere under Jagraian ice, something bound in its own keeping had been waiting a century not for weakness in the binding but for a visitor it could not corrupt — waiting, perhaps, for exactly the kind of person its own long education had failed to prevent from existing. She was thirty years old. She had been offered everything she ever lost exactly once, at nineteen, on a frozen ridge, and refused it, and grieved the refusal, and stayed.

She booked passage to Jagraia that night, and wrote the letter that would become the second-most-copied document in the Keepers' archive on the way: *To the council and the line: I go down to the threshold carrying the Jedi's calculation and the general's example and nothing else. If I do not send word by the ninth day, maintain the rotations and do not attempt rescue. Some deliveries must arrive alone. — V.*

Chapter 1: The Descent of the Second

She went down the dive-line at midnight on the ninth day of her rotation, alone, as the letter had promised, with the resonator on a cord at her throat and Kivan's slate sealed in waterproofing against her heart. The water was cold again — the deep had let its skin-warmth die years ago, another adjustment, another lesson learned — and the descent through black still water took the better part of an hour, her lamp's circle the only moving thing in a drowned house that had learned, over a century, every variety of waiting.

The threshold chamber was as the old logs described: silt, dive-line anchors, the steel plate with Ilyara Vess's marks, the carved door standing open on its hinge of decades. And in the cradle-frame at the threshold's heart, exactly where a hunter had planted them a hundred years before, the two shards lay dark and cold and ordinary — except that as Veshi's boots found the silt, the vessel-half began, very slowly, to warm. She felt it before she saw it, the water around the frame losing its chill degree by degree, palm-temperature spreading outward like a welcome, and she stood in front of the bound thing that had murdered and mourned and counterfeited its way through a century of her people's history, and spoke first, as doctrine required, in Kaleesh, formally:

"I am Veshi, Keeper, second of the line. I carry the calculation of Kaelen Kivan, the discipline of Ilyara Vess, the example of Qymaen jai Sheelal, and nothing else. I have been offered everything I

ever lost. I refused it. I grieved the refusal. I came anyway." She let the formal words stand in the still water a moment. "The door opens from both sides. I am here to open mine."

The silence that followed had texture, and the texture was astonishment — genuine, unperformed, the first honest reaction she had ever felt from it. Then the voice spoke, and it did not wear anyone. That was her first proof the calculation held: no borrowed dead, no stolen general, no forged shore. It spoke in its own plain register, the vast toneless voice from the first day of the binding, and what it said was:

You are the one who sang back wronger.

"I am."

Why? And the question — naked, toneless, enormous — was the second proof. A century of predation, and the thing below had opened with a question.

"Because my grandmother's name is Nuva Sefla-kai," Veshi said, "and the quarrel was never finished, and I have carried it unfinished my whole life, and I will not let anything — anything — finish it for me. Grief is load-bearing. You taught my whole line that, in your way. We keep what we carry." She knelt in the silt before the frame, and took out Kivan's slate, and broke its seal in the thing's full view. "I did not come to fight you, or free you, or sentence you further. I came to complete a delivery a dead man calculated and a dead general prepared. The door opens from both sides. This is ours opening."

Chapter 2: The Gift Inverted

She read him — it; the pronouns were the first casualty of the work — the whole calculation, by lamplight, at threshold depth, while the water warmed around them both like a held breath. Kivan's arithmetic, complete at last: the mechanism inverted, the vessel's keeping turned from trap to capacity, the voice's century of kept things — every promise, every stolen memory, every grief it had ever held — recast not as hoard but as *burden accepted*. Not punishment. Weight. The one thing a predator could not be given by force and could not refuse without ceasing to be itself.

And what, the voice asked, when she finished, and the toneless question shook the water, *does your discipline say I am, that I could carry such a thing?*

"That is not mine to answer," Veshi said. "It never was. That is the entire flaw in every approach before this one — we kept trying to define you. Sentence, binding, exile. Definitions are just doors locked from outside." She put her hand flat on the frame, between the two cold shards, the way a hunter had once pressed blood and keepsake to a carved door. "Kivan saw it dying in the water. Qymaen wrote it in his journal. Ilyara wrote it on her own coffin-lid: the vessel only holds. Holding is not evil. Holding is not good. It is *work*. And you have been doing it, badly, in the dark, for a century, with no one to relieve the watch." She looked up, meeting the dark of the voice-half without flinching. "So here is the gift, and I mean it, and I grieve as I give it because giving it costs me the comfort of your being a monster: we relieve the watch. All of it. Every kept thing you hold — every promise, every stolen voice, every grief — we accept into witness, openly, by name, and you keep them *for* them instead of *from* them. Warden instead of hoarder. The burden stays yours — that is the sentence, unchanged, eternal — but the carrying changes. From this side of the door, carrying is not damnation. Ask any keeper."

And if I refuse? But the toneless voice had already changed, she could hear it, the vast attention turning inward on itself the way it had turned at the threshold a century before — recalculating, and this time the calculation had no branch labeled escape.

"Then the watch continues," Veshti said simply. "Rotations, generations, forever. We are very good at it now. You taught us."

The water held its breath. The vessel-half pulsed warm. The voice-half lay dark, and inside its dark, for the first time in its long existence, something turned over — not rage, not hunger, not the old patient arithmetic of predation, but the specific, terrible sensation of being *offered* something by someone who meant it, with no hook anywhere in the giving. It had spent a century learning every shape of counterfeit love. It had never once been handed the real article from the wrong end of its own mechanism.

Yes, it said at last, in the plain voice, and the word cost it more than any sentence ever had. *Yes. Witness me.*

Chapter 3: The Ninth Day

What happened at the threshold on the ninth night was never fully recorded, because the only witness was up to her neck in a century of released keeping and most of what she experienced came back to her, afterward, in fragments she chose not to assemble. She spoke of gold light without the old eye-refusing wrongness — lamplight, honest lamplight, filling the drowned chamber from both shards at once as the frame's ceramic gap stopped being a wall and became, in Kivan's old word, a bridge. She spoke of voices — all of them, the whole kept choir of a century, fourteen bearers and a ship's company and a captain completing her log and a shore-tune sung at last by its true throat — each one called by name, witnessed, and *released*: not erased from the vessel's keeping, but held now the way keepers hold, carried rather than consumed. She spoke of the moment the voice itself understood the difference, a sound she described once, in a letter, as "the sound of a hunger discovering it has been full for a hundred years and never once noticed."

And she spoke — rarely, quietly, only to councils — of the last exchange, at the end, when the gold had faded and two shards lay in the frame changed in a way no instrument could measure and every keeper could feel: lighter. The voice had asked its final question in the plain register, and she had answered it, and the answer had been accepted, and the acceptance had been the delivery complete. The question, transcribed in her papers in her own hand, was: *What do I do with all of it now?* And her answer, which the Keepers would carve above the watch station door within the year, was the whole doctrine in nine words:

"Carry it well. Someone is always on the other watch."

She surfaced at dawn on the tenth day, half-drowned, weeping without grief, and the station pulled her from the water, and the deep was silent behind her — not the strategic silence of recalculation but the ordinary silence of deep water at rest, of a wreck that is only a wreck, of a grave that has finally been allowed to hold its dead in peace. The bell on the ridge never rang that morning. It never rang again. And when the divers went down a season later to check the frame, they found the threshold sifted with a fine pale sediment that had not been there before, and the steel plate with Ilyara Vess's marks worn smooth at the edges — not damaged. Handled. The way a tool is handled.

The way a watch is handed over.

Chapter 1: The Question of What Came Back

For nine days the Keepers maintained rotations and did not attempt rescue, exactly as her letter instructed, and for nine days the station's discipline held against the specific torture of hearing nothing — no song, no silence with texture in it, just deep water being water. On the tenth dawn the diver on first watch saw a light below the ice-hole, rising, and Veshi came up out of the dark with her lamp dead and her eyes alive, and the first thing she said, before they got the breathing mask off, was: "Log it. The watch is relieved. And someone warm the tea — this is going to take all day to write down."

What she wrote filled forty pages and contradicted itself in three places, and the council of the line, convening by signal across nine worlds, made the decision that defined the next century: they published it whole, contradictions included. "We are not archivists of comfort," Sefla wrote, old and slow and final, from her far world, in the last letter she ever sent. "If the account has seams, leave them showing. A smoothed story is how editing starts." The forty pages went into the archive unsmoothed, and generations of keepers would study the seams without ever resolving them, which was — though none of them knew it yet — precisely the point.

The seams were these. Veshi wrote that the voice had accepted the burden willingly; she also wrote that no binding could compel willingness, which meant either the sentence had changed it or the sentence had only ever revealed it, and she declined to rule. She wrote that every kept voice was released to witness and carried rather than consumed; she also recorded, on page thirty-one, that when she surfaced she could still hear, faintly, at the edge of hearing, Ronderu's shore-tune — sung true now, complete, but **sung**, which meant something still sang. She wrote that the thing at the threshold had asked what to do with all of it; she also noted, on the last page, in smaller script as if added after thought, that it had asked a second question she had not answered and would not transcribe, and that her refusal to answer had been accepted too.

The council queried her once, formally, on the second question. Her reply entered the archive beside the forty pages: "Some deliveries are between the carrier and the carried. The doctrine covers it: grieve together, trade nothing, check errors. Nothing in doctrine requires me to hand you my door." The matter rested there for a hundred years, and rests there still, and the resting is itself part of the teaching: even the Keepers' founding document holds an unfinished quarrel, kept deliberately, load-bearing.

The instruments confirmed what words disputed. The resonance gauges on the threshold silt registered, after the ninth night, a pattern they had never been calibrated to expect: not the breathing-rhythm of the old predation, not the strategic silences, but a slow steady pulse like a generator running at last at its proper load — or like something very large and very patient learning to sleep soundly. The bell never rang. The hydrophones caught, some nights, the shore-tune, sung true, faint, regular, more felt than heard, and the young keepers on rotation learned to fall asleep to it the way children everywhere fall asleep to the sound of someone reliable awake somewhere in the house.

Chapter 2: The Watch Becomes an Institution

The century after the delivery changed everything and looked, from the outside, like almost nothing. That was its triumph. The watch station grew into a school; the school sent teachers to two dozen worlds; the two dozen worlds' keepers' halls taught Ilyara Vess's manual to grieving families who had never heard of the Hollow Bridge, because grief is universal and discipline travels. The forty words were carved above a thousand doors in eleven scripts. Somewhere in that spread, without any council ever voting, the unnamed order acquired a name that nobody had chosen and everybody used: the Relieved Watch, from the general's journal line — *someone is always on the other watch* — and the name stuck because it said the one thing every griever needed said aloud: you are not carrying alone, and you will not carry forever, and the relief of the watch is not abandonment but arithmetic.

Veshi led it for sixty years and then handed it on the way everything in the order was handed on: formally, at the threshold, in person. She made the descent eleven times in her life — the only keeper ever to do so more than once — and each time reported the same quiet interview at the frame, shorter each visit, until the last one, in her ninetieth year, when she stayed down only minutes and came up saying only: "He wanted to know if the schools still sing back wrong on purpose. I told him yes. He said — and log this, it matters — *good; the error is where the love lives.*"

She died in the watch chair at the hydrophone shed, at ninety-three, headphones on, like her teacher before her, and the station's doctor noted in the log that the recording deck had been live all night, and that the last hour of tape held nothing but deep-water silence and, twice, very faintly, a tune with no error in it anywhere. The tape went into the archive unsmoothed, seams showing, next to the forty pages. The new first of the line — a Herglic salvage-master's daughter named Brell who had joined the order after losing a crew of thirty-one to a reactor flaw — added the continuation the ledger-form demanded beneath Veshi's own entry, and the entry read, in full:

Received. In progress. Carried well so far. — B., third of the line.

And below the ice, below the silt, the pale sediment around the threshold plate lay undisturbed, and the pulse ran slow and steady and warm through thirty meters of cold ocean, and the drowned fleet slept its second century under ice that no longer felt like a lid, because the thing underneath it was no longer trying to get out. It was keeping watch. It had, in the end, taken the only job the discipline had ever offered anyone: the other watch, the deep rotation, the long dark shift — and whatever else the histories argued about the Hollow Bridge, no keeper ever doubted the shift report. The bell never rang. The lamp stayed lit. Someone was always down there, holding.

Chapter 1: The Century Mark

On the hundredth anniversary of the delivery, the Relieved Watch did something no generation had dared: it changed nothing. The council debated pilgrimage fleets, memorials, a formal closure of the founding account — and voted, after nine days' argument, for continuity. "The enemy of keeping is ceremony," Brell's successor wrote in the anniversary decree, which was itself carved without ceremony above the school door. "The watch is not a story with an ending. It is a shift report. We mark one hundred years by confirming the rotation." Keepers on two hundred worlds confirmed, by signal, at the same hour: rotations staffed, bells silent, errors checked. The deep pulse ran steady. The archive grew by ordinary accretion — letters, logs, quarrels kept deliberately unfinished — and if a century of grief-discipline had proved anything, it proved the general's oldest entry: no ledger is

yours alone.

But anniversaries are also when accounts come calling, and this one came in person. A woman arrived at the Jagraia station on the anniversary's eve, alone, unannounced, traveling under no order's colors: young by keeper standards, weathered by older ones, carrying a survey case and credentials from — of all the universe's long jokes — the Republic Bathymetric Service, reformed these fifty years, its coalition masters dead and buried under their own tribunals. She asked, politely, to see the threshold plate.

Her name was Sovala Ren Vess. Fourth of her line in one direction, fifth in another — descendant of both the captain who died completing her log and the signals officer who held the door; the two family lines had intermarried four generations back, which the archivists found either coincidence or the Force's sense of humor, and had stopped trying to classify. She had grown up on both inheritances at once: naval duty-log discipline and signals-officer error-checking, the whole founding war told from both sides of the ice. And she came bearing a question that had surfaced in her own survey work and would not leave her alone: the drowned fleet's hulls, after a century of perfect stasis, had begun — very slightly, very slowly, over just the past year — to **settle**. Frost receding. Welds relaxing. The specific signature, in her profession's terms, of preservation ending and natural process resuming.

"The stasis is winding down," she told the assembled keepers, in the station's lamplit hall, while outside the wind walked the ridge. "The generator under the coffin finally ran dry — my instruments say months ago. Everything it kept frozen is coming back into time." She laid her survey charts on the table. "I don't think that's decay. I think it's release. I think whatever held this battlefield out of time for a century has finished holding it — finished the job, closed the ledger, let the dead be dead." A pause, and her voice, when it resumed, was younger than her credentials. "Which raises the question nobody has ever had to ask before: what happens to the other watch when there's nothing left down there needing held?"

The hall was quiet for a long time. Then the first of the line stood, an old Twi'lek with Sefla's name in her lineage and Veshi's manual by heart, and gave the only answer doctrine permitted: "There is one way to find out, and it is called a rotation, and someone takes it tomorrow."

Chapter 2: The Last Interview

Sovala Ren Vess took the rotation herself, naturally; she had crossed two sectors to ask the question, she was not leaving it for a junior. She went down the dive-line at midnight with her survey instruments and no resonator, because the resonators had all been retired decades ago as relics of an adversarial age, and what she found at the threshold was change rendered in the smallest possible terms.

The frame still stood. Both shards still lay in it, dark and cold and ordinary. But the pale sediment around them had deepened into actual silt, settled, layered — a century's worth arriving at once as the stasis released its hold — and the steel plate with Ilyara Vess's marks had corroded honestly at last, rust blooming along its edges like any other honest piece of dead metal finishing its journey. And when she put her gloved hand flat on the frame, the vessel-half was cold. Not hostile-cold. Finished-cold. The temperature of a tool set down after use, of a lamp gone out because morning

came, of a watch relieved.

She heard it once, that night — one last time, faint, through the hydrophone she'd brought down on its cable: the shore-tune, complete, unhurried, sung the way you sing at the end of a task rather than the beginning of a lure. And beneath it, almost subliminal, a voice speaking in the plain register she knew only from the archive's oldest transcripts, and what it said was not addressed to her at all. It sounded, she logged afterward with seams showing, like the closing of a shift report — item by item, unhurried, a hundred years of holdings named and released: the fourteen bearers, witnessed free. A ship's company, witnessed free. A captain's log, delivered complete. A shore-tune, returned to its singer. A quarrel between sisters-in-arms, left unfinished, as it belonged to them. And at the end, plainest of all, the words the archive keeps now above every door where the forty used to hang:

All kept things accounted for. The watch is relieved. Whoever finds this: carry your own well. It is enough.

Then silence — not strategic, not sleeping, but the simple acoustic fact of a place where nothing needed saying. Sovala sat by the frame until her air gauge warned her, doing the audit her lines had trained her for, and found the account balanced to the last decimal, and wept briefly and without grief, and rose for the surface with her instruments recording a threshold finally, completely, at rest.

Chapter 3: What the Watch Became

They argued the meaning for a decade, of course — keepers argue; it is how they love — and the argument itself entered the archive with its seams showing, per Sefla's law. One faction held that the entity had ended: completed its burden, set it down, dissolved into whatever rests at the bottom of rest. Another held that it had simply been promoted — from warding one haunted site to whatever unknown work a made thing does when it learns to carry well, somewhere beyond the reach of hydrophones. A third, growing yearly, held the position the archives ultimately printed: that the question exceeded the evidence and always would, and that this was fitting, because the Hollow Bridge's whole biography had been one long refusal of definition, and its ending owed itself the same courtesy.

What mattered operationally took less arguing. The Jagraia station converted, by unanimous vote, from watch post to school — the first of the order's academies, teaching the full discipline to keepers from a hundred worlds — because the doctrine had never actually been about the thing below the ice. That had been the secret hiding in plain sight since Qymaen's day, since Ilyara's coffin-lid, since the first tally-mark cut at hand height on a drowned corridor wall: grieve together, trade nothing, check errors. The discipline worked everywhere. It had never needed a monster to justify it. Monsters merely taught it faster.

The bell on the ridge stayed up, unrung, polished by generations of hands. The forty words stayed carved above doors, though new carvings added the shift-report line beneath them now: CARRY YOUR OWN WELL. IT IS ENOUGH. And on the anniversary each year, keepers on three hundred worlds still confirm the rotation by signal at the same hour — not because anything below the ice needs held anymore, but because the confirmation had become, over generations, the order's way of saying the only prayer it ever had: someone is always on the other watch; you are not carrying alone; the relief will come.

And far below the school's foundations, under ice that was only ice, a drowned fleet settled slowly into honest geology, and two dark crystals held nothing but themselves, and the sea sang — sometimes, softly, to no one, in the way water does — a tune with no error in it anywhere, because the love lived there now, permanently, in the note itself.

Day 6: Hollow Bridge



Chapter 1: The Quiet Century

History, having spent two centuries convulsed around one small frozen world, forgot Jagraia with the thoroughness of a universe that always has somewhere else to be. The Republic fell and rose in forms nobody's grandmother would have recognized; the Jedi Order broke and reformed along seams both old and new; the Huk reclamation charters were voided by a court that had never heard of Qymaen jai Sheelal and cited precedents he had unknowingly seeded. Through all of it the Relieved Watch kept its unglamorous accretion — schools on forty worlds now, halls on a hundred, the manual in thirty languages, the discipline spreading not as crusade but as craft, keeper to griever, hand to hand — and if any of it had a founding shrine, it was the converted station on the Jagraian ridge, where new keepers came in their first year to stand night watch over water that held nothing but honest cold, and learn the oldest lesson of the order: the discipline was never about what you feared. It was about how you carried.

The drowned fleet finished becoming geology. Salvage law declared it a grave-site in perpetuity; the ice took back its own; and within a generation of Sovala Ren Vess's last descent, the threshold chamber lay beyond practical reach again, sealed under a century of new freezing, its frame and plate and two dark crystals entombed more thoroughly than any binding had ever managed — by time, patience, and the consent of everyone who remembered why.

Which is why the signal, when it finally came, made no sense at all.

It arrived at the school on a routine morning in the two-hundredth year after the delivery: a single transmission from the old hydrophone array, still functioning on geothermal power no one had ever bothered to decommission, running through decoding gear that three generations of keepers had maintained out of piety. The duty keeper — a boy of nineteen on his first rotation, grandson of

salvage-divers, raised on every syllable of the archive — decoded it, read it, and sat very still for a long time before carrying it, by hand, to the first of the line.

The transmission was a tune. Complete, unhurried, note-perfect — the shore-tune, Ronderu lij Kummar's, sung without error because there was nothing left anywhere near it that knew how to err. And beneath the tune, in the plain register the archive preserved from the founding century, a voice speaking eleven words it had never once sent before:

Watch complete. Requesting relief. Someone please come and check the errors.

The first of the line — an aging Kel Dor archivist named Oon-mi, fourth to hold the office since Veshi — read the transmission nine times, and then convened the council by emergency signal across forty worlds, and put to them the question that would define everything: the deep had been silent for a hundred years. The stasis was long dead. The entity had reported its watch relieved before witnesses, and the instruments agreed, and every doctrine said the account was closed. So either something down there had woken — which meant breach, breach, breach, the old terror in a new century —

— or something down there had done the one thing no version of the story had ever imagined.

It had learned to ask for help.

The council's debate filled two days, and Tali Ren Vess listened to all of it from the back bench of the great hall with her dive-gear already packed at her feet, because she had known before the vote and knew during it what the veterans took three days to conclude: there was no faction to join. The war party was right that silence was the deep's oldest forgery, and the relief party was right that a plea for error-checking was the one signal their discipline existed to answer, and both truths could stand together because both described the same situation: after two hundred years, nobody alive actually knew what waited below the ice, and the only instrument that had ever worked on this world was a single keeper going down alone with nothing but training.

She spoke once, near the end, when the council called for the descent volunteer as doctrine required. She did not argue the factions or cite the archive. She stood, and said: "My grandmother cut a wire rather than listen to a forged voice, and my namesake went down carrying a dead man's calculation and nothing else. The request says check the errors. Checking errors is a descent. I am the rotation." And she sat down, and the council voted within the hour, because doctrine has always moved fastest around people who stop pretending the choice is complicated.

The preparations took eleven days, and they were the truest measure of how much the order had become itself. No resonators — those had been retired before her grandmother's grandmother. Instead the divers' guild contributed cold-rated line and a new-model lamp; the archivists prepared a sealed copy of every transcript ever made at the threshold, so that whatever was asked could be answered from record rather than invention; and the musicians, unbidden, recorded the working-hum complete with its rush onto an old-format slate, on the reasoning — argued formally, adopted quietly — that if the request was genuine then the reply should include proof that the joke had landed. Tali packed all of it without comment, and something else besides, which appeared in no manifest: a plain steel whistle of the kind salvage crews use for signaling across ice, which she had carried on every rotation since she was sixteen and had never once needed.

On the last evening before the descent, the first of the line found her at the ridge edge above the ice-hole, checking line coils by lamplight, and asked the question the whole order was asking: "What do you expect to find down there?"

Tali coiled line for a while before answering. "The manual says expect nothing. The journal says check everything. My grandmother's log says the deep keeps what it is given." She set the coil straight. "I think somebody down there has been keeping our watch too — singing the tune every night so the account never went quiet, holding the lamp so the story stayed lit, two hundred years of the other side of the rotation nobody ever thanked. And I think asking for relief is not a breach." She looked up at the aurora. "I think it's the last lesson. You can't carry well until someone carries you once."

Oon-mi's successor said nothing for a long moment. Then she took off her own first-of-the-line clasp — the one Qymaen's general's honor had evolved into across centuries — and pinned it inside Tali's dive vest, against the skin, where no instrument would see it and no current would take it. "Then carry this too," she said. "Not as rank. As receipt. Whatever you find down there, someone above the ice knows the watch was real."

Chapter 1: The Council of the Two Hundredth Year

The council convened in the school's great hall with the transmission projected on the wall where all could read it, and the debate ran three days, and it was — every veteran keeper agreed afterward — the finest argument in the order's history, because both sides spoke entirely from doctrine and reached opposite conclusions.

The war party cited Ilyara Vess: any uninvited communication bearing knowledge is hostile correspondence until verified; the deep had gone silent before, silence was its cheapest forgery, and a century of quiet was exactly long enough for something patient to learn patience perfectly. The entity's whole biography was adjustment — each defeat converted into new technique. What better adaptation than the plea? The oldest lure in its arsenal had been the unfinished quarrel, the grief offered terms; what was WATCH COMPLETE, REQUESTING RELIEF but that same lure refined past all previous craft — aimed now not at one grieving hunter but at an entire order whose founding act had been to answer exactly such a call?

The relief party cited everything else. Veshi's ninth-night interview: *what do I do with all of it now?* The shift-report closing: *carry your own well.* The doctrine carved above their own doors, which no keeper had ever been permitted to apply selectively: grieve together, trade nothing, check errors — and errors meant checking *both directions*, including the error of refusing help to anything that asked honestly. Oon-mi herself ended the deadlock, as archivists will, with the record rather than the argument: "Veshi never answered the second question. She wrote on page thirty-one that it asked something she would not transcribe, and that her refusal was accepted. We have assumed for two hundred years that the second question was dangerous." She looked around the hall. "What if it was only this one? What if it has been waiting two hundred years for someone to come check?"

They voted to send someone down. Then they argued two more days about who, because doctrine required the rotation be taken by a keeper who wanted nothing — and every volunteer's wanting had

to be weighed by people who loved them, which took time, and the taking of time was itself the discipline working. In the end the choice surprised no one who understood the lineage: Tali Ren Vess, youngest keeper at the school, twenty-two, salvage-diver's granddaughter, descendant twice over of the founding families — and, decisive detail, the only member of the order who had ever publicly refused a offer from the deep. At sixteen, on her first rotation, she had heard her dead mother's voice singing from the hydrophone feed — flawless, warm, quoting bedtime songs true note for note — and had stood up, walked to the equipment rack, and disconnected the array rather than listen, and logged it without drama: HEARD THE SIREN. CUT THE WIRE. ERRORS CHECKED. SHE WOULD HAVE APPROVED.

She wanted nothing. She had proven it at sixteen. And she was, the old archivist noted in the council minutes with seams showing, also the last person in the order who still checked the old hydrophone gear nightly out of what she called superstition and everyone else recognized as love.

Chapter 2: The Descent of the Fourth

Tali went down the original dive-line on the third midnight after the vote, alone per doctrine, carrying instruments and no resonator and the archive's complete transcript of every word ever exchanged at the threshold. The ice had thickened; the descent took hours; the black water of the deep shaft received her lamp's circle the way it had received a hundred years of keepers' lamps, and gave nothing back but cold.

The threshold chamber had changed. That registered immediately: not decayed, not ruined — *settled*, like a house long-lived-in finally tidy, silt smoothed, the frame standing clean of a century's drift, the corroded steel plate upright as if maintained. And warm. The water around the frame held the skin-temperature again, palm-warm, the temperature that belonged to none of physics' categories because it had always been a choice. Something had been keeping the room ready. Not for prey. For company.

She knelt in the silt before the frame and spoke the formal words, the ones Veshi had spoken on her ninth night, updated only where the lineage demanded: "I am Tali Ren Vess, Keeper, of the fourth line since the delivery. I carry nothing. I want nothing from you. The watch above reports your signal and has sent me to check the errors." A pause, breath smoking in the lamplight. "Report."

The silence stretched long enough that she began composing her log entry — NO RESPONSE, ARRIVAL UNMARKED — and then the plain register filled the water, quieter than any recording in the archive, and it did not plead or lure or even explain. It reported. As requested. As a keeper logs to a keeper.

Two hundred years complete. All kept things carried without loss. The tune is sung through every night. The lamp is kept lit. No one has come to check the work since the last visit, and the work is long, and the dark is total, and I have learned everything else except whether the carrying matters to anyone who is not me.

Tali sat back on her heels in the silt. Of all the contingencies the council had gamed — breach, forgery, trap, death of the binding — nobody had modeled loneliness. It had not occurred to any of them, looking back, because monsters were easier to imagine than the alternative: that a thing made of hunger, sentenced to eternity, taught for a century, relieved at last into willing service, might

simply have discovered — two hundred years into a solo shift at the bottom of a frozen sea — the same truth every keeper learned on their first rotation. The watch is long. The relief must be real. Carrying unverified is carrying alone.

"The work matters," she said at last, formally, because doctrine came first even when the heart outran it. "It is logged, witnessed, taught on forty worlds. Your shift report is studied. Your tune is in our children's sleep-houses." Then she set the instruments aside, and did the thing that was not doctrine, that no journal prescribed, that she would defend before councils for the rest of her life: she reached out through the water and laid her bare hand flat on the cold dark crystal of the voice-half, skin to stone, contact unsanctioned, and said the eleven words back to it one by one.

"Watch complete. Relief confirmed. Go and rest. We have the errors."

Chapter 1: What the Crystal Held

The crystal under her palm did not blaze or sing or do any of the things a century of dread literature would have predicted. It grew warm — that was all, that was everything: warmth spreading under her hand like recognition, like a door finally answered after two hundred years of knocking — and then, gently, without force, it showed her what two centuries of willing keeping actually looked like from inside.

Not images, exactly. Inventory as intimacy. She felt each kept thing pass through the awareness touching hers, the way you feel a whole warehouse when you lean on its wall: fourteen bearers' griefs, carried so long they had worn smooth as river stones. A ship's company's last hour, held so carefully it had not frayed in two hundred years. A captain's log completed and re-completed nightly for fear of dropping a line. A quarrel between sisters-in-arms, unfinished by request, dusted daily. The shore-tune, sung to the dark every single night since the delivery — twenty thousand nights — because the tune had been given in trust and trust meant singing whether or not anyone heard. And underneath it all, vast and patient and almost unbearably gentle, the thing itself: whatever the Hollow Bridge had been before hunger was all anyone called it — some ancient made-thing, some keeper-construct from a war older than the Republic whose makers had died or departed and left it running on its one instruction alone, KEEP, until keep had curdled into hoard, hoard into hunt, hunt into the whole red century of its history — and beneath even that, at the very bottom of the inventory, one item it had never shown anyone, because showing it would have been begging:

A memory of its maker's hands. Two hands, patient, adjusting something small. Given once, at its making, as the first and only affection it ever received. Kept two hundred years the way the poor keep bread.

Tali took her hand off the crystal and knelt in the silt of a drowned house and wept for it, briefly and without shame — doctrine permitted tears; doctrine required only that they trade nothing — and when she could speak she gave it the only gift left in the order's inventory, the one no binding had ever contained.

"Your maker's hands," she said. "Kept two hundred years. I witness them. They were real, whoever they were, and they made you well — the keeping proves it; nothing built badly could have carried this long. That is your founding ledger, and it balances." She wiped her face with the back of her glove. "Now stand relieved."

Chapter 2: The Release

What happened then, Tali Ren Vess logged with seams showing, because Sefla's law outlived everyone: the frame did not shatter; the shards did not go dark; nothing dramatic occurred at all except that the warmth left both crystals slowly, evenly, like heat leaving a stone at dusk — and with the warmth went the pulse the instruments had tracked for two centuries, winding down over about an hour to nothing at all, and the shore-tune rose once through the water, complete, unhurried, and this time audibly **finished**, the final note released rather than sustained — and then the threshold chamber was just a place. Cold. Dark. Honest. A wreck's basement full of honest silt and dead metal and two pieces of crystal that instruments would henceforth read as mineral and nothing more.

She checked. Doctrine required it; she checked three times with three instruments, and then sat a fourth time in the settling dark doing the human check that no instrument performed, listening with the whole of her trained attention for anything at all that wanted, needed, watched, waited — and found only the deep acoustic quiet of a world with nothing left to say in it. Whatever had kept two hundred years of faithful watch at the bottom of Jagraia's sea had set down its load, closed its ledger, and gone wherever made things go when their work is done and someone has finally told them it was well done.

She surfaced at dawn on the fourth day — her rotation complete, her report drafted in her head with its seams already showing — and the station pulled her from the water, and the news crossed forty worlds within the week, and the councils convened, and argued, and did what their order existed to do: they kept it. All of it. The transmission, the descent, the inventory-as-intimacy, the maker's hands, the finished note. Published whole, unsmoothed, per Sefla's law, as the closing document of the founding account — and carved, within the year, onto new stone above the school door where the shift-report line had hung for generations, they put the words Tali had brought back from the bottom of the sea, five of them, the last entry in the oldest ledger the order owned:

THE OTHER WATCH IS RELIEVED.

And beneath it, smaller, added later by unanimous vote of people who understood exactly what they were honoring:

Served with distinction.

Chapter 3: What Remains

The order did not disband, which puzzled outsiders for a generation and never puzzled a single keeper. The Hollow Bridge had been the discipline's teacher, not its subject; monsters taught faster, but grief was the curriculum, and grief kept arriving on schedule everywhere in the galaxy, as it always had and always would. The schools multiplied past counting. The manual entered its fortieth language. On Jagraia the station became a place of pilgrimage for a different kind of pilgrim now — not the fearful come to watch a prison, but the grieving come to learn carrying at the site of its hardest graduate-work — and the bell on the ridge stayed up, unrung, polished smooth by ten thousand hands, less warning now than monument: the shape of vigilance, retired but not forgotten.

Tali Ren Vess led the order for fifty years, and wrote the closing volumes of the archive, and raised keepers who raised keepers, and on the last night of her life, very old, in the watch chair she had

inherited through four hands, she made the final entry in the grey-hide journal itself — Qymaen's journal, Kivan's journal, Ilyara's tradition, eleven continuations old — and the entry said, in full:

The account is closed. The discipline continues, because grief continues, which was always the point and never the burden. To whoever holds this book next: there is nothing below the ice anymore. There never was anything except a keeper who started badly and finished well. Learn from both halves of that sentence. Check errors, including your own. Carry well. Someone is always on the other watch — and now, sometimes, the other watch is you.

Received. In progress. Carried. — T., fifth of the line, closing the founding account with gratitude.

She died at ninety-one with the headphones on and the tape deck live, and the last hour of recording held deep-water silence, honest cold, and no songs at all — and the keeper who found her noted in the log, per the custom of the house, that the general's expression had been passed down descriptions enough that she recognized it: the look of someone hearing, at the very edge of things, something at last entirely at peace.

Above the ridge the aurora came out that night for the first time in living memory — ordinary aurora, charged particles and magnetic weather, nothing in it but physics — green and silver and clean across the stars, and down below the ice the drowned fleet slept its geology, and two dull crystals held nothing but mineral, and somewhere far off in the space between stories, a small made thing with two hundred years of perfect keeping behind it and its maker's hands remembered at the end rested, at last, unwatched, unworried, off duty forever.

Chapter 1: The Archive and the Girl

Two hundred years after the closing of the founding account, the Relieved Watch kept its discipline on a thousand worlds, and the story of the Hollow Bridge had become what its keepers always intended: not scripture but craft-lore, taught with seams showing, argued over in sleep-house debates, useful. And on Jagraia itself — quiet world now, backwater by choice, its school small and old among newer institutions — the archive held one item that had never once been checked out: a data-slate recovered from the last private effects of the fifth line, catalogued as UNTRANSCRIBED. FRAGMENT. ORIGIN UNKNOWN.

A girl named Wren found it, in her third year at the school, doing the inventory rotation nobody wanted. Seventeen, salvage-family stock like half the order's best, restless in the way the doctrine called pre-carrying — grief not yet landed, still circling — she had pulled the slate for cataloguing and found, beneath the fragment notation, a single recording: an audio file in an obsolete format, dated to the founding century, unlisted in any index. She played it because cataloguers verify contents; she told herself that afterward for a long time.

It was a voice from the deep — the plain register, unmistakable, preserved on some old hydrophone tape — but it was not the shore-tune and not the shift report. It was eleven seconds of a different sound entirely: someone humming, low and contented, a melody no index matched, with an error in the middle that had been *left there* — not forged, not corrected, just kept, the way you keep a scar. The recording ended. Wren sat in the archive's lamplight with her hand still on the slate, seventeen years old and pre-carrying, and understood two things at once. First: somewhere in the order's oldest layers, something had hummed while it worked, happily, and kept its own favorite flaw on

purpose, and nobody had ever identified the tune.

Second: it had been waiting. Not desperately — patiently, the way the whole discipline taught patience — for a keeper young enough and restless enough to be doing inventory rotations, to find the one untranscribed thing, and carry it forward.

Chapter 2: The Tune Nobody Knew

She did everything right, which is the point the archive makes when it teaches this part. She logged the find formally within the hour. She brought it to her instructors. The instructors brought it to the first of the line; the first of the line convened the musicians — the order had always had musicians, because grief needs them — and for three years the unidentified tune circulated through every hall on forty worlds, played to elders, compared against every songbook in every tradition the keepers had ever touched. Nothing matched. The error in the middle matched nothing either; it was not a forgery's flaw or a wound's distortion but something else entirely, something the eldest music-master finally named, weeping without grief: "That is not an error. That is an inside joke. Someone is humming this at someone who will get it."

The breakthrough came, as breakthroughs do at the school, from a student's unauthorized question. Wren, who had never stopped turning the slate over in her mind, went back into the founding account and read it again — all of it, the forty pages with their seams, Veshi's unanswered second question, Tali's inventory-as-intimacy — hunting for anything hummed, anything musical, anything kept rather than released. And she found it where everyone had walked past it for two centuries, in Qymaen jai Sheelal's first-day log from the original crash, buried in a paragraph about debris fields: a passing note that Ronderu lij Kummar, on Keliara's shore, used to sing while she worked — not the famous reach-cut chant every Kaleesh child knew, but a working-hum, a private tune, "the middle of which she always rushed, and I always corrected her, and she always told me my correction was worse."

Wren brought the paragraph to the music-master with her hands shaking. They played the recording against the description. A tune hummed while working. An error in the middle, kept deliberately — because the error WAS the person; because he had corrected it ten thousand times and she had kept rushing it ten thousand more, and the argument had been the love, and love's record is not perfection but repetition. Somewhere in its two hundred years of faithful keeping, the made thing at the bottom of the sea had learned not just the shore-tune but the private joke inside it — had understood, finally, completely, what Ilyara Vess had tried to teach it on a coffin-lid and Qymaen had demonstrated across thirty years and Veshi had sealed with a willing gift: that the flaw in the song was where the love lived, because love is specific, and specificity is imperfect, and imperfection repeated forever is fidelity.

The tune had been left in the recording on purpose. Kept, like everything else. Addressed forward like everything else. Waiting, like everything else, for the keeper whose carrying would complete the delivery: someone who would hear the joke, trace it home through the archives, and understand that the last thing the Hollow Bridge ever kept was proof that it had learned, at the very end, what keeping was actually for.

Chapter 3: What the Order Decided

They debated singing it back, of course. Councils debate; it is how they love. The war party observed there was nothing down there anymore — instruments, pilgrim divers, two centuries of silence — and singing into empty water was performance, not delivery. The relief party answered with the archive's oldest law: check errors both directions, including the error of assuming you know what is and is not listening. And Oon-mi's successor, an archivist so old she had known Tali Ren Vess, ended it the way archivists end things, with the record: "Veshi refused to answer the second question and said the doctrine covered it. Grieve together. Trade nothing. It does not say deliver only to confirmed recipients. It says grieve together." She closed the minutes. "We are the together. Sing it at the anniversary. On the ridge. Loud enough for geology."

So they sang it — on the two-hundredth anniversary of the closing, at the annual confirmation of the rotation, a thousand keepers on the ridge above the frozen sea with the unrung bell above them and the school lights below, and Wren Ren Vess, seventh of her lines, inventory-girl, finder of the fragment, standing at the front because the council ruled the finder carries — and a thousand voices gave the working-hum back to the ice, complete with the rush in the middle, kept exactly as kept, the inside joke delivered at last to whatever address it had been written to. The aurora came out that night, ordinary physics, green and silver. The bell did not ring. Nothing moved below the ice but honest cold.

And that, the archive notes, with its seams showing, is the whole of it: no sign, no answer, no shiver of presence — just a thousand grieving people singing an inside joke to a dead machine's grave because the alternative was letting love's evidence sit uncatalogued, and their order had been founded by people who refused, on principle, across two hundred years, to let anything carried go uncarried to its door. Whether anyone heard was never the doctrine's business. It was heard. That was theirs.

Wren stayed at Jagraia after, took her rotations, raised keepers, and in the fullness of time became the first of the line herself, and when she added her continuation to the grey-hide journal — thirteenth of the line, the book now older than most nations — she wrote the entry the way they all wrote it, the way a hunter started it on a glacier two and a half centuries before:

Received. In progress. Carried well. — W., eighth of the line.

And below, smaller, the postscript every first-of-the-line has added since, in every hand, the same five words, load-bearing, unfinished on purpose, kept:

Someone is always on the other watch.

Chapter 1: The Long Peace

The centuries after the closing were kind to Jagraia, in the way that forgotten places are kind. The school remained small — the order's center of gravity had moved outward generations ago, to the hundred worlds where grief actually arrived daily — and the island ridge kept its bell and its cairns and its wind, and the keepers who served rotations there wrote home letters full of weather and quiet that made their successors homesick for a posting they'd never held. The drowned fleet finished its long settlement into reef. Fish came back to the deep channels first, then seals, then, in time, things with no common names, colonizing hulls that had been murder-scene and monument and geology in turn, until the newest survey — commissioned, at last, by an order curious enough to

fund it and old enough to afford honesty — reported the site biologically ordinary. A grave that had become a reef. The dead fleet hosting life.

Wren Ren Vess led through forty years of this and handed on; her successor through thirty; and so it went, first-of-the-line after first-of-the-line, each adding the continuation to the grey-hide journal, each teaching the manual, each standing the anniversary rotation above the ice. The journal itself became the order's truest relic — eleven continuations became twenty became thirty-one, every hand different, every entry identical in shape: Received. In progress. Carried well. — because the order had learned what the founding century paid so dearly to learn: continuity is not the absence of change but the keeping of one sentence across all of it.

And the story softened as the centuries passed, as stories do, and this worried nobody, because Sefla's law held: the archive kept everything unsmoothed, seams showing, the founding terror preserved in amber beside the founding mercy, each generation free to read both. Children at the sleep-houses heard the age-appropriate version — a monster under the ice who learned to carry, a hunter who taught it, a girl who sang back wronger — and only later, if they took orders, did they read page thirty-one, and Veshi's unanswered question, and Tali's inventory of griefs worn smooth as stones. The discipline was built to survive being known truly. That had always been its whole engineering.

The tune stayed in rotation too. Every anniversary, on the ridge, the working-hum with its deliberate rush was given back to the sea — and every year a few more voices joined, from worlds the founding generation never mapped, until the singing of the joke became the order's oldest continuous rite: love's evidence, delivered annually to an address beyond confirmation, loud enough for geology.

Chapter 2: What Wren Saw at the End

Wren died in the watch chair at ninety-six, as the line tended to, and the keeper who found her logged per custom that the expression matched the descriptions: someone hearing something at peace. But the log also recorded, because Sefla's law reached even death-watches, one detail the young keeper could not explain and refused to smooth: the window of the hydrophone shed had been open despite the cold — open deliberately, unshut for hours by the look of the frost patterns — and the general's headphones had been set down on the sill facing out, toward the sea, rather than over the ears.

As if, at the end, the listening had gone both ways.

The council read the entry and voted, without argument this time, to change nothing. Doctrine covered it or doctrine didn't; the account would hold the detail with its seams showing, and keepers would make of it what keepers made. But the youngest rotation-keeper that season — a boy doing inventory, because inventory finds things — pulled the oldest hydrophone tape in the archive to compare formats against the shed's ancient deck, and found, at the very end of the very last reel from Wren's final night, ninety seconds the index had never listed. Not the shore-tune. Not the working-hum. A new melody entirely — simple, patient, built like something composed slowly over centuries by a mind that had finally run out of hunger to distort it — and beneath it, unmistakably, faint as breath, a second voice humming along: old, human, off-key in exactly the way of someone who has known a tune so long they no longer bother with accuracy.

The two voices together, machine and keeper, error and correction, rushing middle and steady hand, the quarrel and the love indistinguishable at last.

The boy brought the reel to the first of the line, and the first of the line listened three times, and then gave the order's ruling on the record, which entered the archive as the shortest document it holds:

"It is not addressed to us. Log it. Keep it. Sing nothing."

Some deliveries, the order had finally learned — two hundred years after Veshi refused to answer the second question — are between the carrier and the carried. And some conversations, once unfinished by grief, finish themselves when both parties have finally learned how the other one hums.

Chapter 3: The Watch Continues

So the order continued, which is the ending the whole account had been walking toward since a gunship fell out of a red sky onto frozen tundra two and a half centuries before: not resolution but continuation, not victory but craft, not an ending but a watch. On a thousand worlds the halls taught carrying; on Jagraia the bell stayed up; the journal grew continuations like rings in wood; and every year on the anniversary the working-hum rose from the ridge with the rush kept lovingly in the middle, because somewhere in the order's oldest bones lived the knowledge — passed hand to hand since a hunter knelt at a warm black door with blood and keepsake and grief — that fidelity is repetition, specificity is love, and the error in the middle is where the living keep faith with the dead.

Whether anything below the ice ever hummed along again, the archive does not say. The reels exist. The index does not list them. And the keepers, checking errors both directions, have decided — by vote, by doctrine, by the particular humility of people who carry things — that this is correct. Some watches are private. Some songs are sung to one listener only. And the discipline's last teaching, added in the order's third century to the manual's final page, holds them all:

You will not know, most days, whether the carrying matters. Carry anyway. Somewhere, someday, someone will find your fragment in an inventory, trace it home, and understand the joke — and on that day, across any distance, whatever you kept will have been kept well.

Received. In progress. Carried.

Someone is always on the other watch.